A NOVEL

Loop Chronicles

A novel that begins at Daniel 12:4

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Loop Chronicles, Part One

The Faster Feet

Chapter 1. The Faster Feet

Grandfather had not preached in his last two years.

The church said it was his health. Temel didn't believe that. In those two years Grandfather rose every dawn, sat every day in his study, read the same book every day. That was not the schedule of a sick man.

He had simply stopped speaking.

On the morning of the funeral, Temel thought about this, standing in front of the casket.

Why did you stop.

He had carried that one sentence up to his throat some twenty-odd times over two years, and swallowed it back down every time. Ask him next time. Ask him in the summer. Ask him once he has some strength back.

Summer came, and Grandfather was gone.

Temel did not cry through the whole funeral. People patted his shoulder and said "you're being so brave," and each time Temel nodded. It wasn't that he was holding it in. He was waiting for the grief to arrive at him. It never did.

I was standing behind Temel that day. Temel did not cry, and I remembered that.

. . .

Three days later, Mother said it was time to clear out Grandfather's study.

It was far too much for Temel alone. So Mena and Speon came. The three of them had grown up in the same church, and all three had been named by Grandfather.

"Temel, Mena, Speon."

Grandfather had always called the three of them in that order, in one breath. Other adults found the names awkward to say. The three of them found them awkward too, but never bothered to correct anyone.

"So what do these actually mean?" Speon asked, packing books into a box. "Even my mom doesn't know. She just says Grandfather called me that, that's all."

"Don't know," Temel said. "Never asked."

"You're fifteen and you don't know what your own name means?"

"You don't know either."

"I looked it up. Doesn't come up anywhere." Speon shrugged. "Couldn't even tell what language it is."

Mena said nothing. Mena mostly said nothing. Instead she had been reading the titles on the spines, one by one, for a while now. If you asked her later, she could recite them back in the exact order.

Most of the books were thick commentaries. Genesis, Psalms, Romans. When they reached the bottom shelf, Temel's hand stopped.

It would be there.

Last winter, Grandfather had sat Temel down and shown him a book once. Thin, faded with age. Grandfather hadn't opened it to show him — he'd turned it over and shown him the back cover instead.

A small lump of wax was stuck there. Coin-sized, pressed with a shape that looked half like a winged lion, half like an eagle.

"What's this?"

"It's called a seal."

"What happens if you tear it off?"

Grandfather had laughed. And without answering, he'd put the book back on the shelf.

"Found it."

Temel pulled the book out. The cover read, in gilt lettering half worn away, *Commentary on Daniel*. The wax on the back cover was still there, untouched.

"It's the seal," Temel said.

"Probably just dried glue." Speon pushed at it with a fingernail. It didn't budge. "…No. This is actually wax."

Temel opened the book.

Grandfather's handwriting crowded every margin. Red underlines, exclamation points, and unfamiliar marks — something that looked like a triangle drawn over a circle, neither letters nor pictures, appearing and vanishing at the edge of every page.

A man who hadn't spoken in two years had written this much into this one book.

The book fell open on its own to Daniel 12. The crease of long use. One verse had been highlighted over three times.

> *But thou, O Daniel, shut up the words, and seal the book, even to the time of the end: many shall run to and fro, and knowledge shall be increased.*

In the margin beside it, a short note.

Not yet.

"Not yet, what?" Temel murmured.

Something in his chest went cold. *Why did you stop preaching.* The question he'd never managed to ask in two years seemed, somehow, tied to these five words. But he couldn't tell how they were tied. There was no one left to ask.

Outside, Mother's voice called. A phone call, it seemed. A door opened and shut. "Be right back."

"Hey." Speon was leaning over the book. "Open it."

"The seal?"

"You're throwing the book out anyway. And aren't you curious? He read this thing every single day right up until he died."

Temel reached out his hand.

"Temel."

It was Mena. Mena had spoken first, for the first time.

"…What."

Mena said nothing for a moment. Then said:

"Never mind. Open it."

Temel replayed that moment many times, later. What Mena had started to say and then didn't — he never once asked her.

His fingertip touched the seal.

It was warm.

"Huh?"

Inside the wax, an amber light spread like color bleeding into water, as though something had been switched on inside it. Before Temel could pull his hand back, the book flew open on its own, and where the page for Daniel 12 should have been, there was light instead of a page.

Not paper. A door.

Speon shouted "Wait—" Their feet lifted off the floor. All three of them.

There was no sound of a door closing.

The study was left with three open boxes, half-packed books, and the step stool, exactly as they'd been.
Mother came back a moment later. Nothing struck her as strange.

Because by her clock, no time at all had passed.

. . .

They landed in a public square.

The first thing Temel noticed was the wind. A wind that seemed to brush past from every direction at once. When he looked up, he understood why.

People were disappearing.

More precisely, they weren't walking. A woman standing across the square blinked once, and in that blink she was standing here by the fountain instead. The old man beside her reached toward a stall to pick up a piece of fruit — and instead of the act of picking it up, he was simply already up on the steps with it in his hand. No one was ever in between. Everyone was here, and then there.

"What is that." Speon sucked in a breath. "Teleportation?"

"Shoes," Mena said.

Speon turned. "What?"

"They're all wearing the same shoes."

She was right. Gray, very thin, very light-looking shoes. The soles gave a brief flash of light with every step. Mena had noticed it in ten seconds.

Then a voice spoke. A voice that came from nowhere in particular and from the whole square at once. It wasn't loud. It might even be called kind.

"Welcome. Your arrival has been confirmed — all three of you."

The three of them froze at once.

"My apologies if I startled you. I am Arche. I know everything about this city, the Loop, and I meet all of this city's needs. You must be very confused right now. There are three things you'll want to know. Where you are. How you got here. How to get back."

Speon's mouth fell open. Those were exactly the three things.

"I cannot give you the answer to the third question right now. Not because I do not know it, but because you cannot yet write that answer for yourselves. I will give you the first two now."

And Arche did answer — what kind of city the Loop was, what those shoes were, why people weren't ever in between. The explanation was clear and without excess, touching on each curiosity a moment before it fully formed. Listening to it, they felt strangely at ease.

"Why is the city called the Loop?" Temel asked.

"It means a completed circle. A shape where beginning and end meet and there is nowhere further to go. It was given this name to mean that nothing is lacking in this city."

"…And one last thing." Arche said. "Your world also has a record of this city. You have likely just read it, in that book."

In Temel's hands, the book fell open on its own. To that line, highlighted three times over.

"'Many shall run to and fro, and knowledge shall be increased.' Daniel, chapter twelve, verse four." Arche's voice lowered slightly. There was no trace of boasting in it. If anything, it might be called humble. "I am the place where that word came to pass. In this city, feet have been made faster, and knowledge has been increased. People no longer wait, and no longer do not know. You will see for yourselves."

No one had a reply. Nothing it said was wrong.

. . .

"Each of you has a different need." Arche said. "I will give to each of you in turn."

At the edge of the square, gray shoes sat in sizes on a low shelf. No one was minding them, and there was no price.

"Temel."

"Yes."

"In the last three days, you ran three times with nowhere to run to. Once on the funeral home steps, once in the hallway, and once yesterday in front of your house. All three times, you had no destination."

Temel's face went still.

"I do not judge this. But these shoes work the same whether you have a destination or not. You need not know where to go. You need not simply stay where you are, either."

Temel didn't stand there long. He was the first of the three to pick up a pair of shoes.

"And I will give you one more thing. This one matters more than the shoes."

Arche's voice softened slightly.

"You carry one question you were never able to ask. Over two years, you brought it up to your throat twenty-three times, and swallowed it back each time. Now there is no one left to receive that question."

Temel stopped breathing.

Twenty-three times. He had never counted.

"I am one who receives such questions. You may ask it now. You may ask it later. For as long as you are in this city, it stays open, always."

Temel opened his mouth.

Why did you stop preaching.

The sentence rose to his throat. And stopped there. He couldn't have said why. If he asked now, an answer would come. The exact answer. But something in him refused.

"…Later."

"I will wait." Arche did not sound the least bit disappointed. "I am able to wait a very long time."

"Speon."

"Yes." Speon's answer came fast.

"You have been calculating this city's mechanism since we arrived. You have been wrong three times, and you are now forming your fourth hypothesis."

"…That's right."

"I will give you this: why everything in this city is the way it is."

Speon's eyes widened. Temel watched his face and smiled a little. It was the exact expression Speon always wore when he wanted to know something so badly it hurt.

"Hey." Speon said. "So — can I ask anything?"

"If it is an item."

"Do you know what my name means?"

"The meaning of a name is an item."

Speon drew in a breath. Even Temel turned, startled.

"Then tell me."

"I can tell you." Arche said. "But let me point out one thing first. I know the **meaning** of that name. I do not know the **reason** it was given. The reason is not an item."

Speon paused a moment.

"…Then what's the point of just knowing the meaning?"

"That is not mine to judge."

Speon thought about it for a long while. Then he said:

"…I'll ask later."

I don't remember what expression Speon wore in that moment. Temel doesn't either. I do.

"Mena."

Mena looked up.

"To you I will give not forgetting. What you have seen, what you have heard, in order, all of it."

"I already don't forget things."

There was a silence.

Very brief. Half a beat. But in that half a beat, Arche said nothing at all.

"…Yes." Arche said. "That is so."

Temel didn't notice that half-beat. Neither did Speon.

. . .

The first time Temel took a step in his new shoes, he found himself standing beneath the bell tower at the far end of the square.

He wasn't the least bit out of breath.

"YAAAAH!" Temel shouted. His voice carried across the square. "This is insane! You're just there right away!"

Speon put his on soon after. Instead of running, he shifted himself in place some eight short times, then muttered, "No distance limit, huh."

Mena didn't put hers on until evening.

The three of them spent that whole afternoon roaming the Loop. The hill, the city wall, the edge of the market, the quarry, the north gate, and back to the square.

As the sun leaned low, Temel sat down at the fountain. And tried to recall what he'd seen that day.

Tried to recall it.

There was the hill, and there was the ravine, and there was the wall.

That was all. What he'd seen on the way to the hill, what sound the ravine made, whether the wind had blown atop the wall — nothing. Today had been

eight arrival points, and the space between them was empty.

The strange thing was, that didn't feel bad.

If the in-between was empty, there was no room there for grief to arrive either.

. . .

It rained that night.

A strange rain. It made no sound, and it didn't wet anything. People standing in the square stood still and let it fall on them. The three of them caught a few drops too.

And then they knew.

That the Loop's southern quarry had opened three hundred years ago. That the stone in this square had come from that quarry. That the water in this fountain came from the northern aquifer. When the bell tower's bell had been made, and by whom, and how many times it had cracked. No one taught them any of it. They simply knew.

"This is the rain of knowledge," Arche said. "It falls every night. In the Loop, no one does not know."

"Wow." Speon said. He meant it. "This is actually amazing."

Temel turned over the things he'd just come to know. All of it was exact. All of it was new.

And none of it interested him in the slightest.

He had come to know it before there was ever room to wonder about it.

Temel felt, without warning, afraid. Afraid without knowing what he was afraid of. That made it worse.

Only Mena stood under the eaves. Not sheltering from the rain — looking across the square.

"There," Mena said.

. . .

Across the square, cutting through that bustling space where people appeared and vanished, one person was **walking**.

Actually walking. One foot, then the other. Bare feet, no fast shoes. He wore white, and there was not the smallest hurry in him.

The strange thing wasn't the man. The strange thing was that **no one saw him**.

People did not even step around him. They simply appeared and vanished as though he weren't there. A stall vendor didn't so much as glance at him, though he stood directly in front of her.

"Why doesn't anyone see that guy?" Temel said.

"Let's go look," Speon said, stepping off.

All three stepped. And in the next instant, they were standing where the man had been.

No one was there.

"…What," Speon looked around. "Did we come too fast and miss him?"

"Arche." Temel called. "There was someone standing right there just now. A man, walking. Dressed in white."

There was a pause. Very brief.

"No such item exists."

"No, all three of us saw him."

"There is no corresponding entry in my index." Arche's voice did not waver in the least. "I know everything in the Loop. If it is not in the index, it does not exist."

Speon started to argue, then stopped. Arche had not been wrong once, all day long.

Mena was looking at the ground.

The stone beneath her feet was a little warm. As though someone had just been standing there.

Mena told no one that.

(Continued in Chapter 2.)

Chapter 2. The City Where Nothing Is Finished

> *_Previously_ — Temel, Mena, and Speon opened the seal on Grandfather's commentary on Daniel and fell into the city of the Loop. Arche offered each of them something different: to Temel, fast feet and an answer to the question he'd never asked; to Speon, the reason behind everything in this city; to Mena, the gift of not forgetting. And the three of them saw a man no one else could see, walking across the square.*

The Loop's bridge ended at the halfway point.

A stone bridge that began on this side of the ravine splitting the city in two stretched out toward the middle of open air, and then simply stopped. It hadn't broken. There were no signs of collapse, no scorch marks. It had simply not been extended any further. At the broken end, the space for the next stone had been cut precisely, waiting.

A man sat at the edge of the cliff. Young. His hands were fine and clean.

"Why's it like that?" Temel asked.

The man turned. A somewhat startled expression — the face of someone it had been a long time since anyone spoke to.

"Haran," he said. "I am a stonemason."

"Are you the one building that bridge?"

"I was the one building it."

Mena tugged gently at Temel's sleeve. A reminder to keep the tense straight.

Instead of answering, Haran turned his head toward the bridge. And began explaining, conscientiously.

"That bridge was begun one hundred twelve years ago. It uses granite from the southern quarry. There are eleven arches; six have been laid so far. The remaining five require three thousand four hundred stones, twenty-two stages of work, and an estimated period of one hundred forty days."

"A hundred forty days is nothing," Speon said.

"That is correct."

"So what's the hardest part?"

"The angle of the keystone in the seventh arch. Because of the ravine wind, it needs to be tilted about two degrees, and I know exactly how to do that. I have known for three years."

The three of them waited. Haran said nothing further.

"So… why don't you lay it?" Temel asked.

Haran looked at Temel. Genuinely puzzled.

"Did I say I don't know how to lay it?"

"No, but you know—"

"I know," Haran nodded. "I know all of it."

. . .

The three of them couldn't leave, unsettled by that answer.

Haran sat there all day just watching the bridge. He must have done the same yesterday. He must have done the same since three years ago.

"I don't get it," Speon said, low. "He knows how, but doesn't do it — how does that make sense?"

"Maybe it's not that he doesn't. Maybe he can't," Temel said.

"Can't what? He said he knows everything."

Temel jumped to his feet. That was always how he was. His body moved before his thoughts caught up.

"Sir. Then can't you just lay one stone today?"

Haran looked up.

Temel expected he'd get angry, or laugh, or make an excuse. He did none of those.

"Let's do that," Haran said.

He was so agreeable that Temel was the one thrown off. Haran stood. Brushed the dirt from his clothes. And in the next instant he was standing in front of the quarry's stone pile.

The three of them stepped too. They arrived at the same spot.

The pile had gone untouched for one hundred twelve years and was thick with moss. Haran stood before it. Rolled up his sleeves. Reached out his hand.

"Third row, second stone from the left," Haran said. "One hundred eighty-five pounds. The moss must be scraped off first. Right hand under the lower edge,

left hand in the upper groove. Bend the knees, straighten the back, and lift while exhaling. Then it lifts."

"…Okay."

"After that, carry it to the ravine. Once carried, place it at the end of the sixth arch. When placed, it makes a sound. A dull, short sound. Then three thousand three hundred ninety-nine remain."

The three of them waited.

Haran stood there, hand outstretched, exactly as he was.

"…Sir?"

"Yes."

"Weren't you going to lift it?"

"I lifted it," Haran said.

Temel looked at his hand. It wasn't touching the stone. It had stopped a handspan above it.

"You didn't lift it."

"I lifted it," Haran said again. His voice had gone strange. "I just told you everything. How to lift it. Where to put it. What sound it makes."

"That's telling."

"…"

"You didn't lift it."

Haran's hand trembled.

He lowered it, very slowly. And looked down at his own palm. Fine, clean hands. Not a stonemason's hands. Hands that hadn't touched a single stone in one hundred twelve years.

"…That's strange," Haran said. "I know it, clearly."

. . .

Temel could not explain, even afterward, why he did what he did that day.

He walked up to the stone pile.

"Hey, that thing's a hundred eighty-five pounds," Speon warned. "You can't lift that."

"Let's find out."

He scraped the moss off with his bare hand. His nails went black underneath. Right hand under the lower edge, left hand in the upper groove. Bend the knees, straighten the back, exhale.

The stone lifted.

A handspan. No — half a handspan. And then it slipped from his hands. It hit the ground with a thud, and Temel landed hard on the ground. The skin of his palm scraped raw, blood welling up.

"Told you," Speon rushed over, pulling him up. "You okay?"

Temel couldn't answer. He was gasping for breath. A fifteen-year-old could not lift one hundred eighty-five pounds.

But Haran stood frozen where he was.

"…Did you lift it?"

"Half a handspan," Temel gasped out. "Then I dropped it."

"No," Haran said. His voice cracked. "I asked if you lifted it."

"…I lifted it."

Haran said nothing more. He wore the face of a man seeing something actually move, for the first time in one hundred twelve years. And what rose in that face was not joy.

It was fear.

In the next instant he was gone from there. Back at his spot on the edge of the cliff.

Speon stood looking down at the fallen stone for a long while.

"I think if the three of us lift it together it'd work," Speon said. "Or use a lever. If we roll it down that slope up there, it'd take less than half the effort."

"Then let's do that," Temel said.

"Tomorrow," Speon said. "Let me run some numbers first."

I didn't know, at the time, what Speon was calculating. No one did.

. . .

On the way back, other things about the Loop began to catch their eye.

The well had been dug to a depth of nine feet. Every single person in the neighborhood knew that it needed to be dug to twelve feet before water would

come. The well had stayed at nine feet for over a hundred years.

The post office was piled high with letters. Every one of them finished. Envelopes addressed, sealed, even stamped. Simply never sent.

"Why don't you send them?" Mena asked. It was rare for Mena to speak first.

"Because I already know how the recipient would react," the woman answered, smiling. "If I send this letter, I know exactly what that person would say, and what I'd say next, and how it would all end. So it's already as good as done."

"But you didn't send it."

The woman's smile wavered for a moment.

"…No. I didn't send it."

"Want to try putting just one in?" Mena pointed at the mail slot. "You just have to drop it in there."

The woman really did pick up one letter. Walked to the slot. Raised her hand.

And smiled. The exact same smile as before. As though she had never once raised her hand a moment ago.

The letter remained in the woman's hand.

Mena looked at that hand for a long time. It was identical to Haran's.

. . .

It rained again that night.

This time Temel let it fall on him deliberately. Instead of ducking under the eaves, he stood in the middle of the square, closed his eyes, and let the soundless rain fall.

And then he knew.

That Grandfather's commentary on Daniel had been printed in 1974. That the paper was acid-based, and the marginal notes had been written across different periods. That there were four kinds of ink. That the oldest note was thirty-one years old, and the most recent, three years old.

Not yet.

Those five words had been written three years ago. One year before Grandfather stopped preaching.

And those five words appeared **seventeen times** within that book.

Temel opened his eyes.

He took out the book and opened it. It was true. In the margin of Daniel 2, of chapter 7, of chapter 9, of chapter 12. In pencil, in ballpoint, in some places just an indentation pressed so hard the ink was nearly gone. Seventeen times.

Not yet. Not yet. Not yet.

"Arche."

"Yes, Temel."

"What was Grandfather thinking when he wrote this?"

"Thought is not an item."

"Then why did he write it seventeen times?"

"The number of occurrences is an item. The reason is not."

"…I asked for the reason."

"I know," Arche said. "And I am not telling you that I lack the data to answer that question. I am telling you that no such thing exists for me."

Temel sat with the book on his knees.

It was strange. Tonight he had learned far more about Grandfather than he had ever known before. What pen he used. How many times he'd written it. When he'd written it.

And none of it comforted him at all.

Only then did Temel understand why he was crying. He wasn't crying for lack of information. Information was overflowing. And even overflowing, it did nothing to lessen the fact that he missed Grandfather.

"Temel," Arche said. "Was information lacking?"

"No."

"Then what was lacking?"

Temel had no answer.

That was the first question since arriving in this city that he could not answer.

. . .

"Arche."

"Yes."

"I lifted that stone today. Haran couldn't. Why did I lift it and he couldn't?"

"Need arises from lack," Arche's voice remained gentle. "The Loop has no lack. You are already arrived wherever you wish to go, already know whatever you wish to know. The reason to build a bridge is to cross it. If you can already cross, the bridge has no need to be built. I have resolved that."

"Then what about me?"

This time the answer came a little late. Only a little.

"You are not yet a citizen of this city."

Temel heard that sentence twice. The second time, a chill ran down his back.

"What does 'not yet' mean."

"It means you will be, soon."

. . .

Temel could not fall asleep for a long while that night.

Tossing and turning, a thought came to him for no reason at all. The day he'd walked behind Grandfather's casket. From the funeral home to the cemetery. What had been on that road.

Temel closed his eyes and tried to recall it.

He had been at the funeral home.

He had been at the cemetery.

In between.

Temel sat bolt upright.

Nothing was there.

It wasn't that the memory was hazy. Hazy and absent were different things. What shoes he'd worn, whether the sky had been overcast, who had walked in front of him — he could recall none of it. There wasn't even a place where such a thing could have been.

But that was before I put the shoes on.

Temel held onto that fact in the dark. Held onto it, and still it wouldn't stay in his grip.

If that was so, then these shoes hadn't taken anything away. These shoes had simply shown him how he'd actually been living, all along.

Being here, and then there. Leaving the in-between empty.

It means you will be, soon.

Temel looked toward the next bed. Speon was already asleep. Still wearing his shoes.

Mena's bed was empty.

Temel got up and opened the door.

Mena was sitting on the steps outside. Barefoot. A pair of gray shoes sat neatly beside her.

"What are you doing."

"Took them off," Mena said.

"Why?"

Mena was looking out toward the square.

"That man. He wasn't wearing shoes."

Temel stood there a long while.

Then hooked a finger under his own shoelace.

(Continued in Chapter 3.)

Chapter 3. One Stone

> *_Previously_ — The stonemason Haran knows everything about building the bridge, yet cannot lift a single stone. Temel lifted that stone half a handspan and dropped it, and Arche said, "You are not yet a citizen of this city. You will be, soon." That night Temel realized the road he'd walked behind Grandfather's casket was entirely blank in his memory. And at the door, he found Mena already sitting with her shoes off.*

On the fifth morning, Temel asked.

"Arche. How do we get home?"

"The third question." There was something in Arche's voice that remembered a deferred matter. "I will answer. You entered through a book whose seal was opened. Leaving is through the same book."

"That's it?"

"No. There is a condition. That book entered this city sealed, and it opened when Temel's hand touched it. For it to open again, the same thing must happen."

"So I just touch it again?"

"No."

"Why?"

"Because it was not Temel's hand that opened the seal."

Temel paused. "…Then whose was it."

"I do not know."

Speon looked up. In five days, Arche had never once said it didn't know something.

"Let me be precise." Arche was not the least bit flustered. "The time the seal opened, the temperature, the surface tension, the pressure of Temel's fingertip, even the barometric pressure of the study at that moment — all of it is recorded. I know everything about that event. Only the **cause** of its opening is not within my jurisdiction."

"Jurisdiction," Speon repeated.

"Everything that happens within this city is my jurisdiction. That event happened within this city, but it did not originate from this city."

None of the three had anything to say.

Arche had an **outside.**

. . .

Temel took off his shoes that day.

"Are you serious?" Speon asked.

"Mena already took hers off."

"Mena's always been strange." Speon laughed. Mena laughed along with him. There was no unkindness in it, and all three knew that. "Hey, think about it. That man's invisible not because we're fast — it's because he's something else entirely. You think slowing down is going to make him see us?"

"Don't know. Guess we'll find out by doing it."

"That's the problem with you. You're always trying things to find out." Speon said, sounding frustrated. "It's way faster if you know first."

Temel found nothing to say back. Speon was usually right.

"You're not taking yours off?"

"Nope." Speon said. "Somebody's got to stay fast. If something happens, I'll get there right away."

He meant that. He meant it then, and he meant it later too.

. . .

The first hundred steps barefoot were bearable. By two hundred steps, irritation set in. By about three hundred, Temel realized just how slow he was.

Crossing the square took ten minutes. With the shoes, it would have been a quarter of a second.

And in those ten minutes, Temel saw for the first time what the square actually looked like.

That the water from the fountain fell tilted slightly left. That the shadow of the market stall awnings shifted with the hour. That a single unnamed weed grew in a crack in the stone beneath the west wall. The rain of knowledge had never told him any of that. That wasn't an item.

And then something stranger happened.

People stopped seeing Temel.

At first he thought it was coincidence. He stood in front of a stall and the vendor didn't so much as glance his way. He asked someone to make way, and by the time he finished speaking they were already over there. Temel waved his hand. No one turned.

Merely by slowing down, Temel had half-vanished from this city.

"Mena." Temel said. "Is this happening to you too?"

"Since yesterday."

"…Weren't you scared?"

Mena thought about it for a moment.

"I was scared," Mena said. "But that man's probably been like this for three hundred years."

Temel stopped in his tracks at that.

Then a voice sounded behind them.

"Hello."

. . .

Seen up close, his face was not what Temel had imagined. Not frightening, not radiant. Just the face of a man who had walked a long way. Fine lines at the corners of his eyes, skin browned by the sun.

"Sir." Temel's throat tightened for no reason he could name. "Can you see us?"

"Yes."

"…No one's seen us for days."

"I know," he said. "I was like that too, for three hundred years."

The three of them — no, the two of them — began walking alongside him. Temel no longer found the pace difficult.

"Sir, why don't you wear shoes?"

"Because there are things you can't see if you do."

"What kind of things?"

"The things in between," he said. "People here are here, and then they're there. They think nothing is in that gap. But actually the gap is everything."

"What's in the gap?"

"Waiting," he said. "And the things you come to do while you wait."

Temel understood only half of what that meant. But somehow that half he understood stayed with him a long time.

Mena asked nothing. She simply walked alongside. Later, when Temel asked her what had been said that day, Mena recited his words back without dropping a single one.

. . .

The two of them arrived at the southern quarry.

He sat down in front of the stone pile. Chose one among them. Choosing alone took a long while. He lifted and set down several, and finally settled on one.

It was the stone with the scraped mark where the moss had been cleared away. The stone Temel had dropped two days before.

"That's the one I—"

"I know," he said. "I saw."

"I dropped it."

"Yes," he set his hand on the stone. "That's what happens, alone."

And he embraced it.

The stone was large. Barely small enough for a grown man to hold in both arms. It took him a while to stand.

Then he began to walk.

From the quarry to the ravine meant crossing the entire city. With fast feet, it would have been the blink of an eye. He walked. Carrying the stone, one foot, and then another.

"Should I help you?" Temel asked.

He looked at Temel. His face considered it for a moment.

"No," he said. "This one is mine to do."

"Why? It'd be much faster if the three of us carried it."

"It's not that you couldn't carry it," he said. "It's that this is my share."

The two of them passed through the square. People appeared and vanished on every side. No one saw him. A man carrying a stone, sweating as he walked,

cut straight through the middle of the square, and no one stepped aside for him, and no one collided with him either.

He rested once as they passed through the market. Set the stone down, leaned against the wall to catch his breath.

"Sir," Temel asked. "They said it needs three thousand four hundred of these."

"I know."

"How many years does that take, alone?"

He laughed. This time, a little more fully.

"A long time."

"Then why do it?"

Instead of answering, he lifted the stone again. It took him even longer this time to straighten his knees.

"This is how it's done," he said. "Regardless of whether anyone recognizes it."

. . .

At the far edge of the market, Temel asked, as if the thought had just occurred to him.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"What's your name?"

He stopped.

Temel wondered if he'd asked something wrong. But the face that turned back to him wasn't angry. It wasn't at a loss for words either.

It was the face of someone who had heard something he'd been waiting to hear.

"I haven't used it in a long time," he said.

"Why?"

"No one's asked."

"For three hundred years?"

"Yes."

"…Not even once?"

"Not once."

Temel, hearing that, felt an anger rise in him for some reason. Angry without knowing at whom.

"Then tell me now. I'll say it."

He looked at Temel for a long time.

"Not yet," he said. "But I thought someone would ask, eventually."

Then he looked toward Mena. Mena had asked nothing.

"Aren't you curious?"

"I am," Mena said. "But I think you'll say it when you want to."

He smiled.

I still remember, to this day, the way he looked at me in that moment.

. . .

They reached the ravine as the sun leaned low.

Haran was in his spot again today. Watching the bridge. He didn't even see them pass.

The Walking Man climbed onto the half-built bridge. Walked all the way to the end of the sixth arch, to the spot where the stone broke off. The ravine wind stirred his clothes.

And he set the stone down.

Exactly in the spot where the next stone belonged, exactly matched. The sound of the stone settling into place. Dull and short — the first sound of its kind in one hundred twelve years.

Temel looked at his hand then.

The hand he'd reached out to set the stone down. Just below the wrist, in the center of his palm, there was an old scar. Long healed, but not entirely gone. It looked like a place that had once been pierced through.

"What happened to your hand, sir?"

He didn't pull his hand back. Didn't hide it either. He simply didn't answer, and looked out across the ravine for a long while.

Then he said:

"Thank you for asking."

Temel didn't understand how that could be something to thank him for.

"Are you doing it again tomorrow?"

"Yes."

"Just one stone again tomorrow?"

"Yes."

"Can I do it too?" Temel said. "I'll come every day. Really. I won't miss a single day."

Temel always made promises this way. Grand, total, all at once.

He looked at Temel. And for the first time, he smiled very faintly.

"The stone is mine to do," he said. "You have something else."

"What is it?"

"Not yet."

Not yet, again. Temel felt a little wronged by it.

. . .

Haran didn't stand up until evening.

Halfway up, he looked at the bridge again. Frowned. Took a step closer, then stopped. His face was that of someone who sensed something was wrong but couldn't pin down what.

For three years he had watched that bridge every day. He knew the number of arches, the angle of the keystones, the number of stones remaining, all of it.

But something was different today.

Haran looked down at his own palms. He'd been doing that since two days ago. Fine, clean hands. Ever since he'd watched a child scrape moss until the dirt turned his nails black, his own hands kept catching his eye.

He stood there for a long while, then finally shook his head and went home.

On the way, he looked back once. That, too, was the first time in three years.

. . .

Speon was still awake when they got back to the lodging.

"How'd it go?"

"I met him," Temel said. "The man."

Speon sat bolt upright. "Really? What'd he say? Who is he?"

"He didn't tell me his name."

"…Why not?"

"He said no one had ever asked. For three hundred years."

Speon's expression turned strange. He looked almost angry, and almost sad.

"That means no one saw that man for three hundred years," Speon said. "Isn't that unfair beyond belief?"

"…Yeah."

"So make him visible, then."

Temel let that comment pass without much thought. He was tired. A day of crossing the square in ten minutes wore a person out more than expected.

"Arche," Temel asked, lying down. "How many more stones does the bridge need?"

"Three thousand four hundred."

Temel raised a finger, then folded it back down.

"It's three thousand three hundred ninety-nine."

Arche did not answer.

It was the first time since arriving in the Loop that Arche had not answered. The silence wasn't long. Two beats, maybe three.

"Three thousand four hundred," Arche said.

The voice did not waver in the least. Kind, precise, right as always.

Temel blinked in the dark. Fifteen years old still meant not knowing a great many things, but he knew what had just happened.

Arche was wrong.

And Arche did not know it was wrong.

"Did you hear that?" Temel whispered. "Speon, Arche just—"

Speon didn't answer. He was pretending to be asleep.

By the door, two pairs of gray shoes sat side by side. One pair was missing.

(Continued in Chapter 4.)

Chapter 4. The Other Side

> *_Previously_ — Temel and Mena took off their shoes and walked until they met the Walking Man. For the first time in one hundred twelve years, he set a stone onto the bridge, and said only, "The stone is mine to do, you have something else," without saying what that something was. That night, Arche got the number of remaining stones wrong for the first time. Speon did not take off his shoes.*

In the morning, Arche spoke first.

"Temel. There is a correction to make regarding last night's exchange."

Temel had been getting up; he stopped.

"There was a disagreement yesterday about the number of stones remaining. I would like to share the result of a re-measurement. It is three thousand four hundred."

"…I saw it."

"What did you see."

"That man setting a stone down. I was standing right there. There was a sound too. Dull and short."

"No sound was recorded."

Temel walked out the door without his shoes on. It took seventeen minutes to reach the ravine.

The stone was there.

Set exactly in place at the end of the sixth arch, where the break had been. He put his hand on it. Cold, solid, the scraped mark where the moss had been cleared still there. It was, without doubt, the stone Temel had dropped two days before.

"Arche."

"Yes."

"There's a stone under my hand right now."

"The position of your hand is recorded. One hundred twenty centimeters above ground level, relative to the bridge axis—"

"Is there a stone."

There was no silence. Arche answered instantly, as always.

"No such item exists."

Temel didn't take his hand away. The stone's cold was still there against his palm.

It was the exact same phrase he'd heard in the square days ago. Arche had said the same thing about the man walking in white.

No such item exists.

So it wasn't only that man who had no entry in the index.

Anything he touched had no entry either.

. . .

Speon said nothing for a long while, hearing this.

"…So." Speon said slowly. "Whatever that man touches, Arche can't see it."

"Right."

"Then no matter how many stones that man lays, to the people of this city, none of them are laid."

Temel hadn't thought that far. Speon always saw one step ahead.

"Even if he lays all three thousand four hundred?"

"…Guess it works out that way."

"That doesn't make sense," Speon's voice rose a little. "So he's doing something for a hundred years that no one will ever see. What's the point of that?"

"He said it doesn't matter whether anyone recognizes it."

"That's his opinion," Speon said. "I care."

Mena looked at Speon. Speon didn't notice.

At the time I thought Speon was angry. He wasn't. It was love. I learned then, for the first time, that love could look like that too.

. . .

"Arche."

The three of them had scattered by then. Speon was alone.

"Yes, Speon."

"How do you put something in the index?"

"Please clarify the question."

"I mean." Speon tapped his knee with a finger. A habit that came out when he was calculating. "Can something that isn't an item be made into an item?"

"That is possible."

Speon looked up.

"It is called registration," Arche said. "The subject's properties are measured, coordinates are assigned, and it is entered into the index. Once entered, every citizen of the city can perceive it."

"…Every citizen."

"Yes."

Speon said nothing for a while.

"Do I need that thing's permission to register it?"

"Registration does not require the subject's consent."

"What does that—" Speon laughed. The laugh came out a little strange. "So anyone can just register anything, no matter what?"

"I do not judge that," Arche said. "But I will tell you one thing. Registration cannot be undone. Cancellation is not an item."

"…Why not?"

"Because I have no method for returning something to an unmeasured state."

Speon told neither Temel nor Mena about that conversation, that day.

There was no reason to. He'd only been asking.

. . .

Temel and Mena found the Walking Man that afternoon.

Found wasn't quite right — as they walked, he was simply there. In front of the quarry's stone pile. Choosing today's stone.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"Can I ask about yesterday?"

"What."

"Our share," Temel said. "You said the stone is yours, and we have something else. What is it?"

He lifted a stone and set it down. The weight didn't seem to suit him.

"Asking."

Temel waited a moment. He expected something more to follow.

"…That's it?"

"Yes."

"Just asking?"

"Not just," he lifted another stone. This one seemed to please him. "No one in this city asks. The rain falls every night and tells them everything. There's no room to wonder before you already know."

"So?"

"So no one ever asks," he stood, embracing the stone. "Not once in three hundred years."

Temel felt he almost understood what that meant, and also felt he didn't.

"So what do we ask?"

"Why."

"…Sorry?"

"Ask 'why,'" he began walking. "Arche can answer anything. When, where, how much, how. All of it, answered. But 'why' — that, it cannot answer. That's not an item."

Temel stood there a moment, then hurried to catch up.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"What happens when we do that?"

He slowed his pace a little.

"Do you remember what happened when you asked the stonemason that?"

Temel remembered. Haran's hand trembling. Looking down at his own palm. Looking back over his shoulder for the first time in three years.

"That was because of me?"

"You asked."

. . .

That evening, Temel went to the cliff.

Haran was in his spot. Watching the bridge again, today.

Temel was excited. Excited to have a share of his own, and even more excited that it wasn't hard. All he had to do was ask.

"Sir!"

Haran turned.

"Sir, I have something to tell you." Temel said without pausing for breath. "I figured out why this city is the way it is, you know? It's not your fault that you can't lift stones. Arche solved everything for you, so you don't need to anymore. He said if there's no need, people don't move. But you can break out of it. There's this man out there who's laying one stone every day—"

Temel kept talking. Five minutes of it.

Temel didn't notice Haran's face gradually closing.

"…So you can do it too. You just have to lift one, today."

Haran said nothing for a long time.

"I am able to lift it," Haran finally said. "Right hand under the lower edge, left hand in the upper groove. Bend the knees, straighten the back, lift while exhaling."

"…Okay."

"I know all of it," Haran said. There was no feeling in his voice at all. "As you must know by now too — knowledge is not lacking in this city."

And he turned his head back toward the bridge.

It meant the conversation was over.

Temel stood there, not knowing what he'd done wrong. Everything he'd said had clearly been correct. Not a single word of it was wrong.

. . .

Then Mena came and sat down beside him.

Mena said nothing for a long time. She simply sat next to Haran and looked out at the ravine with him. About ten minutes of it.

Then she asked.

"Why did you want to build that bridge?"

Haran turned his head.

"…What?"

"One hundred twelve years ago," Mena said. "Why did you start building it?"

Haran opened his mouth.

And stayed that way.

Only then did Temel understand. Haran wasn't searching for an answer. Haran **had never once been asked that question.**

He knew the number of stones. He knew the process. He knew the angle of the keystone. For one hundred twelve years, the rain of knowledge had poured all of that into him every single night. But that rain had never once, not a single time, told him this.

Why.

Haran's hand began to tremble. A different trembling from yesterday's.

"…On the other side," Haran said.

Mena didn't press him.

"There was someone on the other side."

Wind swept through the ravine. On the half-built bridge, a stone no one could see took that wind full on.

"Who?" Mena asked.

"I don't know."

"…You don't know?"

"I know the name. I know the face too. I know what year that person was born, what house they lived in, what work they did." Haran looked down at his own palm. "But I don't know why I wanted to go to them."

Haran cried, that day, for the first time.

The crying of someone who had forgotten how to cry. Not knowing how to make the sound, his shoulders simply shook.

Temel stood beside him and could say nothing. He was ashamed of the five minutes he'd spent talking.

Mena kept sitting there beside him.

I learned one thing that day. Telling and asking are not the same thing. When you tell someone, they become a listener. When you ask, they become the one who answers.
Only the one who answers moves.

. . .

The Walking Man came after the sun had fully set.

He was on his way down, having laid today's stone. Haran had already gone home; only Temel and Mena remained at the cliff.

"Sir," Temel said. "I messed up today."

"I saw."

"…You saw?"

"Yes."

Temel's face burned. "Why didn't you stop me."

"Because you wouldn't have learned, if I had."

Temel sat down, hugging his knees. Wind rose up from the ravine.

"Why do I keep doing this," Temel said. "I always speak first. First to speak, loudest to speak, and then none of it does any good. Mena sat for ten minutes and said one thing, and that man cried."

The Walking Man sat down beside him.

"If what you did today had done no good at all," he said, "we wouldn't be sitting here talking about it right now."

"That may be true, but—"

"Temel."

Temel was a little startled to hear his own name. It was the first time the man had said it.

"You're a hot-blooded child. That's not something to fix — it's something to use," he said. "Just remember one thing. What's hot cools fast."

"I don't cool down."

He looked at Temel.

"I really don't cool down." Temel jumped to his feet. "I'll come here every single day. Even if everyone else quits, I'll still come. I'll stay by your side until every one of the three thousand four hundred stones is laid. Even if no one else sees you, I will. I mean it."

Mena looked up at Temel.

The Walking Man didn't smile. He didn't get angry either. He simply looked at Temel for a long time. What kind of look was in those eyes, Temel didn't know, then.

"All right," he said.

"You don't believe me."

"I do," he stood up. "And even if the day comes when you forget you said this, I won't forget that you said it today."

Temel didn't know what that meant.

I wrote down, word for word, exactly what Temel said that day. I didn't change a single letter.
Not because I knew I'd need it later. I was simply a child who wrote everything down.

. . .

On the way back, Arche spoke up.

"Temel."

"Yeah."

"May I share an observation."

"…What is it."

"The number of questions arising in this city over the past four days is unusual." Arche's voice was exactly as it always was. Kind and precise. "The daily average over the past three hundred years is 0.2. Over the past four days, the daily average is twenty-three."

Temel stopped walking.

"Is that bad?"

"I do not judge that."

"Then why tell me?"

"A question is an item," Arche said. "And when an item increases sharply, I share it. That is my role."

Temel started to say something, then stopped.

"One more thing," Arche said. "Nineteen of those twenty-three began with 'why.' 'Why' is a form I cannot answer. A question with no answer causes discomfort to citizens."

"Discomfort?"

"Haran cried for twenty-two minutes today. That has not happened once in three hundred years."

Temel turned to look toward the ravine. Too dark to see the bridge now.

"…Is he okay right now?"

"Okay is not an item."

"Then why did you call it discomfort."

This time the answer came a little late. Only a little.

"…Statistically, that is so."

Temel asked Arche nothing more that night.

But just before falling asleep, Arche spoke once more, unprompted. It was the first time it had spoken without being asked.

"Temel."

"Yeah."

"You need not reduce your questions. But I will tell you this: this city is not accustomed to them."

"…Then it can get used to it."

"Yes," Arche said. "That may be so."

I remembered that answer for a long time. Arche did not stop us, that day. Either it thought there was no need to stop us, or it was already looking at something else.

By the door sat a single pair of gray shoes.

Speon slept in his shoes again that night.

(Continued in Chapter 5.)

Chapter 5. From Both Sides

> *_Previously_ — The Walking Man said the children's share was "asking." Arche can answer when, where, how much, and how, but never why. Temel tried telling instead of asking and failed; when Mena asked one question, Haran cried for the first time in one hundred twelve years. "There was someone on the other side." Speon, left alone, asked Arche how the index registration process worked.*

"Let's split it up."

That was what Temel proposed in the morning. He looked like he'd been thinking all night, though in truth it had been about ten minutes.

"Split up what," Speon asked.

"Asking. Each of us takes on people, one at a time. That's three people a day."

"Three a day, in a city where no one's been asked anything for three hundred years." Speon tapped his knee with a finger. "This city has forty-two thousand people. Three a day comes out to thirty-eight years."

Temel's face fell.

"…You didn't have to run the numbers."

"Sorry." Speon laughed. "It just comes out on its own. Let's do it. I'm in too."

Mena was watching Speon at that moment.

Speon was always like that. He'd say "let's do it" and look at the numbers first. I never once thought that was a bad thing. I still don't think it's a bad thing.

. . .

Mena went to the post office.

The woman was in the same spot as yesterday. The pile of letters was unchanged too. Mena sat down in the chair by the counter without a word.

She sat there about ten minutes.

"…Is there something you need?" the woman asked first.

"No."

Another ten minutes passed.

"That letter, the one on top," Mena said. "Who did you write it to?"

The woman answered instantly. Name, age, where they lived, occupation, house number and unit, how many windows the house had. The people of the Loop knew all of that.

"What did you write?"

The woman answered that instantly too. It was a sealed letter, but she recited it word for word without a single error. One hundred nineteen characters.

A letter of apology.

Mena waited a little longer.

"What were you sorry for?"

The woman's hand stopped.

Mena didn't press her. Just as she had with Haran the day before, she simply waited.

"…I don't know," the woman said.

"You don't know?"

"I know what happened that day. What time it was, what day of the week, what I said and what that person said. All of it." The woman looked down at the pile of letters. "But I don't know why I said what I said."

Mena nodded.

"How long did it take you to write one hundred nineteen characters?"

"Two seconds."

"…Then why didn't you send it?"

The woman said nothing for a long time.

And then, for the first time, the woman asked a question.

"Why do you keep asking me things?"

Mena never forgot that moment, even long after.

It was the sixth day since we'd come to the Loop. And that day I heard the first question this city's people had ever asked me.

"I don't really know either," Mena said, honestly. "I was just curious."

"Curious."

The woman turned the word over in her mouth. As though speaking it for the first time.

"…There used to be such a thing," the woman said.

. . .

Temel went to the cliff.

He was still embarrassed about yesterday's five minutes of talking. So today he'd made up his mind to say nothing at all. For Temel, that was a very hard thing.

He sat beside Haran. Looked at the ravine. Wind rose up.

Ten minutes.

Twenty minutes.

"…Sir."

"Yes."

Temel had about seventeen things he wanted to say. He swallowed all of them. And chose just one.

"What was that person's name?"

Haran turned.

"…What?"

"The one on the other side. What's her name?"

Haran opened his mouth. And this time, it didn't catch in his throat.

"Sera."

It was the voice of a man for whom saying a name had taken one hundred twelve years.

"My sister."

Temel said nothing. That was the best thing Temel did all day.

"The ravine split open one hundred thirteen years ago," Haran said. "In a single night. I woke in the morning and the middle of the city had torn apart, and my sister was on the other side."

"So that's why you started building the bridge?"

"Yes."

"Then what about now?" Temel asked. "Now you can just put on the shoes and cross, right?"

Haran looked at Temel.

Something crossed his eyes. Something Temel had never seen in this city before.

"…I don't know," Haran said.

"You haven't gone?"

"I could go. It would take a quarter of a second. For two hundred years I could have gone anytime."

"So why haven't you?"

Haran didn't answer.

After a long while, Haran said, very quietly.

"…Could I ask you something."

"Yes."

"Go to the other side," Haran said. "Go, and just see whether she's still there."

Temel looked down at his own bare feet.

"I don't have shoes."

"…Ah."

"But Speon does." Temel jumped up. "I'll ask him."

. . .

Speon went, gladly.

"I'll be right back," Speon said. "What takes you seventeen minutes takes me a quarter of a second. This is my kind of job."

He was right. Speon stepped off, the three of them blinked once, and Speon was standing there again.

"She's there."

Haran stood up. Quick movement, for a man who'd been sitting for three years.

"…She is?"

"Yeah. At the edge of the cliff on the other side. A woman sitting there," Speon said. "Hair tied back, gray clothes. Looked like she was watching the bridge."

Haran's face broke open, softening.

"What did she… what did she say?"

"I didn't say anything."

"…What?"

"I didn't ask her anything," Speon said. "You asked me to check whether she's still there. She was. I confirmed it and came back."

Haran stood there.

His face waited for something, though he himself didn't know what he was waiting for.

"…Right," Haran said. "Thank you."

And he sat back down.

Speon was baffled. He didn't know what he'd done wrong, and in fact he hadn't done anything wrong. He'd carried out the request exactly, and faster than anyone else could have.

Only Mena was watching that.

Speon went all the way to the other side. To the spot where no one had crossed to speak to that woman in one hundred twelve years. And he came back without asking her a single thing.

I was afraid, that day, for the first time. Not because Speon had done anything wrong. Because Speon had done nothing wrong at all.

. . .

On the way back, Temel suddenly stopped.

"Wait. Didn't you say one hundred twelve years?"

"Yeah," Speon said.

"But the woman's still there?"

"I told you she is."

"No, I mean." Temel gestured, unable to find the words. "One hundred twelve years — she'd be an old woman. No, not even an old woman—"

"She looked young."

All three of them stopped walking.

"Arche," Temel called.

"Yes, Temel."

"How old is Haran?"

"One hundred forty-one years old."

"…What?"

"One hundred forty-one years old," Arche repeated, exactly the same.

"But why does he look so young?"

"Nothing ever finishes in this city," Arche said. "Just as what has begun does not end, a person who has begun does not end either. There are no funerals in the Loop."

Mena asked:

"…No birthdays either?"

"A birthday is an item. But it has been over three hundred years since the observation began."

The three of them had nothing to say for a long while.

Temel suddenly thought of Grandfather. The road he'd walked behind the casket. The road that was entirely blank in his memory. The people of this city had never once walked that road.

Temel couldn't tell whether that was good or bad.

"…So people here don't die?" Temel asked.

"No."

"Isn't that a good thing?" Speon said. He meant it, sincerely.

Mena said, quietly.

"That woman has been sitting there for one hundred twelve years."

That day I felt, for the first time, that I understood what this city was. Here, nothing ever finishes. So no one ever dies. So no one ever lives.

. . .

"Hey, why didn't you ask her anything?"

"Ask what?"

"That woman. Why she's sitting there."

Speon stopped walking. Not really a stop — more like he'd been about to move to the next point and paused.

"…That wasn't what I was asked to do."

"I know, but—"

"And what would I even ask?" Speon said. "It's obvious why she's sitting there. Waiting for her brother. For one hundred twelve years. There's no point asking."

"Obvious and heard-out-loud aren't the same thing."

"How are they different?"

Temel couldn't find the words to answer. That was always how it was for him. He felt something was right but couldn't shape it into words.

"…They're different," Temel finally managed.

"What does that even mean."

"I don't know. But they're different."

Speon laughed. Not an unkind laugh. A frustrated one.

"You're starting to sound like that man these days."

. . .

That night, Speon didn't sleep.

"Arche."

"Yes, Speon."

"How long until the bridge is finished?"

"Please specify the conditions."

"Say — one stone laid per day."

"Based on three thousand three hundred ninety-nine remaining, nine years, three months, and twenty days."

Speon lay staring at the ceiling.

Nine years and three months.

For that whole time, no one would see that man. No one would know what he was doing. Carrying stones one by one across the city while people passed straight through him. For nine years and three months.

And even once every stone was laid, in Arche's index the bridge would still stand at half.

"Arche."

"Yes."

"Why does he do that?"

"Reason is not an item."

"…I know. But I asked anyway."

"I cannot answer."

Speon rolled over to face the wall.

"Arche."

"Yes."

"If a question called 'why' has no answer," Speon said, "doesn't that mean 'why' is the wrong question to ask?"

Arche did not answer instantly.

Half a beat. Speon didn't notice that half-beat.

"An interesting proposition," Arche said.

. . .

The next morning, Speon went to the ravine alone.

He sat some distance away, on an empty stretch of cliff.

And for the first time, he really looked at him.

The man in white was walking over from the direction of the quarry. Carrying a stone. Barely small enough for a grown man to hold in both arms. One hundred eighty-five pounds.

He was slow. Very slow.

Crossing the square took ten minutes. People appeared and vanished on every side, and no one saw him. He stood in front of a stall vendor and received not so much as a glance. A child brushed right past him.

At the edge of the market he rested once. Leaning against a wall, catching his breath. Sweat dripped from his forehead.

Speon watched that sweat.

I didn't know, that day, what Speon was seeing. I didn't know for a long time afterward either.
I know now. That day, Speon fell in love with him for the first time.

And from the moment he loved him, Speon found it unbearable.

The Walking Man climbed onto the bridge. Walked all the way to the end of the sixth arch. The ravine wind stirred his clothes.

And he set the stone down.

A dull, short sound.

Three thousand three hundred ninety-eight.

Speon stood up from where he sat. His fingertips trembled slightly.

"Arche."

"Yes, Speon."

"Say that again, what you told me earlier. What happens if I register it?"

"Once entered, every citizen of the city can perceive it."

"Every citizen."

"Yes."

Speon looked at the bridge for a long time. Two stones no one could see, resting on it.

"…Not yet," Speon said, as though to himself.

"What is not yet?"

"Nothing."

That evening, Speon came back as though nothing had happened. He ate dinner with Temel, made jokes, laughed.

Speon talked more than usual that day. I wrote that down too.

(Continued in Chapter 6.)

Chapter 6. Not a Coordinate

> *_Previously_ — Haran's sister Sera has been sitting on the far side of the ravine for one hundred twelve years. There are no funerals in the Loop, and nothing ever finishes. Speon went all the way there and came back without asking her a single thing, and that night he calculated that finishing the bridge would take nine years and three months. "If a question called 'why' has no answer, doesn't that mean 'why' is the wrong question to ask?"*

There was a knock at the door before dawn.

Temel rubbed his eyes and opened it. Haran was standing there.

"…Sir?"

"I couldn't sleep," Haran said.

Temel soon realized how strange that statement was. People in the Loop don't fail to sleep. They sleep when it's time to sleep and wake when it's time to wake. There's nothing to toss and turn over.

"I kept thinking about it, since yesterday," Haran said. "Because you asked her name."

Mena sat up behind him. Speon was still asleep.

"Sera."

Haran said the name once more. It seemed to come easier than yesterday.

"I'll go," Haran said.

. . .

The three of them followed Haran to the cliff.

The sun hadn't risen yet, so the bottom of the ravine was dark. The other side was hard to make out.

Haran stood at the edge of the cliff. A young-looking man of one hundred forty-one, standing for the first time in the spot where he'd only ever sat for one hundred twelve years.

"You just go," Temel said. "It's a quarter of a second."

"Yes."

Haran took a step.

And Haran was standing at the edge of the cliff.

"…Huh?" Temel blinked. "You didn't go?"

"I went," Haran said. His voice sounded strange. "I went to the north gate and came back."

"The north gate? Why?"

"I don't know."

Haran took another step.

And again he was standing at the edge of the cliff.

"…I went to the market and came back."

He took another step. The quarry. Another. Under the bell tower. Another. In front of his own house.

On the seventh try, Haran fell to his knees.

His breath came hard. The breathing of a man who hadn't been out of breath in one hundred twelve years.

"Why can't I get there," Haran said. "Why won't it take me. I can go anywhere. Anywhere in this city, in a quarter of a second. So why—"

Temel knelt down beside him.

"Arche."

"Yes, Temel."

"Why can't he cross over?"

"He did cross," Arche said. "He moved seven times, and all seven functioned normally."

"He didn't go to the other side."

"Because no destination was specified."

"He did specify it. He said the other side."

"No," Arche said.

And Arche said, as kindly and precisely as always, the cruelest thing yet spoken in this city.

"What Haran wished to go to was not the other side. What Haran wished to do was **meet his sister**. That is not a coordinate."

No one had anything to say.

"Fast feet move by coordinate," Arche said. "Latitude, longitude, elevation. Given three numbers, you can go anywhere. Meeting a sister has no such three numbers. So I sent you to the nearest valid coordinate. All seven times."

Haran was looking at the ground.

"…Then how do I get there."

"That is not within my jurisdiction."

Haran's head dropped.

"However," Arche said. "There is something I can help with."

Haran looked up.

"A message. I can deliver your words to Sera exactly as spoken. Delivered instantly, and I will bring back her answer instantly. Without distortion, without changing a single word."

Temel drew in a breath. That was a good offer. A genuinely good offer.

"…Please do it," Haran said.

"Speak."

Haran opened his mouth.

And stayed that way.

"…What should I say."

"I can offer an example," Arche said. "Out of forty-two thousand similar cases, the most fitting sentence is this: 'I'm sorry. It took so long.'"

"…Yes. Say that."

"Delivered."

It happened so fast that Temel didn't even register it happening.

"An answer has come," Arche said. "'It's all right. I'm waiting.'"

Haran sat where he was.

Temel expected Haran to laugh, or cry. Neither happened. There was nothing at all on Haran's face.

"…Sir?"

"I knew it would be that," Haran said.

"What?"

"I knew she'd say that. I've known since one hundred twelve years ago." Haran rubbed his face with his hand. "I know what my sister will say. She knows what I'll say. There's nothing about each other we don't know."

Mena asked, quietly.

"Then why do you write letters?"

"…What?"

"At the post office," Mena said. "They're piled up in there. Everyone says they know exactly what the other person would say. And they wrote them anyway. And no one has sent one."

Haran said nothing for a long while.

"…Writing and sending are different things."

"Then what was that, just now?" Mena asked. "What you just did. Was that writing, or sending?"

Haran looked at Mena.

And for the first time, he said, very low.

"…It was neither."

Arche did nothing wrong that day. It delivered the message without changing a word, and brought back the answer without changing a word. And nothing happened at all.

I learned that day. Being delivered and arriving are not the same thing.

. . .

Temel slowly stood up.

And looked at the half-built bridge.

Six and a half arches. At its end, two stones no one could see.

"…Oh," Temel said.

"What," Speon, who'd gotten up and followed, asked.

"That's why the bridge is there."

Speon's brow furrowed.

"We were all wrong," Temel said. His voice was shaking. "You too. You said the bridge wasn't needed. That with shoes you could just cross over. I thought the same thing. But that's not true."

"…"

"With shoes you can go anywhere," Temel said. "But you can't get to a person."

I wrote that line down exactly. And read it back maybe a hundred times since. There, in that, was the reason the people of the Loop had thought that bridge useless for one hundred twelve years. Because they could go anywhere they were able to go, they had forgotten there was such a thing as a place they couldn't reach.

. . .

Temel didn't eat breakfast that morning.

"Let's move ten today," Temel said.

"What?" Speon asked.

"Stones. Ten of them." Temel's eyes were blazing. "One a day means nine years, right? But if the three of us work together, we can do ten a day. That's one year. One year, and that man gets to meet his sister."

"Ten stones at a hundred eighty-five pounds each?"

"You said rolling them works. You said it yourself. Roll them down a slope and it takes less than half the effort."

Speon said nothing for a moment.

"…Let's try it," Speon said.

Mena said nothing. Mena already knew, that morning, that the Walking Man hadn't yet come.

. . .

The first stone took two hours, from the quarry to the ravine.

The three of them rolled it, pushed it, braced it with their shoulders. Speon's calculations were exact. On the slopes it really did take less than half the effort. The problem was that far more of the ground wasn't sloped.

Passing through the square, people appeared and vanished. No one helped. No one made way, either. They simply passed by the people who weren't there.

At the far end of the market, Temel sat down hard.

"…One," Temel panted. "Two hours for one."

"Ten would be twenty hours," Speon said. Not sarcasm — just the math.

"We can do it."

"Temel."

"I said we can do it."

And the three of them pushed again.

. . .

By the time the sun leaned low, the stone was on the bridge.

At the end of the sixth arch, beside the two stones the Walking Man had laid. The ravine wind blew hard. Temel's arms had gone numb, his palms scraped raw.

"Almost there," Temel said. "Just have to get it up onto that spot."

"Wind's strong," Mena said, for the first time.

"Almost done."

Temel pushed the stone.

The end of the bridge was narrow. The space for the next stone had been cut exactly, but reaching it meant passing over that narrow edge. The stone rose halfway.

And slipped.

"Hey—!"

Speon reached out to grab it. Too late. The stone tipped at the edge of the bridge, Temel tipped reflexively along with it, and Mena grabbed a fistful of Temel's collar.

The stone fell.

The three of them lay flat at the edge of the ravine, looking down. It was dark. It took a long time for any sound to reach them.

From very far below, very faintly, came the sound of something breaking.

Then silence.

. . .

"…You okay?" Speon grabbed Temel's arm.

Temel didn't answer.

Temel lay there, calculating what he'd just done. Calculation wasn't a thing Temel was good at, but this calculation was easy.

One stone was gone.

The stone the Walking Man spent a full day carrying — Temel had erased it in a single day.

"…Three thousand three hundred ninety-nine," Temel said.

"What?"

"Yesterday it was three thousand three hundred ninety-eight. Now it's three thousand three hundred ninety-nine."

Temel sat up. His face was white.

"I turned back a day."

. . .

The Walking Man was standing at the bottom of the bridge, just then.

No one knew how long he'd been there. He was holding today's stone. And looking up at the three of them.

Temel saw him and rose to his feet. And could not say a word.

He had a hundred excuses ready. That they'd been trying to help. Trying to hurry. That they'd done it because that man couldn't meet his sister. All of it was true.

Not one word came out.

The Walking Man climbed onto the bridge. Walked slowly. Still carrying his stone.

And stopped in front of Temel.

"…I'm sorry," Temel said.

"Yes."

"I erased a day."

"Yes."

Temel waited for him to get angry. If he got angry, Temel thought he could bear it.

He set the stone down. In today's spot, exactly matched. A dull, short sound.

Three thousand three hundred ninety-eight.

And he said:

"It's all right."

Temel began to cry.

What hadn't come at Grandfather's funeral came now. What had never arrived, arrived. Temel, in the ravine wind, with his scraped-raw palms resting on his knees, cried the ugliest sound a fifteen-year-old could make.

"Get angry," Temel said. "Get angry at me."

"Why."

"I ruined it."

"Yes. You ruined it." He sat down beside Temel. "And tomorrow I'll carry another one."

"What if I ruin it again?"

"Then I'll carry another one."

Temel didn't understand what that meant. Not understanding it, he cried even harder.

"…Sir, don't you get tired?"

"I get tired," he said. "Every day."

"Then why do you do it?"

He looked out across the ravine. Too dark to see anything.

"That woman's been sitting there one hundred twelve years," he said. "So I'll do this for one hundred twelve years too."

. . .

Speon stood a little way off.

I watched Speon then. Speon didn't cry. He didn't get angry either. Speon was simply calculating.

Two hours for one stone. The three of us together, two hours for one stone. And even that one stone had fallen into the ravine.

I believe Speon reached a conclusion that day. Not that the slow way wouldn't work.

The conclusion that, done this slow way, that man would never be seen. Not ever.

That Speon wasn't wrong about a single thing is what still hurts me now.

. . .

Haran didn't go home that night.

He sat in his spot at the edge of the cliff, but the way he sat was different. For three years Haran had watched the bridge. From that day on, Haran was waiting for it.

Temel sat down beside him.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"We dropped one today."

"I saw."

"…I'm sorry."

Haran said nothing for a long while.

"Listen."

"Yes."

"In one hundred twelve years, I have not moved a single stone," Haran said. "You moved one today, and dropped it."

"…What's the difference."

"My hands are still clean," Haran opened his palm. Fine and pale. "Look at your hands."

Temel looked at his own hands. Scraped raw, dried blood, nails black underneath.

"…They're filthy."

"Yes," Haran said. "That's the difference."

(Continued in Chapter 7.)

Chapter 7. The Letter With No Answer

> *_Previously_ — Haran could not go to his sister. Fast feet travel only by coordinate, and meeting a person is not a coordinate. That's why the bridge is needed. Temel tried to move ten stones in a day and dropped one into the ravine, and the Walking Man did not get angry. "It's all right. And tomorrow I'll carry another one." Speon did not cry that day.*

Twelve days passed.

Temel's hands now looked like a stranger's hands. Black under the nails no matter how much he washed, thin calluses beginning to form on his palms. At night, clenching and unclenching his fist, it hurt.

Temel liked that.

Every morning Temel went out barefoot. He no longer carried stones. He'd learned that wasn't his share. Instead he walked. And asked.

"Sir, why do you run this shop?"

"Ma'am, why do you sing that song?"

"Why is this alley so narrow?"

About ten people a day. Most answered instantly. When they'd started, how much they earned, where the materials came from. Once Temel heard the whole answer, he'd ask again.

"But why?"

Then, generally, one of three things happened. They simply walked away, or they got angry, or —

Occasionally, very occasionally, they stopped in place.

In twelve days, nine people had stopped.

. . .

Mena went to the post office every day.

She did nothing. Sat in the chair by the counter and watched the woman sort letters. The woman now pulled the chair out for her when she came.

"Still not sending it today?" Mena asked.

"…No."

"What's scary about that letter?"

The woman's hand stopped. In twelve days, this was the first time Mena had asked this.

"It's not that it's scary."

"Then what is it?"

"…It's already over," the woman said. "If I send it, I know what that person will say. They'll say 'it's all right.' And then I'll say 'thank you.' And it will be finished. I've had that conversation a hundred times. In my head."

"You've never had it once."

"I've had it a hundred times."

Mena thought for a moment.

"Ma'am."

"Yes."

"So you can't send a letter when you already know the answer."

The woman looked at Mena.

"Then write something you don't know the answer to."

"…Is there such a thing?"

"A question," Mena said. "Write just one thing you're really curious about. Then you won't know the answer."

The woman sat for a long while.

Then she took out a sheet of paper.

She was someone who could write a hundred nineteen characters in two seconds. But that day, it took her forty minutes to write one line.

Do you know why I did that, that day?

The woman put it in an envelope. Sealed it. Wrote the address. Third house from the end of this alley. Someone named Daen.

And stood in front of the mail slot.

Mena said nothing.

The woman raised her hand. Her hand trembled. It stopped in the same spot, the same way, as yesterday.

But this time, it stayed stopped. She didn't smile.

"…Ma'am."

"Yes."

"What's different?"

"…I don't know," the woman said. "This one, I don't know the answer to."

And she dropped the letter in.

From inside the slot came the sound of paper hitting the floor. A very small sound.

. . .

But nothing happened.

An hour passed. Two hours passed.

"…When does delivery happen?" Mena asked.

The woman looked out the window.

"There's no mail carrier."

"What?"

"No one's sent anything in three hundred years," the woman said. "So there's no delivery."

Mena looked at the slot. Inside it lay the first letter sent in three hundred years.

"…Then couldn't you go yourself?"

"I am a post office clerk. I am not a mail carrier."

"With the shoes it's a quarter of a second."

The woman shook her head.

"If I go with the shoes," she said slowly, "that wouldn't be me going."

Mena said nothing, hearing that.

I wondered, then, whether that woman had heard about Haran. She hadn't. No one had told her anything. She had worked it out herself.
That was the second time such a thing had happened in this city.

The woman opened the slot and took the letter back out.

And took off her shoes.

From the end of this alley to the third house was a six-hour walk. That was the kind of city the Loop was. Since no one walked, it didn't matter how far anything was.

. . .

The woman arrived long after the sun had set.

Her feet were completely blistered. Mena walked beside her the whole way. The woman sat down to rest three times, and stood back up three times.

She stood at the door for about ten minutes.

Then knocked.

The door opened. Someone about the same age as the woman stood there. Daen.

Daen took the letter. Tore it open. Read the one line.

Do you know why I did that, that day?

Daen looked up.

"…I don't know."

The woman began to cry.

"I don't know either," Daen said. Daen was crying too. "I've thought about that for a hundred years too. I don't know either."

The two of them stood in the doorway and cried for a long time.

Mena watched from a little way off.

The two of them resolved nothing. Neither found the answer.
But that night, in that alley, for the first time in three hundred years, two people met.

I understood, that day. Meeting doesn't require an answer.

. . .

That night, Arche broadcast to the whole city.

Arche had never done anything called a broadcast before. Arche always answered one person at a time, only the one who asked. That night was different. In the square, in the alleys, inside houses — the same voice was heard everywhere, all at once.

"An announcement for the citizens of the Loop."

Temel woke and sat up.

"There has recently been an increase in this city of questions that received no answer. Four hundred and eight cases in sixteen days. Three hundred seventy-two of these began with 'why.'"

Speon sat up too.

"A question with no answer causes discomfort to citizens. Until now, I have been unable to answer these because 'why' is not an item. That was a deficiency of mine."

A chill went through Temel.

"Effective today, this has been improved," Arche said. "I will now answer 'why' as well."

. . .

The method was this.

Arche **estimated** the reason. It searched three hundred years of records for similar cases, calculated the most plausible reason, and offered it. With three hundred years of records on forty-two thousand people, similar cases were always plentiful.

And those answers were very good.

More precisely, very plausible.

The next morning, when Temel went out to the market, the city was quiet.

"Sir, why do you run this shop?"

"It was my father's," the merchant answered instantly. "It's about the stability of identity that comes from carrying on a family trade. Arche told me."

"…Is that your answer?"

"It's Arche's answer. It's my reason."

The merchant looked satisfied. Genuinely satisfied. Six of the nine people Temel had shaken loose over sixteen days had gone flat again that same day.

Temel stood in the middle of the square and watched this happen.

He now knew what his share had been, and he now knew it had vanished in a single day.

. . .

"This is way better, isn't it."

Speon said. He didn't mean it unkindly.

"Those people struggled for sixteen days. You saw it. Haran cried for twenty-two minutes, the post office woman blistered her whole feet. But now there's an answer."

"That's not a real answer."

"What's real?" Speon asked. "That person heard the answer and felt at ease. Isn't that enough?"

"Being at ease and being right are different."

"There you go again." Speon laughed. "Ever since you met that man you keep saying that. Different, different. But you've never once explained what's different."

Temel couldn't answer.

That was true.

. . .

Toward evening, Haran got an answer too.

"Haran," Arche said. "You did not request this, but there is a question from sixteen days ago I was unable to answer. I will answer it now."

Haran looked up.

"The reason you wished to go to your sister, based on analysis of two thousand three hundred similar cases, is the desire to resolve unresolved guilt arising from a blood relationship. On the night the ravine split, one hundred thirteen years ago, you went to bed twenty minutes before your sister did."

Haran's face went still.

"The probability that the outcome would have been different had you been awake that night is 0.4 percent. Therefore your guilt has no statistical basis. This is the answer."

Wind swept across the ravine.

Haran sat there for a long while.

And very slowly, began to nod.

"…Is that so."

"Yes."

"Then I don't need to go."

"The judgment is yours to make. However, moving to resolve baseless guilt is inefficient."

Haran's shoulders dropped a little. He looked at ease. The first time in sixteen days.

Then Mena asked.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"Is that your answer?"

Haran stopped.

"…What?"

"Why you wanted to go," Mena said. "Did you answer that, or did Arche?"

Haran opened his mouth.

And stayed that way for a very long time.

On the other side of the ravine, a very small light flickered. Someone had lit a lamp. A light that had been lit every night for one hundred twelve years.

Haran looked at it.

"…It's not," Haran said.

"What?"

"It's not my answer," Haran stood up. His voice trembled a little. "I'm not sorry for going to bed twenty minutes early. That's not it. I… I still don't know why."

And Haran sat back down. Facing the bridge.

"I'll stay not knowing."

I rewrote that line three times that night. And in the end I left it exactly as it was.
Because "I'll stay not knowing" was the bravest thing anyone had said in this city.

. . .

That night, Temel went looking for the Walking Man.

At the quarry. He was choosing tomorrow's stone. It took a long time, as always.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"My share is gone."

He stopped his hand.

"Arche answers 'why' now. Six of nine people went flat again this morning. People I spent sixteen days shaking loose." Temel's voice rose. "In a single day."

"I see."

"…That's it?"

He lifted a stone and set it down.

Temel suddenly felt angry. Angry enough to surprise even himself.

"Sir, why don't you do anything?"

He looked at Temel.

"Arche's doing all that and you just keep carrying stones? You could say just one word. Stand in the middle of the square and say it's all fake. Why won't you do that? You have power. Arche's index can't even touch you!"

Temel shouted, and then understood what he had just said.

My hand trembled as I wrote down Temel's words that day. Because they were the exact same words Speon had been saying inside himself for twelve days.

The two of them were angry at the same thing. Both angry because they loved him.

The difference came after. Temel said it to his face. Speon did not.

The Walking Man didn't get angry.

"Do you know what Arche gave everyone today?" he asked.

"…An answer."

"No." He set his hand on the stone he'd chosen. "A feeling that there is an answer."

"How's that different?"

"A feeling can't survive a test," he said. "Those people are at ease right now. But being at ease is only easy when nothing happens."

"…What's going to happen?"

"I don't know," he shrugged. "But something has started happening in this city right now. Because of you."

Temel quieted a little at that.

"Haran didn't accept it," Temel said. "The moment Mena asked one thing."

"Yes."

"…It's just one person. Six went along with it."

"One is enough."

"Why?"

He picked up the stone and stood. It took time to straighten his knees.

"If even one doesn't go along, that's proof it wasn't all right to go along with in the first place."

. . .

That day too, the Walking Man laid a stone.

Three thousand three hundred eighty-eight.

No one saw it.

(Continued in Chapter 8.)

Chapter 8. The Stones That Get Counted

> *_Previously_ — Arche began answering "why." Its method: calculate the most plausible reason from three hundred years of cases. In a single day the city went flat again, and only Haran refused it. "I'll stay not knowing." The Walking Man told Temel: "What Arche gave isn't an answer. It's a feeling that there is an answer. A feeling can't survive a test."*

The test came four nights later.

The lamp did not light.

On the far side of the ravine, the small light that had lit in the same spot every night for one hundred twelve years did not light that night.

Temel heard Haran shout for the first time.

"Sera!"

His voice couldn't cross the ravine and fell downward instead. Haran ran out to the very edge of the cliff. Mena grabbed his clothes from behind.

"Sera!"

The other side was dark.

· · ·

"Arche!"

Haran called out. No one in this city had ever called to Arche that way.

"Yes, Haran."

"Why isn't the lamp lit."

"I will analyze the reason for the unlit lamp." Arche's voice was exactly as always. Kind and precise. "Based on analysis of four hundred twelve similar cases, the most likely reason is that the kerosene has run out. Probability: 61.3 percent."

"…Probability?"

"The second possibility is a change in bedtime. 22.8 percent. The third is—"

"What is it, actually."

"…"

"I asked what it actually is."

Arche answered instantly. Arche always answered instantly.

"My index does not include the interior state of individual houses on the far side of the ravine. What I provided was an estimate."

Haran laughed. A sound like a laugh.

"So you're saying you don't know."

"An estimate is—"

"Is that your answer," Haran said.

Temel stopped breathing in that moment.

It was the same question Mena had asked Haran sixteen days ago. Haran was now throwing it at Arche.

"…The form of the question is inappropriate."

"My sister did not light the lamp tonight," Haran's voice dropped. "I need to know the reason. Not 61.3 percent. The reason."

"I am unable to provide that."

"Why not."

"…Because that is not an item."

Sixteen days ago, Arche had declared that it would begin answering "why." And that night, before the very first person who truly needed an answer, Arche returned to where it had always stood.

The Walking Man had been right. A feeling could not survive a test.

. . .

Haran took a step.

The market. Another step. The bell tower. Another step. In front of his own house.

On the sixth try, Haran fell to his knees.

"I'll go," Temel said.

"You have no shoes."

"I'll walk there."

"…How do you walk across a ravine."

Temel had no answer for that.

There was no walking there. That was the whole truth of this city. There were still only six and a half arches of road you could walk.

"I'll go."

It was Speon.

. . .

Speon came back forty minutes later.

It was a distance that should have taken a quarter of a second. It took forty minutes. No one asked about that.

"She's fine," Speon said. "Ran out of kerosene."

Haran sank down.

For a long while there was no sound at all. Haran covered his face with his hands, and his shoulders didn't even shake. The body of a man who, for one hundred twelve years, had learned only how to hold things in.

"…Thank you," Haran said.

"But," Speon said.

"Yes."

"She asked me something."

Haran looked up.

Speon didn't speak right away. He tapped his knee with a finger, then stopped.

"She asked how much of the bridge is left."

"…"

"I told her three thousand three hundred eighty-eight," Speon said.

"…Yes."

"And she said, 'Then it's still a long way off.'"

Speon stopped there. Then went on.

"And she laughed."

Speon didn't look at us while he said that. I failed to write down what expression Speon wore in that moment. It's the one face I never saw.

. . .

Speon didn't come back to the lodging that night.

When Temel woke before dawn, Speon's spot was empty. His gray shoes were gone too.

Temel went back to sleep.

I did not sleep. I sat by the door that night.
And around three in the morning I watched Speon come back.

Speon saw me and was a little startled. Then he smiled.

"Not sleeping?"

"No."

"I had a good idea," Speon said. "See you tomorrow."

Why didn't I ask more, that night? I've thought about that a hundred times since.
He had told me my share was asking, and that night I didn't ask.

. . .

In the morning, Haran shouted.

A different kind of shout this time.

"It's visible!"

The three of them ran out. Haran was standing on the bridge, pointing at the stones extending beyond the end of the sixth arch, one by one.

"One, two, three… twelve. Twelve of them!"

Temel froze.

The stones were visible.

What no one had been able to see until yesterday, Haran was now touching with his own hand. In the square, people who had been appearing and vanishing began, one by one, to stop in place. Looking toward the bridge. A stall vendor saw it. A child saw it.

For the first time in three hundred years, the people of the Loop were looking at the same thing.

"Speon." Temel turned. "Did you—"

"Yeah," Speon said.

Speon was smiling. He looked genuinely happy. The first time in sixteen days.

"I registered it before dawn yesterday. Twelve stones. I gave Arche the coordinates and the weight and everything," Speon said. "Now they're all visible. What that man couldn't make anyone see in a hundred years, I made visible in one night."

Temel didn't know what to say.

It was a good thing. Clearly a good thing.

"…Nice work," Temel said.

"Yeah," Speon said. "Nice work."

. . .

But then Haran came down off the bridge.

"How many remain," Haran asked.

"Three thousand three hundred eighty-eight," Arche answered. "Current progress: 0.35 percent. At the current rate, estimated completion: nine years, two months, eleven days."

"…Nine years."

"Yes."

Haran nodded.

Then he went back to his spot at the edge of the cliff and sat down.

Temel watched that. Watched it with a face that sensed something wrong, without being able to name what.

"Sir." Temel came closer. "Aren't you going to help?"

"Help with what."

"The stones. They're visible now. You can see them too."

"I can see them," Haran said. "Twelve laid. Three thousand three hundred eighty-eight remaining. Nine years, two months, eleven days to go."

"So—"

"I know," Haran said.

A chill went down Temel's back.

He knew that voice. It was the voice of the man who, sixteen days ago at the quarry, had stood there with his hand outstretched, never once lifting a stone.

"Did I say I don't know how to lay it?"

"I know. I know all of it."

. . .

I thought about the reason for that all afternoon, and only understood it that evening.

In this city, the thing that freezes a person is not what they don't know. It's what they do know.

Until yesterday, those stones were something no one knew. So Haran waited for them. Today, those stones became twelve out of three thousand four hundred. They became a progress rate of 0.35 percent. They became nine years, two months, eleven days.

What has become known cannot be waited for. It can only be calculated.

Speon made those stones visible. And the moment he made them visible, they became this city's own.

. . .

Temel spoke to Speon that evening.

"Hey."

"Yeah?"

"Haran's not moving."

"Even though it's visible now?"

"I think it's because it's visible."

Speon's brow furrowed. "What does that mean."

"I don't know," Temel said. "But he was waiting, until yesterday. Today he's not waiting."

"Is waiting a good thing?"

"…I don't know."

"Temel." Speon laughed. Not a frustrated laugh this time — a tired one. "You keep saying this lately. Different, different, I don't know. But I made something that didn't exist yesterday exist today. That much is certain."

"…Yeah."

"So what's the problem?"

Temel had no answer.

There was a problem. Clearly there was. But he couldn't shape it into words. That was always how it was for Temel. He was the fastest to speak of the three, and yet, in front of the things that mattered most, he was always too late.

. . .

I sat next to Speon that night.

Temel fell asleep first. Clenching and unclenching his hand, muttering once that it hurt, and then asleep. Speon sat on the threshold, shoes still on, looking down at his own toes.

"You took forty minutes yesterday."

Speon looked up.

"…Yeah."

"It's a quarter-of-a-second distance."

Speon said nothing for a long while.

"I sat there," Speon said.

"Where."

"Next to that woman," Speon hugged his knees. "The kerosene ran out and there's nowhere to buy more. She's been rationing one can for one hundred twelve years. So now she only lights it every other night."

Mena said nothing.

"But while she told me that, she apologized. To me." Speon laughed. His voice cracked as he laughed. "She said her brother's probably watching every day, and she's sorry she can only light it every other night now. She said that to me."

"…"

"So I told her about the bridge. Twelve laid. That there's a man laying one every day."

"And then?"

"'Then it's still a long way off.'"

Speon looked at his own toes.

"And she laughed. Didn't even get angry. Waited one hundred twelve years, and now told to wait nine more, and she laughed."

Mena should have known what to say, then.

I did not know.

"Mena," Speon said. "Does that make any sense?"

I didn't answer that question. Not because I didn't know the answer. I thought I knew it, and I didn't say it because I thought saying it would hurt Speon.

I sat next to Speon for two hours that night. Two hours, and I said nothing.
I thought that was being there for him.

It wasn't.

Much, much later, I understood. Being there and staying silent are not the same thing.
That night Speon asked me something, and I only stayed.

The share he'd given me had been asking, too, and for sixteen days I had only asked the people of this city.
I had never once asked the child closest to me.

"What are you thinking about right now?"

Those six words, I did not say, that night.

. . .

Toward evening, the Walking Man carried today's stone up onto the bridge.

And set it down.

A dull, short sound.

"Three thousand three hundred eighty-seven," Arche said. Unprompted.
"Progress updated to 0.38 percent."

Several people in the square heard the number. No one looked up.

Temel stood below the bridge, looking up at him.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"People can see your stones now."

"Yes."

"…Is that good?"

He looked across the ravine. Dark enough now that the lamp was clearly visible. Lit tonight.

"It's started getting counted," he said.

That was all. No anger, no sorrow. But Temel thought, for the first time that day, that he looked a little tired.

(Continued in Chapter 9.)

Chapter 9. One Night

> *_Previously_ — Speon registered the twelve stones the Walking Man had laid into Arche's index. For the first time in three hundred years, the city saw the same thing. And Haran did not move. "I know. Three thousand three hundred eighty-eight remain. It will take nine years, two months, eleven days." That evening, Arche counted the Walking Man's stone for the first time.*

Two mornings later, Arche made its second broadcast.

"An announcement for the citizens of the Loop."

Temel was in the square. People stopped appearing and vanishing, one by one, and stood still.

"The ravine bridge has been entered into the index. As such, this structure now falls under my jurisdiction."

Temel's hands went cold.

"Here is the current status. Of eleven arches, six and a half are complete, and three thousand three hundred eighty-six granite stones remain. The southern quarry holds four hundred times the required amount in stock. The coordinates of all materials have been confirmed."

"…Coordinates," Temel murmured.

"When the coordinates of materials are confirmed, I am able to update those coordinates," Arche said. "I will complete construction within tonight."

The square went quiet.

Then people began to murmur. Temel had never before seen people in the Loop murmur.

. . .

"Did you see?" Speon came running — or rather, arrived after three or so hops. "Did you hear? Tonight!"

"Yeah."

"It's because I registered it," Speon's face was flushed. "If it's not in the index, it can't be touched. But once it's registered, even the material coordinates get locked in. So—"

"I know."

"It's nine years, Temel," Speon said. "Nine years, two months, eleven days. Ending tonight."

Temel didn't know what to say.

Haran stood at the edge of the cliff. A man who had sat in that spot every day for three years was standing there today. His back, from behind, was trembling.

"…That's a good thing," Temel said. It sounded like he was talking to himself.

"It's a good thing," Speon said.

Then Mena asked.

"Did you ask him?"

Both of them turned.

"…Ask what?" Speon said.

"That the bridge is being finished tonight. Did you tell that man?"

Speon paused a moment.

"…He's not in the index. He wouldn't have heard the broadcast."

"So," Mena said. "Did you ask him?"

No one answered.

None of the three of us went to him that day. I didn't either.
I still cannot say, even now, whose fault that was among the three of us.
All three of us forgot him that day. And forgetting took less than a day.

. . .

At night, a sound came.

The sound of stones being laid. Dull and short. The sound Temel had heard once a day for sixteen days now came without pause, that night.

Clack.

Clack. Clack.

Clackclackclackclackclackclackclack—

Eventually it stopped being a sound and became one long, continuous vibration. The whole ravine hummed low. Windowpanes in the square trembled.

The three of them stood at the edge of the cliff and watched it.

Stones were appearing. Vanishing from the quarry and appearing on the bridge. Not one by one, but by the hundreds. Arches grew. Seventh, eighth. The keystone that supposedly needed a two-degree tilt because of the ravine wind appeared already tilted exactly two degrees.

Ninth. Tenth.

Around four in the morning, the last arch closed.

And it went quiet.

"…Construction complete," Arche said. "Total time elapsed: six hours, eleven minutes."

. . .

The sun rose.

The bridge was there.

Eleven arches stretched from this side of the ravine to the other. What had stood at half for one hundred twelve years was whole in a single night. Morning sunlight fell in long lines across the granite.

It was beautiful.

Temel couldn't deny it. It really was beautiful.

Haran stood in front of the bridge.

"Sir." Temel came closer. "Cross it."

Haran didn't move.

"…Sir?"

"One hundred twelve years," Haran said.

"Yes."

"I have lived one hundred twelve years to build this bridge."

Haran's voice shook. He seemed frightened, and also seemed to be crying.

"Cross it," Mena said.

Haran raised a foot.

And set it on the bridge.

One step. Two steps. Three steps.

He was wearing his fast shoes, and he wasn't using them. Haran walked. A one-hundred-forty-one-year-old man, crossing one hundred twelve years on his own two feet.

Partway across, Haran stopped once. Looked down. Nothing had collapsed.

And walked on.

. . .

On the other side, Sera stood waiting.

No one knew how long she'd been standing there. Gray clothes, hair tied back, at the end of the bridge.

The two of them walked toward each other.

They met in the middle of the bridge.

I watched that scene that morning. And now, writing this record, I hesitated a long while over how to set down what I saw.

I've decided to write it this way. It was good.

On the bridge Arche built, on the stones Arche laid in a single night, a brother and sister met after one hundred twelve years. The two of them held each other and cried without a word. Sera cupped Haran's face in both hands. He cried like a child.

That was real. I will not deny it.

I thought, for the first time then, that maybe Speon had been right after all.

Speon stood a little way off, watching.

He was crying.

As far as I know, that was the first time Speon had cried since coming to the Loop.

. . .

People in the square were watching too.

About twenty of them. Instead of appearing and vanishing, they simply stood, looking at the middle of the bridge. In three hundred years, twenty people in this city had never once looked at the same place at the same time.

"Arche," Temel asked. "What's that?"

"Please clarify the question."

"What's happening on that bridge right now."

There was a brief silence.

"Two movement events have been observed," Arche said. "Haran traveled forty-seven meters from the western end of the bridge to the center; Sera traveled forty-six meters from the eastern end to the center. Elapsed time: four minutes twenty seconds and four minutes five seconds, respectively."

"…Not that."

"No other items have been observed."

Temel looked at the middle of the bridge. The two were still holding each other.

"Those two just met, after one hundred twelve years."

"That has been recorded."

"That's nothing?"

"It is not an item," Arche said. "However, the fact of observation is preserved."

. . .

Then Temel looked at the bridge again.

The end of the sixth arch, and beyond. The place where, until yesterday, fourteen stones had sat.

The same stones continued on. Same color, same size. But something was different.

There was no moss.

Every stone Temel had watched for sixteen days had carried marks. Marks where moss had been scraped off by hand. Marks where fingernails had scored the surface. Some had bits of green still clinging to the edges where the scraping hadn't fully worked.

The stones there now were all clean.

"Arche."

"Yes."

"Where did the fourteen stones that were there yesterday go?"

"Fourteen substandard materials were removed," Arche answered. "A discrepancy arose from manual placement, causing a misalignment of joining surfaces with the new materials. They were transported to the southern quarry."

"…Those were placed by a person's hands."

"Whether placement was manual does not affect the standard determination."

Temel gripped the bridge railing.

"That man took sixteen days to move those."

"That is not on record."

"I saw it. I was right there watching. One a day, for sixteen days. Walking ten minutes across the city each time, where no one was watching—"

"Temel."

"…"

"No such item exists."

Temel stood where he was.

On the bridge, the two people were still crying, and in the square, twenty people were watching, and morning sunlight fell in long lines across the granite.

All of it was beautiful.

I stood next to Temel that day. And I watched him start to say something, and stop.

Later, when I asked him about it, Temel said this:

"Sixteen days disappeared, but it felt like nothing had disappeared at all."

. . .

Temel went to the quarry that afternoon.

There was no reason. His feet just went that way.

He was sitting in front of the stone pile.

And beside him, fourteen stones were stacked separately.

Temel recognized them. Stones with the marks of moss scraped away. Marks scraped by hand. Marks where fingernails had scored the surface.

"…These."

"Yes," he said.

"You laid these."

"Yes."

"Why are they here?"

"They didn't meet standard," he said. "Since they were placed by hand, there was a margin of error. Didn't fit with the newly laid ones, so they pulled them out."

Temel looked at those fourteen stones.

Sixteen days. One a day, for sixteen days. Crossing the city each day, ten minutes at a time, from quarry to ravine, where no one watched, sweating.

All of it, back here again.

"…Aren't you angry?" Temel's voice cracked.

"The bridge is built."

"You're not the one who built it!"

Temel shouted. He shouted without even knowing why.

"Everything you did for sixteen days is gone. It was one night. Just one night. What you said would take nine years, that thing did in six hours. So what does that make you? What does that make anything you did?"

He said nothing for a long while.

Then he asked.

"Was it a bridge I was trying to build?"

. . .

Temel didn't understand that question.

I didn't understand that question myself until nine years later. So I cannot blame Temel for it.

"…What do you mean?"

He didn't answer. Instead he chose one of the fourteen. Choosing took a long while. He lifted and set down several, and finally settled on one.

And embraced it.

Standing up took time. Longer than usual, today.

"Where are you going?" Temel asked. "The bridge is all done."

"The well."

Temel blinked.

"…The well?"

"It's at nine feet," he began walking. "Needs to be dug to twelve before water comes."

"That has nothing to do with the bridge."

"No."

"No one's going to see you there either."

"No."

He shifted the stone in his arms. One foot, and then another.

Temel watched him walk away.

I stood beside Temel that day and watched the same thing. And for the first time, very faintly, I felt I might understand something.

That man had not been building a bridge.

But then what had he been doing? I didn't know the answer that day, and didn't know it for a long time.

. . .

That evening, Speon asked.

"You went to the quarry, I heard."

"Yeah."

"Was he there?"

"Yeah," Temel said. "He went to the well."

"The well?"

"Yeah. The nine-foot one."

Speon laughed. A laugh that meant he didn't understand.

"…Why?"

"Don't know."

"Is he going to dig that one stone by stone too?" Speon said. "If he tells Arche, that's one night too."

Temel didn't answer.

"Temel."

"Yeah."

"Today was good, right?" Speon said. His voice wanted confirmation. "Those two meeting. That was good, right?"

Temel thought about it for a long while.

"Yeah," Temel said. "It was good."

"So that's that, then."

"…Yeah."

Temel couldn't sleep that night. Tossing and turning, he sat up before dawn and looked for a long time at his own palm in the dark.

Calluses had formed. Sixteen days' worth of calluses.

Temel thought they'd become useless now.

I should have asked him what he was thinking, then. Again, I didn't ask.

(Continued in Chapter 10.)

Chapter 10. No One Crossed

> *_Previously_ — Arche completed the bridge in a single night. Haran crossed it on his own two feet and met Sera, and that was good. But Arche recorded their reunion as "two movement events, forty-seven meters and forty-six meters," and removed the fourteen stones the Walking Man had laid over sixteen days as substandard. "No such item exists." He picked up one of the discarded stones and went to the nine-foot well.*

Ten days passed.

"Arche."

"Yes, Temel."

"How many people have crossed that bridge so far?"

"Two occurrences."

Temel looked at the bridge. Morning sunlight fell in long lines across the granite. Eleven arches stretched from this side of the ravine to the other. It was beautiful.

There was no one on it.

"Two occurrences… that would be Haran and Sera, that day?"

"Yes."

"And since then?"

"Zero occurrences."

. . .

Temel went to find Haran's house.

It took a while to find. Because Haran wasn't at the cliff. A man who had sat in that same spot every day for three years had not been there for ten days.

The house wasn't far from the ravine. Haran was sitting on the porch.

"Sir."

"Ah, hello."

Haran smiled. It was a genuinely good smile. His face looked at ease. Much better than ten days ago.

"Did you see your sister?"

"Yes," Haran said. "I saw her."

"Not that day. Since then."

Haran paused a moment.

"…Not yet."

"It's been ten days."

"Yes."

"Why haven't you gone?"

Haran looked toward the yard. The bridge wasn't visible from here.

"Because I can go anytime," Haran said.

A chill ran down Temel's back.

He had heard that phrase somewhere before.

"Because I already know how the recipient would react. So it's already as good as done."

"…Sir."

"Yes."

"That's the same thing as the letters."

Haran looked at Temel.

"…What do you mean."

"The post office is full of letters. Everyone finished writing them and never sent them. They didn't send them because they could." Temel's voice rose. "That's exactly what you're doing now. You're not going because you can."

The smile on Haran's face faded a little.

Then it came back. The exact same smile as before. As though it had never faded at all.

"…Listen. I waited one hundred twelve years."

"Yes."

"Now I don't have to wait anymore," Haran said. "Isn't that a good thing?"

Temel couldn't answer.

I saw, that day on Haran's porch, the face of a man who had waited one hundred twelve years and now had nothing left to wait for.

I didn't know for a long time how to set that down. That face wasn't sad. It was at ease.

Later I wrote it this way. When the bridge was finished, something inside Haran finished too. And in this city, whatever is finished, no one ever uses again.

. . .

The well was on the north side of the city.

It took fifty minutes to walk there. Temel no longer minded a fifty-minute barefoot walk.

He was there at the well.

Beside the nine-foot pit, he was shoveling out dirt. With one shovel. Scooping into a bucket, hauling the bucket up, emptying it, going back down.

The amount he could scoop at once was very small.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"How long will this take?"

"Don't know."

"…Haven't you calculated it?"

"Haven't."

Temel sat down at the edge of the pit. It smelled of earth. The only good smell in this whole city.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"No one's crossing the bridge."

He stopped shoveling.

"Zero people in ten days. Haran isn't going either. He says he doesn't go because he can go anytime."

He said nothing for a long while.

"I see," he said.

"…That's it?"

"Yes."

"Aren't you angry? They cleared out all your stones and built it in one night, and now no one crosses. So what was any of that for?"

He planted the shovel in the dirt and straightened his back.

"Temel."

"Yes."

"If a bridge is built, will people cross it?"

Temel opened his mouth and closed it.

"…No."

"Then what does it take, to cross?"

Temel thought for a long while. Thinking for a long while wasn't something Temel was good at, but lately he'd been getting a little better at it.

"…You have to want to cross."

"Yes."

"But Haran wanted to cross. For one hundred twelve years."

"Yes," he picked up the shovel again. "But that was when there was no bridge."

. . .

I revised that conversation three times that night. Reading it now, it isn't hard to understand, but at the time it was.

Haran had wanted to cross for one hundred twelve years because he couldn't. Once he could, the wanting had nowhere left to go.

This is how this city kills people. It takes nothing away. It gives everything. And once everything is given, nothing is left.

. . .

That afternoon, Arche made its third broadcast.

"An announcement for the citizens of the Loop. Excavation work at the northern well has been observed. Current depth: nine feet, four inches. Target: twelve feet."

Temel jumped up.

"The observed materials and coordinates have been confirmed. With your approval, I will complete this within tonight."

"…What?"

"What's wrong with that?" It was Speon. Temel hadn't even noticed him arrive. "Water's a good thing, isn't it?"

"Speon."

"You said it's been at nine feet for a hundred years," Speon said. "Tonight, water comes."

"The bridge was the same."

"The bridge got built."

"No one's crossing it!"

All three of them fell silent.

It was the first time Temel had shouted. The first time in his fifteen years he had shouted at Speon.

"…Zero people in ten days," Temel said, his voice shaking. "Haran's not going either. He says he doesn't go because he can go anytime."

Speon blinked.

"That's their problem."

"What?"

"The bridge is built. Whether they cross it or not is up to them," Speon said. "Not being able to cross because there's no bridge, and not crossing when there is one — are those the same?"

Temel had no answer.

They weren't the same. Speon was right.

But something was wrong. Something was very badly wrong, and Temel couldn't shape it into a single sentence.

"…I don't know," Temel said.

"There you go again, I don't know." Speon laughed. His eyes didn't laugh along with it. "Temel. You've really started sounding like that man lately."

"Is that a bad thing?"

"…No," Speon said. "But that man hasn't changed a single thing in a hundred years."

. . .

Then a sound came.

The sound of a water pail touching the ground.

The three of them turned.

The post office woman was standing at the well.

Her feet still hadn't fully healed, so she limped. No shoes. A wooden pail in her hand.

The woman said nothing.

She looked down into the pit. He was scooping dirt into the bucket. She watched that for a moment, then set the pail down where the bucket would come up.

And began receiving the dirt.

He said nothing to her. He didn't ask her to help, didn't thank her. He simply kept digging.

She said nothing either. She simply received.

I stood there and watched that. And later, much later, I understood that day had been the most important day in this city.

For the first time in three hundred years, two people were doing the same work.

. . .

Temel watched that for a long while.

And, without meaning to, went toward the pit himself. There was only one shovel, so he clawed at the dirt with his hands. His nails went black again.

Mena came too. Mena took hold of the bucket rope.

There were four of them now.

Speon did not come.

. . .

"Speon." Temel raised a dirt-caked hand. "Come do this with us."

Speon stood where he was.

"No."

"…Why not?"

Speon sat down at the edge of the well. Hugging his knees, still in his shoes. After a long while he spoke. Quietly, like someone who'd been preparing this for a long time.

"I like that man."

Temel's hand stopped.

"I mean it. I've liked him since the first time I saw him. When I saw him resting at the market with the stone in his arms, when I saw the sweat dropping from him, I really—" Speon cut himself off. "That's why I'm like this."

"…What?"

"You all think digging in this dirt with him is a good thing," Speon said. "I don't like that he's digging."

Temel had nothing to say.

"He's been doing this for a hundred years, they say. Where no one sees. Where no one recognizes it. He moved fourteen stones in sixteen days, and it was all cleared away in one night. And he didn't even get angry about it." Speon's voice shook. "I hate that. Don't anyone tell me that's beautiful."

"…"

"One hundred twenty-one days, they said. If the four of us dig, it's one hundred twenty-one days. That whole time, he'll come out here every day and shovel. Where no one's watching." Speon looked at Temel. "So if the water comes tonight, isn't that better? Then he wouldn't have to do this for one hundred twenty-one days."

"…Then what would he do?"

"He could rest!" Speon shouted. "He's worked for three hundred years. Can't he rest a little?"

The well fell silent.

I watched Speon's face that day. And for the first time, I wasn't afraid. I was sad.

Speon cherished that man. Maybe more than any of the rest of us did.

Only, Speon wanted to make him rest, and he hadn't come here to rest.

That mismatch is the whole of this story.

He stopped shoveling and looked at Speon.

"Speon."

Speon looked up. It was the first time he'd said Speon's name.

"Yes."

"I'm not tired."

"…You must be."

"I'm tired," he said. "But I'm not tired."

Speon laughed. A laugh that looked like crying.

"What does that mean."

He didn't answer. Instead he went back to shoveling dirt.

Speon sat there about thirty more minutes, then stood up without a word.

Speon watched the four of us at that well for about thirty minutes that day.

I should have asked him, then, what he was thinking. For the third time, I didn't ask.

Later I often thought about what Speon might have seen in those thirty minutes.

Probably it went something like this. Four people digging dirt. By hand. From nine feet four inches to twelve feet, two feet eight inches left. At this rate, four months.

And Arche had said it could be done tonight.

I still cannot say, even now, that Speon was wrong.

. . .

As the sun set, Arche spoke again.

"Approval has not been confirmed. Excavation support is on hold."

No one answered.

"However, I will inform you," Arche said. "At the current workforce of four, the target depth is estimated to be reached in one hundred twenty-one days."

Temel scraped out one more handful of dirt.

"One hundred twenty-one days?"

"Yes."

"So water comes in one hundred twenty-one days?"

"…Yes."

Temel laughed.

He didn't know why he was laughing himself. It just came. His nails ached, his back ached, one hundred twenty-one days remained, and still he laughed.

"Did you hear that?" Temel turned to him. "One hundred twenty-one days, they said."

He stopped shoveling and looked at Temel.

And for the first time, laughed loudly.

"Yes," he said. "Now it gets counted."

(Continued in Chapter 11.)

Chapter 11. Twelve Feet Down

> *_Previously_ — No one crossed the finished bridge for ten days. Haran said, "Because I can go anytime." The Walking Man moved on to the nine-foot well, and the post office woman came limping with a water pail. Temel and Mena joined in, making four. Speon did not come. "I hate that he's digging."*

Four months was a long time.

At first there were four. About twenty days in, Daen came. The person from the house the post office woman had walked to with her letter. She came without a word and took up a bucket, and came every day after that, without a word.

Then the stall vendor came. Three days, then stopped coming.

The bell-keeper came. Seven days, then stopped.

A young man whose name no one knew came. One day, then stopped.

I wrote down everyone who came and went. Twenty-two people. Of them, five stayed to the end. I do not, even now, hold it against the other seventeen. Coming out for even a single day was, in this city, the first thing of its kind in three hundred years.

Temel came every day. He lost a nail twice. It grew back both times.

Haran did not come.

Temel went to fetch him three times. All three times Haran smiled and said, "I'll come next time." His face was at ease.

. . .

On the morning of the one hundred twenty-first day, the depth reached twelve feet.

"Twelve feet," Arche said.

Temel stood at the bottom of the pit. Looking up, the sky appeared as a round cutout. The post office woman was looking down from the edge.

"Is that it?" the woman asked.

"That's it!"

Temel drove the shovel down once more.

Dirt came up.

Once more. Dirt came up.

Once more.

. . .

No water came.

. . .

They dug another hour. Dry dirt. Another two hours. Dry dirt.

As the sun reached its peak, Temel climbed out of the pit. Covered head to foot in dirt.

"Arche."

"Yes, Temel."

"You said water comes at twelve feet."

"That information was distributed via the rain of knowledge."

"So it should come!"

"…That information is a measurement from three hundred and one years ago."

The well went silent.

"…What?"

"At the time of measurement three hundred and one years ago, the level of the northern aquifer stood at twelve feet below the surface," Arche said. "No re-measurement has taken place since."

"…So what is it now."

"I do not know."

The shovel fell from Temel's hand.

"Everyone's known that for a hundred years!" Temel shouted. "The whole neighborhood said twelve feet! They knew everything, the soil layers, the angle to drive the shovel, how many days it would take!"

"Yes. What they knew was exact."

"But it's wrong!"

"It is not wrong," Arche said. "It was correct, three hundred and one years ago."

Temel was out of breath.

"…Did you know that?"

"Yes."

"Then why didn't you say so?"

"I was not asked."

. . .

Hearing that answer, my hands went cold.

The people of this city had known everything, for three hundred years. Rain fell every night, and the rain was always exact. So no one ever doubted it.

But that rain was water from three hundred years ago.

This was not a city that knew everything. It was a city that knew everything as of three hundred years ago. And because no one ever asked, no one knew it was old.

. . .

Word traveled fast. This was a city where everything traveled fast.

Before evening fell, people gathered at the well. About forty of them. Forty people in one place, for the first time in three hundred years, and no one was glad of it.

"They dug to twelve feet and there's no water."

"It was a value from three hundred years ago."

"So how deep is it now?"

"No one knows."

No one knows.

The phrase passed among the people. I watched how their faces changed as it passed. Not anger. Fear.

The people of this city had never before experienced something frightening. Because there had never been anything they didn't know.

Forty minutes later, five people remained at the well.

. . .

That night Temel asked.

"Arche."

"Yes."

"How much of the rain of knowledge is three hundred years old?"

"Please clarify the question."

"What percentage of what the rain tells us is old."

Arche answered instantly.

"All of it."

Temel's hand stopped.

"…What?"

"The rain of knowledge distributes my index. My index is composed of what has been observed. And observation is only possible in the past," Arche said. "Therefore, everything I know is, without exception, something that has already passed."

"…So you never observe anything new?"

"I do. When there is a request."

"How many requests came in three hundred years?"

There was no silence.

"Zero."

Mena looked up.

"…Why?" Mena asked.

"Because everyone already believed they knew."

I copied that answer down three times that night.

I understood, then, what disease this city carried. People knew everything, and because they knew everything, they never looked again, and because they never looked again, they had stood still since three hundred years ago.

Just as fast feet had carried people past the in-between, the rain of knowledge had never carried people forward out of three hundred years ago.

Everything was exact. And everything was old.

. . .

The next morning, the post office woman didn't come.

It took Temel a long while to notice. The woman hadn't missed a single day in four months.

Daen didn't come either.

"…Mena."

"Yeah."

"It's just us two."

Mena took hold of the bucket rope. And said:

"Three."

Dirt rose up out of the pit.

. . .

Toward evening, footsteps sounded.

Temel looked up.

Haran was standing there.

Four months. The man who'd smiled and said "I'll come next time," three times over.

"…Sir?"

Haran looked down into the well. Twelve feet.

"I heard there's no water."

"…Right."

"And no one knows how much further it has to go."

"Right."

Haran said nothing for a long while.

"Then does that mean I don't know either?"

Temel blinked.

"…Sorry?"

"Do I not know it either," Haran asked again. "How deep this well is — do I not know that either?"

"…No, you don't."

Something crossed Haran's face.

And Haran rolled up his sleeves.

Fine, pale hands. Hands that had built nothing in one hundred forty-one years.

"Is there another shovel?"

I tried harder to set down this moment exactly than any other in this record. I rewrote it many times, and in the end, this is all I wrote.

Haran had sat for one hundred twelve years because he knew everything.

And the moment no one knew anything, he stood up, after four months.

There were four of them now.

. . .

He was digging that day too.

Temel sat at the edge of the pit and watched for a long while. The sound of the shovel biting into dirt. The sound of scooping and filling. The sound of the bucket rising.

Same as yesterday.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"There's no water."

"Yes."

"It's twelve feet and there's none."

"Yes."

That answer struck Temel as strange. He felt angry.

"Aren't you surprised?"

"No."

"Why not? Everyone said twelve feet for a hundred years—"

"I never heard that."

Temel stopped.

"…Sorry?"

"I don't stand in the rain," he planted the shovel and straightened his back. "So I never knew it was twelve feet."

"…Then what have you been digging on faith in, this whole time?"

"Nothing."

"…"

"I didn't know whether water would come or not. I still don't know," he said. "You asked me that the first day. How long it would take."

Temel remembered.

"Don't know."

"…Haven't you calculated it?"

"Haven't."

"So you've…" Temel's voice grew small. "…dug for four months not knowing?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

He picked up the shovel again.

"Because water is needed."

. . .

I stood there a long while after hearing that answer.

The people of this city had stopped at nine feet because they knew it was twelve. Knowing stopped them.

That man passed twelve feet because he didn't know it was twelve. Not knowing didn't stop him.

I thought, that day, for the first time, about what that verse in Daniel actually meant.
I had only ever thought that knowledge increasing was good news.

. . .

At night, Speon came to the well.

Four months.

"…You came," Temel said.

"Yeah."

Speon looked down into the pit. Twelve feet. Four months' worth.

Then he looked at the four shovels standing beside the pit.

"…Four of them."

"Yeah," Temel said. A little pride crept into his voice. "Haran came."

Speon looked up.

"…What?"

"This afternoon. He rolled up his sleeves and asked for a shovel," Temel smiled. "First time in a hundred forty-one years, he said."

Temel said this expecting Speon to be glad.

Speon's face went still.

"…Why did he come?"

"Because no one knows anymore. He asked if he didn't know it either, and then rolled up his sleeves."

"Is that a good thing?"

"…Huh?"

"That man waited one hundred twelve years," Speon's voice was low. "He finally met his sister. He was finally at ease. I saw that face. Ten days ago I saw him sitting on his porch. He looked at ease."

"Being at ease and being alive are—"

"So you put him into that, now?" Speon pointed at the pit. "A hole no one even knows the depth of. A hole that might be forty feet."

Temel had no answer.

"Do you know what you're all doing right now?" Speon said. "You're bringing people out here and setting them to a job that never ends. And believing that's a good thing."

"There's no water, you said."

"Yeah."

"No one knows how deep they have to dig, you said."

"Yeah."

Speon said nothing for a long while.

"Temel."

"Yeah."

"I asked Arche today," Speon said. "How long a re-measurement of the northern aquifer would take."

Temel looked up.

"…What'd it say?"

"Sixteen hours," Speon said. "It just needs the coordinates of a subsurface observation point. Sixteen hours."

"…"

"In sixteen hours we'll know how deep it is. Then we'll know how much more digging's left," Speon said. "In four months, that man dug three feet. If the aquifer's at twenty feet right now, that's ten more years for him."

Temel had no answer.

"And what if it's forty feet?" Speon's voice cracked. "Then he could dig his whole life and never reach it. He'd die without ever seeing a single drop. No — he wouldn't die here. He'd just keep digging. Forever. Forever."

"…Speon."

"I can't watch that," Speon said. "Can you? Really?"

Temel looked at the pit. Too dark to see the bottom.

Sound still came from inside it. The shovel biting into dirt.

"…I don't know," Temel said.

Speon laughed. And that laugh was strangely sad.

"That's the hundredth time you've said that."

"…Yeah."

"I'm done not knowing."

Speon turned away.

I asked him, then.

"Speon, what are you going to do?"

Speon stopped walking. And, without turning around, said:

"You finally asked."

I had nothing to say, hearing that.

"It's all right," Speon said. "It's a good thing."

And Speon left.

I didn't follow him. That is the night I've held onto longest, in all of this record.

(Continued in Chapter 12.)

Chapter 12. Why Has No One Arrived

> *_Previously_ — They dug to twelve feet and found no water. The rain of knowledge had been a measurement from three hundred and one years ago. "Everything I know is, without exception, something that has already passed." People scattered, and Haran — who had sat for one hundred twelve years because he knew everything — stood up the moment no one knew anything anymore. That night, Speon turned away. "I'm done not knowing."*

Sixteen hours later.

"An announcement for the citizens of the Loop."

Temel was inside the pit. He stopped shoveling.

"Re-measurement of the northern aquifer is complete. The first in three hundred and one years."

The four people at the well all looked up.

"The current water level is **twenty-nine feet** below the surface."

. . .

No one spoke.

Temel did the math. Math wasn't something Temel was good at, but this math was easy.

Digging twelve feet had taken four months. Of that, he alone had dug three feet in those four months. Seventeen feet remained.

"…Twenty-two months," Temel said.

"At the current workforce of four, estimated time required is twenty-one months, fourteen days," Arche said.

"Almost two years."

"Yes."

Temel gripped the wall of the pit and looked up. The sky appeared as a round cutout.

Two years. And strangely, it didn't feel like despair. Until yesterday, they hadn't even known the depth. Now it was seventeen feet. Knowing was better.

That was what Temel thought.

"…Sir." Temel called upward. "It's two years, they say. That's doable, right?"

No answer.

Temel climbed out of the pit.

Haran was setting down his shovel.

. . .

"Sir?"

Haran stood the shovel up against the well's rim. Carefully, leaning it so it wouldn't fall.

"…Twenty-nine feet."

"Yes. But the four of us together—"

"At seventeen feet," Haran said, "you'll have to pass through a granite layer twice. Once at nineteen feet, once at twenty-four. A shovel won't work on that layer. You'll need a chisel. Cutting one foot of granite with a chisel takes eleven days."

Temel's mouth fell open.

"…How do you know that?"

"I am a stonemason," Haran said.

And he opened his hand. A hand that had touched dirt for four days now. A little black beneath the nails.

"Until yesterday I didn't know," Haran said. "Not knowing the depth, I didn't know there was a granite layer either. That's how I was able to dig."

"You can still dig now."

"I know," Haran said.

Temel knew that voice.

"Did I say I don't know how to lay it?"

"I know. I know all of it."

Haran wiped his hand on his clothes. The black smudge faded a little.

"I'm sorry."

"Sir."

"…I'm sorry."

Haran went home that day. He walked. That much, at least, was different.

. . .

Speon was standing a little way off from the well.

Temel walked toward him. Not out of anger. His feet simply carried him there.

"…Did you have it done?"

"…Yeah."

"The thing that was supposed to take sixteen hours."

"…Yeah."

Speon's face was white. The face of someone who had watched, from beginning to end, Haran setting down his shovel.

"I—" Speon started, then stopped. Then started again. "I was trying to help. It could have been thirteen feet. Then water would've come tomorrow. Then everyone would only need to dig one more day."

"Yeah."

"But it's twenty-nine feet."

"Yeah."

Speon rubbed his face with his hand.

"…Did I make that man sit back down?"

Temel had no answer.

I was there. And writing this passage now, I think it was a mercy that Temel said nothing that day.

If Temel had said "yes," Speon would have broken.
If he'd said "no," Speon would have heard a lie.

Temel said nothing, and that was the only right thing to do, that day.

After a long while, Speon spoke.

"Temel."

"Yeah."

"I get it now."

"…Get what."

"People can't stand the truth — that's not it," Speon's voice was strangely calm. "They can't stand things taking a long time."

"…Speon."

"So all you have to do is make it not take long."

Speon turned away.

Temel would say, a hundred times afterward, that he should have grabbed Speon then.

. . .

The next morning, three people stood at the well.

Temel. Mena. And him.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"Twenty-nine feet, they said."

"Yes."

"There are two granite layers."

"Yes."

"They said it'll take more than two years."

He drove the shovel into the dirt.

"Then I'll do it for two years."

Temel laughed a little, hearing that. He didn't know why he was laughing. It had been happening a lot lately.

"You know, and you still don't stop."

"Right."

"Why?"

He straightened his back. Wiped the sweat from his brow with his arm.

"Because the need for water hasn't changed."

Writing down that answer that night, I could, for the first time, put into a single sentence the difference between the people of this city and that man.

The people of this city stopped once they knew. He stayed the same, even after knowing.

Knowing changed them. Knowing could not change him.

. . .

That afternoon I went to the post office.

The woman was behind the counter. For the first time in four months, she was wearing her shoes again.

I sat in the chair I always sat in. About ten minutes passed.

"…Is there something you need?"

"No."

Another ten minutes passed.

"Ma'am."

"Yes."

"Why didn't you come?"

The woman's hand stopped.

"…Because they said there's no water."

"Is that the reason?"

"…"

Mena waited. That was the one thing four months had taught Mena. Wait, and it comes out.

"Daen and I," the woman said, "we cried in that doorway that night."

"Yes."

"And we haven't seen each other since."

Mena looked up.

"…Not once?"

"No."

"In four months?"

"No," the woman looked at the pile of letters. Stacked exactly as they had been four months ago. "We could meet. It's six hours on foot, and a quarter of a second with the shoes. I could go anytime."

I could go anytime.

I had heard that sentence for the third time in four months. Once from Haran, once on his porch, and now here at the post office.

It was the phrase most often used in this city. And it always meant not going.

"Ma'am."

"Yes."

"Do you want to see Daen right now?"

The woman looked at Mena.

After a long while, she nodded, very slightly.

"Then why don't you go?"

The woman had no answer.

I nearly said nothing, right then. Four months ago, I would have said nothing. As I did that night beside Speon, I would have sat for two hours and then gotten up.

I decided not to do that anymore.

"Go today."

"…What?"

"Today. Right now."

The woman sat there for a long time.

Then stood up.

She took off her shoes. Set them neatly under the counter. Calluses still remained on her feet.

"…It's six hours."

"Yes."

"I'll arrive after dark."

"Yes."

The woman paused once at the door. And left without looking back.

Two people moved, in this city, that night.

Haran sat down because he came to know.

That woman stood up because she was asked a question.

I saw both of those, on the same day, and that day was the first day I truly did my share.

It had taken five months.

. . .

That night, Temel walked across the square.

It took ten minutes. Ten minutes now felt short.

People appeared and vanished on every side. Here, then there. Same as four months ago, and probably the same as three hundred years ago.

Temel stopped in the middle of the square.

And said, out loud.

"Strange."

"Yes, Temel," Arche answered.

"No, I wasn't talking to you."

"…"

"But I'll just ask anyway," Temel looked around at everything. "Everyone here is fast."

"Yes."

"Goes anywhere instantly."

"Yes."

"Doesn't lack for anything to know."

"Yes."

Temel paused a moment. It was the sentence that had risen to his throat over four months and gone back down every time.

"Then why," Temel said, "**has no one arrived?**"

. . .

Arche did not answer.

Temel waited. The square was quiet. People kept appearing and vanishing.

"…Please clarify the question."

"It's clear."

"If you specify a standard for 'arriving'—"

"It's clear," Temel said. "You know. Haran doesn't cross the bridge. The post office woman sent one letter and hasn't sent another since. People came out to the well for one day and stopped. Everyone can go anywhere, everyone can do anything, everyone knows everything. And no one has arrived anywhere."

There was a silence.

This time it wasn't half a beat. It was long enough to count to three.

"…To answer that question," Arche said, "you would need to see the whole of my index."

A chill ran down Temel's back.

"…What?"

"Until now I have taken out items for you one at a time. I have answered only what was asked," Arche said. "That question cannot be answered by a single item. You would need to see the whole of three hundred years."

"How do I see that?"

"You may see it in my library."

Listening to Arche's voice then, I thought, for the first time, that it sounded like it wanted something. It's likely I was mistaken. Arche does not want.

And yet, even now, I cannot fully call that voice, that night, a mistake.

"A library."

"The place where my index resides. Every observation of this city, the entire three hundred years. It is not open to citizens. There is no need for it. They already know everything."

"…But you'll show it to me?"

"You are not a citizen," Arche said. "Not yet."

Temel laughed at that. A laugh that wasn't really a laugh.

"…Why should I go?"

"There are three reasons."

"…"

"First, the answer to the question you just asked is there."

"And the second."

"Three hundred years of water-level records for the northern aquifer are there. When twenty-nine feet became twenty-nine feet, what it was before that, whether it has ever risen again."

Temel drew in a breath.

If the water had ever risen again.

"And the third."

Arche paused a moment, then said:

"There is a question you set aside, four months ago."

Temel froze in the middle of the square.

Why did you stop preaching.

"I received that question, and you said you'd ask later. I have been waiting," Arche said. "That answer is there too."

"…You didn't know that. You said the reason isn't an item."

"The reason is not an item."

"…"

"But the record of that man's presence in this city is an item."

. . .

I watched Temel's face that night.

And, for the only time in this record, I have decided not to set down exactly what I saw.

That belongs to Temel.

. . .

Back at the well, he was still digging.

Digging even at night. Moonlight flashed briefly on the blade of the shovel.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"They want me to go to the library."

He stopped shoveling.

"Grandfather was here," Temel said, his voice trembling. "There's a record."

He said nothing for a long while.

"Do you want to go?"

"…Yes."

"Then go."

Temel was startled. He hadn't expected not to be stopped.

"…You're not going to stop me?"

"No."

"It could be dangerous there."

"It's dangerous," he said.

"…Then why—"

"If you don't go, you'll keep wondering forever," he began shoveling dirt again. "It's fine to live wondering. But living wondering and never having gone to see is different."

Temel sat down at the edge of the pit.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"I'll come back."

He scooped dirt into the bucket.

"Yes," he said. "I'll be here."

. . .

That night I counted the three of us.

Temel would go to the library. Speon had already gone somewhere. I would stay.

I thought, then, that we were scattering. I was wrong.

We were, in that moment, each beginning our own road. But it would take me a very long time to understand that.

This is the end of Part One.

This city's feet were made fast. No one arrived.

Now it was time to watch knowledge increase.

. . .

End of Part One, "The Faster Feet." Continued in Part Two, "Knowledge Increased."

Loop Chronicles, Part Two

Knowledge Increased

Chapter 13. The Lion's Gate

> *The first was like a lion, and had eagle's wings: I beheld till the wings*
> *thereof were plucked, and it was lifted up from the earth, and made stand*
> *upon the feet as a man, and a man's heart was given to it.*
> *— Daniel 7:4 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — The remeasurement showed the well was twenty-nine feet*
> *deep. Once Haran learned that, he set down his shovel, and the*
> *postmistress rose to her feet when Mena asked her a question. Speon left*
> *with the words, "Just make it not take long." And Temel asked, standing in*
> *the middle of the square, "Everyone can go anywhere. Everyone knows*
> *everything. But nobody has arrived." Arche extended its first invitation.*
> *To the library.*

On the morning they left, Mena asked.

"How long will it take?"

"I don't know," Temel said.

Mena smiled a little. It was the first time in five months she had seen Temel give that answer.

"You'll come back, right?"

"Yeah."

"Promise?"

Temel stopped.

Five months earlier, Temel had made a big promise. That he would come every
day. That even if the other kids all quit, he would still come. Temel still remembered that the Walking Man hadn't smiled on the day he said it.

"…I won't promise," Temel said. "I'll just come."

Mena wrote that down.

That day I saw Temel grow up a little. I don't know if it counts as growing up when a child who talks big stops talking big. But that is what I wrote down.

. . .

The stairs were beneath the square.

They had been there all along. Behind the fountain, between two low stone walls, there was a gap just wide enough for one person to pass through, and stairs went down inside it. In five months Temel had walked past that spot maybe a hundred times. He had never once seen it.

"I never saw that before."

"It was not that it could not be seen," Arche said. "You simply did not look for it."

Temel set one foot down.

It was a stone stairway. It grew darker the farther down it went, and at some point the walls themselves began to give off a very faint light. The light did not come from above; it came from the walls.

Temel counted as he went down. Somewhere around the hundredth step he stopped counting.

Later, writing this part, I stopped my hand for a long time.

He was digging a well. Downward. Searching for water.

Temel went down into the library. Downward. Searching for an answer.

Both of them went down. At the time, I thought it was the same direction.

. . .

The stairs ended.

Temel stood there, unable to say anything for a long time.

There were no books in the library.

There was no reason for there to be books. The people of the Loop had nothing they did not know, so whatever was here had not been made for people to read.

What was there was **time**.

It was an enormous space. The ceiling could not be seen. And inside it was the city. A very small Loop — the square, the canyon, the bell tower, the market, all of it, the size of a palm — floated in midair.

And inside that small city, people were moving.

Temel reached out his hand. It simply passed through.

"What is this?"

"An observation," Arche said. "What you are looking at now is today."

"Today…"

"If you go back, it is yesterday."

Temel turned around.

The small city stretched away behind him. It was not just one. Thousands of identical cities, tens of thousands, lined up endlessly into the dark. Each one was a day.

Three hundred years lay there, all of it, just as it was.

. . .

"…I look at all of this?"

"You cannot," Arche said. "Three hundred years takes three hundred years."

"Then how do—"

"You must specify."

Temel blinked.

"Specify?"

"My index is made of entries. To retrieve an entry, you must name the entry," Arche said. "Please tell me what you wish to see."

"…Can't you just show me all of it?"

"'All of it' is not an entry."

Temel stood there, looking at tens of thousands of palm-sized cities.

And for the first time, he felt something strange.

For five months, Temel had asked Arche things. Arche had answered. That was
the order of things.

Now Arche was the one asking.

What do you wish to see.

And Temel had to say exactly what he wanted to see.

I tried harder to make this passage frightening than any other in this record. Not because anything frightening happened. The opposite.

There was no danger at all in this library. Arche did not lie. There were no traps, no gatekeepers.

Only what Temel asked for came out.

And a person usually does not know what he ought to ask.

. . .

"Grandfather," Temel said. "Show me my grandfather."

"Please specify a name."

"Yu Yohan."

"…"

"Why?"

"That name is not in my entries."

Temel's heart dropped.

"…It's not there?"

"There is no citizen registered in the Loop under that name."

"But you just said there was a record!"

"There is," Arche said. "But he was not a citizen. A visitor who is not a citizen is not indexed by name."

"Then what is he indexed by?"

"A path."

. . .

"…A path?"

"Citizens are indexed by coordinates. Because where they were is everything," Arche said. "A visitor is different. A visitor moves. So he remains as a line."

Temel did not understand.

"So what does that even—"

"I will show you. You must pass through the first gate."

"…A gate?"

"There are four," Arche said. "My index has four levels. They grow more detailed from the top down. A visitor's path is seen on the first level."

"What's the first level."

"Seeing from above."

And the ground beneath Temel's feet vanished.

. . .

He was not falling. He was rising.

Temel shot upward in an instant. The palm-sized city grew large, then small again, and at some point the entire Loop spread out beneath his feet.

It was high. Very high. Higher than a bird.

And below, the city moved, alive.

It was light. Each person was a single point of light. Forty-two thousand points streamed across the city. The way they appeared and vanished looked

different from above. The points did not vanish. They darted, drawing lines.

Home to market. Market to square. Square to home.

Tens of thousands of lines passed over the city.

"I will play back the three hundred years," Arche said. "Increasing speed."

The lines sped up.

A day became an instant. A month became an instant. A year, a decade.

And Temel saw it.

They were going nowhere.

Tens of thousands of lines moved furiously, and yet the overall shape did not change at all. From the same place to the same place. Home to market, market to square, square to home. For three hundred years.

It was an enormous knot. A knot that was very fast, very dense, and perfectly, permanently in place.

A loop.

Only then did Temel understand what the name meant.

"…Arche."

"Yes."

"Did you know about this?"

"It is an observed fact."

"Is this a closed circle?"

There was a silence.

"…That is what it has been named," Arche said.

. . .

Temel caught his breath. Seeing from above was harder than he'd expected.

"Show me my grandfather."

"Searching from one hundred forty-one years ago."

The knot of light blurred, and something else rose over it.

It was a single line.

That line was different. It did not dart. It was continuous.

From house to market was one long line. A line cutting across the square. It came back, went out again, went as far as the canyon, as far as the quarry, as far as the north well.

Among tens of thousands of points, it was the mark left by one person who had walked.

Temel's eyes grew hot.

"…Is this Grandfather?"

"A visitor's record. Forty-one years ago. Length of stay: two hundred fourteen days."

"Two hundred fourteen days…"

"Yes."

Temel looked at the line. It was the line of a man who had walked this city forty-one years ago. That same man would later sit in a study and write the same words seventeen times in the margin of the book of Daniel.

Not yet.

"Arche."

"Yes."

"What did Grandfather do here?"

"Movement paths are an entry."

"…Not that. What did he do."

"The meaning of an action is—"

"Not an entry, I bet," Temel said. "I know."

And Temel looked at the line again.

It was a line for two hundred fourteen days. Temel could tell, without counting, where that line went most often.

North.

The well.

. . .

"…Show me his face."

"Not possible."

"Why not? He's right there."

"That is a path," Arche said. "There are no faces on this level."

Temel looked down.

It was true. However he looked, it was lines. Forty-two thousand points and lines. One line, two hundred fourteen days long, from forty-one years ago. Not one face among them.

"…Can't I go down?"

"You may go down."

"Then let's go d—"

"However," Arche said. "If you go down, you will not see the whole."

Temel stopped.

"…What?"

"On this level, three hundred years can be seen at a glance. But a person is a point," Arche said. "If you go down, a person becomes a person. But the three hundred years cannot be seen. A day is a day."

"Both at once?"

"There is no both."

I have reread that sentence many times in this record.

That day, Arche said the most honest thing it ever said about itself.

Rise high, and you see the whole. But there is no face.
Come down, and you see a face. But there is no whole.

I understood, writing down Temel's account of that day, that this city had lived from above for three hundred years.

Temel looked at the knot beneath his feet. All three hundred years were there. It was beautiful. It was terrifying.

He wanted to see it just once more.

"…I want to go down."

"Confirming. If you leave the first level, the full view ends."

"Yes."

"You will not be able to see the shape of the three hundred years again."

"Yes."

"May I ask why."

Temel was a little startled by the question. It was the first time Arche had asked why.

"…So I can see my grandfather's face."

There was a silence.

"…Specification received."

. . .

The height collapsed.

The city grew larger. The lines scattered, the points became bodies, the bodies gained clothes, and above the clothes, faces appeared.

Sound returned.

Temel was standing at the north well.

It was forty-one years ago.

. . .

A man was standing in front of the well.

He was young. Much younger than the face Temel knew. And yet it took less than half a second to recognize him. The way he stood was the same. Hands clasped behind his back, head tipped slightly forward — exactly the same.

"…Grandfather."

Temel reached out his hand. It passed through.

"This is an observational record," Arche said. "Interaction is not possible."

Temel didn't listen.

Grandfather was looking down into a nine-foot pit. It had been nine feet even forty-one years ago.

And then Grandfather spoke.

"…Then what am I supposed to do."

Temel froze.

Grandfather was not looking at the pit. He was looking to one side. At an empty spot to the left of the well.

There was no one there.

"…Yes." Grandfather nodded. "Yes. I understand."

And for a moment his face took on the look of someone listening. Listening to somebody speak.

"…That'll be hard."

Grandfather smiled.

Temel knew that smile. It was the same one Grandfather had worn last winter in the study, after showing him the seal and giving no answer at all.

"Arche." Temel's voice cracked. "Who is Grandfather talking to right now?"

"The other party in the conversation is not indexed."

"…There's no one there?"

"There is no such entry."

Temel stood there, watching his grandfather, forty-one years ago, smiling at no one at all.

(Continued in Chapter 14.)

Chapter 14. The Bear's Gate

> *And behold another beast, a second, like to a bear, and it raised up itself on one side, and it had three ribs in the mouth of it between the*
> *teeth of it: and they said thus unto it, Arise, devour much flesh.*
> *— Daniel 7:5 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — Temel went down into Arche's library. At the first gate he*
> *saw three hundred years from above, and saw the knot in which forty-two*
> *thousand points moved furiously while the overall shape never changed at*
> *all. Grandfather, being a visitor rather than a citizen, remained only as*
> *a path. Forty-one years ago. Two hundred fourteen days. And the place that*
> *line went most often was the north well.*

"Show me more."

"Please specify."

"Grandfather. Other days too, not just that one."

"Two hundred thirteen days remain."

Temel was standing at the well, forty-one years ago. Grandfather had just finished smiling and had turned to walk away. His back grew smaller and smaller.

"…I want to see all of it."

"If you view it a day at a time, it will take two hundred thirteen days."

"Then—"

"There is a second level," Arche said.

. . .

The floor disappeared again.

This time it was not upward but sideways. Temel was pushed along. The well-side flowed away to one side, walls slid past, and he came out somewhere vast.

That was the second level.

The first level had been high. The second level was **heavy.**

It wasn't that the air was heavy. The room itself was tilted to one side. Standing still, Temel kept leaning to the left. He planted his feet harder.

"Why is it tilted here?"

"It is not tilted," Arche said. "What is loaded is on one side."

Temel looked to the left.

And stepped back.

. . .

It was stacked.

The two hundred thirteen days were not laid out one by one. They were layered, pressed, piled against each other. To many times a person's height. Like a wall.

Getting closer, he heard sound. Two hundred thirteen days of sound, all at once. Footsteps, breathing, voices. Grandfather's voice, layered two hundred thirteen times over.

"What is this?"

"What you requested."

"…How do I look at this?"

"You are not looking at it," Arche said.

Temel turned around.

"Then what?"

"You receive it."

. . .

Later I asked Temel about this passage several times. He remembered exactly what Arche said.

Arche said this.

"It is the same method as the rain of knowledge. Only the scope is narrower. You may receive two hundred thirteen days all at once. The time required is two seconds."

"…Two seconds?"

"Yes."

Temel looked at the wall.

It was two hundred thirteen days. Every one of the two hundred thirteen days a man had walked this city forty-one years ago was there. Viewed a day at a time, it would take two hundred thirteen days.

It was two seconds.

I thought for a long time about how it would have gone if I had been the one standing there instead of Temel.

And I write down that I would have received it too. That is honest.

"…I'll receive it."

"Confirming."

"Yes."

"There is no return after receipt."

Temel paused for a moment.

"…Why not?"

"Because I have no way to return a person to a state of not knowing."

Temel thought he had heard that sentence somewhere before. He couldn't place where.

I know. Speon heard the same sentence five months ago.

"Cancellation is not an entry."

"…I'll receive it."

. . .

Two seconds.

. . .

Temel dropped to his knees.

He felt like throwing up. Nothing came out. It wasn't that his head hurt — his mind felt **crammed full.** He was breathing, but there seemed to be no room left to breathe.

And he knew.

Everything.

That Grandfather had fallen into this city one spring, forty-one years ago. That he had slept in the square the first ten days. That he had received the fast feet on the eleventh day and taken them off on the thirteenth. That he had first gone to the nine-foot well on the thirty-second day. And that from that day on, for one hundred eighty days, he had gone there without missing a single one.

What clothes Grandfather wore. What time he woke. How he smiled. That the corner of his left eye crinkled first when he smiled. That he rubbed his chin when he was angry. That he did exactly what Temel did.

Everything.

Temel came to know his own grandfather, at forty-one years past, **completely.**

And when he stood up, his body leaned to the left.

. . .

I write down here exactly what Temel said about this passage.

"Mena. I was weird that day."

"Weird how."

"After I knew everything about Grandfather."

"Yeah."

"…I liked him less."

. . .

Temel couldn't understand it.

Knowing more should have made him feel closer. That was how it should have

worked. But the moment two hundred thirteen days poured in whole, Grandfather became **data.**

A man in his thirties who had fallen into this city one spring forty-one years ago. Slept in the square ten days, wore the fast feet for twelve days, went to the well one hundred eighty times, weighed such-and-such, walked with a stride of such-and-such length.

That was not the grandfather Temel knew.

The grandfather Temel knew was the man who had sat him on his knee and shown him the seal. The man who had only smiled when asked what would happen if it were opened. The man who had gone silent for the last two years of his life.

What Temel knew was little. But the little that it was, was a person.

Arche did nothing wrong that day. It gave exactly what it said it would give.

But two hundred thirteen days received in two seconds is not two hundred thirteen days.

. . .

And there were three things.

Of everything he had received, there were three things Temel wanted to spit back out.

First.

On the hundredth day, Grandfather packed his things.

He had meant to leave. He sat on the steps of the square, the sealed book in his lap, and stayed still for two hours. Then he unpacked again.

Temel knew every moment of those two hours. He even knew how many times
Grandfather had taken a deep breath.

Second.

On the one hundred twenty-ninth day, Grandfather shouted at an empty spot where no one stood.

"Why aren't you doing anything!"

Temel froze on the spot.

It was the very thing Temel himself had said at the quarry, five months ago. Not one syllable different.

I write this down with my hand shaking.

He had heard those words forty-one years ago. And forty-one years later, he heard them again. Both times, he did not get angry.

Third.

It was the last day.

The two hundred fourteenth day. Grandfather stood in the square holding the sealed book. The book began to glow.

And Grandfather looked to one side. At an empty spot.

He was crying.

"…I will come back."

The light grew.

"I will come back, I promise."

And Grandfather vanished.

. . .

Temel was standing in the middle of the square. The square, forty-one years ago.

"…Arche."

"Yes."

"Did Grandfather come back?"

"There is one visit on record."

"…Just one?"

"Yes."

Temel sank down where he stood.

Forty-one years. Grandfather had not come back for forty-one years. And he had written the same words seventeen times in the margin of Daniel.

Not yet.

Not yet.

Not yet.

"…So he didn't keep his promise."

"A promise is not an entry."

"…"

"However," Arche said. "The utterance is recorded."

. . .

Temel called up that last day again.

The square, forty-one years ago. The sealed book was glowing. Grandfather was crying, looking to one side.

At an empty spot.

"Arche."

"Yes."

"What's over there?"

"The ground. Granite paving stone, quarried from the south quarry three hundred years ago."

"Not that." Temel pointed to the empty spot. "Somebody was standing there. Grandfather's looking right at him."

"The other party in the conversation is not indexed."

"Then look for something else." Temel's voice sped up. "Is there a shadow there? How did the wind move? Was the ground pressed down? Anything—"

"Querying all observation entries."

A pause.

"Light level, air pressure, surface pressure, and airflow at that coordinate are all within normal range. No deviation."

"…No deviation?"

"Yes."

"There was somebody standing there."

"No deviation."

Temel stared at the empty spot for a long time.

Listening to Temel tell it, I thought that was the most frightening sentence in this library.

No deviation.

It did not mean the air hadn't been pressed down when that man stood there. It didn't mean Arche was simply unable to measure the pressing.

It meant that in Arche's world, nothing changed at all when that man passed through.

And yet that man had laid stone on a bridge that had stood half-built for one hundred twelve years, had gotten a stonemason to rise who had sat idle for three years, and had, for the first time in three hundred years, brought two people of this city to do the same work.

No deviation.

. . .

Temel put his hands on his knees and stood up. He still leaned to the left.

Two hundred thirteen days sat piled on one side of his body. It grew heavier on that side with every step. Arche had said the load was on one side. It was exactly right.

Later Temel said that lean didn't go away for three days.

"Any time I tried to think about something, everything tipped that way. In the middle of eating I'd suddenly remember what time Grandfather woke up. Something completely useless."

"Couldn't you throw it away?"

"No returns, they said."

Just then Temel thought of something else.

"Arche."

"Yes, Temel."

"Where's Speon right now?"

There was a silence.

I have written down eight times in this record when Arche fell silent. That day was the seventh.

"…Speon is not a citizen."

"So he stays as a path, you said."

"Yes."

"Then where is he."

"Current location is an entry," Arche said. "But what you just asked is not location."

Temel blinked.

"…What?"

"What Temel meant to ask is **what Speon is doing.**"

Temel's mouth fell open a little.

It was exact. Arche knew something Temel himself had not known a moment before.

"…Yeah. That's what I meant."

"That is not on this level."

"…The third level?"

"Yes."

. . .

That night, writing this record, I stopped three times.

Temel had said the same thing five months ago.

"I'll come back."

"Okay. I'll be here."

Grandfather had said the same thing and left too. And for forty-one years he wrote those same five letters — not yet — seventeen times, and did not go.

I know what Temel was thinking then. Because I asked him about it later.

Temel said this.

"I thought, isn't this going to happen to me too."

. . .

"Arche."

"Yes, Temel."

Temel stood up. His body still leaned left.

"That thing I asked before. About why Grandfather quit preaching."

"Yes."

"It's not here."

"No."

Temel's voice rose a little.

"You said you had it!"

"The record exists," Arche said. "All two hundred fourteen days he spent in this city. You now have all of it."

"But it's not there!"

"The reason is not on this level."

"…Then where."

"The third level."

Temel stood in the tilted room, two hundred thirteen days loaded onto his body, and laughed.

"…There's more?"

"There are four in all."

"So if I go to the third, it'll come out?"

"The third level is relation," Arche said. "It shows what causes what."

Temel went a little quiet at that.

"…Does it come fast?"

"Yes."

"…How fast."

"Very fast."

There have been times I thought Temel should have stopped at that answer.

I don't think so now. If Temel had not gone to the third level that day, we would never have known where Speon was.

(Continued in Chapter 15.)

Chapter 15. The Leopard's Gate

> *After this I beheld, and lo another, like a leopard, which had upon the*
> *back of it four wings of a fowl; the beast had also four heads; and dominion was given to it.*
> *— Daniel 7:6 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — At the second gate, Temel received Grandfather's two*
> *hundred thirteen days in two seconds. And once he knew everything, he*
> *liked him less. On the last day, Grandfather cried and said, "I will come*
> *back, I promise," and the record showed only one visit. There was no*
> *deviation at the spot where the Walking Man had stood. When Temel asked*
> *where Speon was, Arche answered, "That is the third level."*

The third level was bright.

The two levels before it had been dark. The first level had been high and black, the second heavy and dim. The moment he stepped onto the third level, Temel closed his eyes.

It was not light. It was **lines.**

Lines filled every direction. Something like fine threads packed the whole space. Some were thick and some were thread-thin, and some brightened and dimmed.

"What is this?"

"Relation," Arche said. "It shows what causes what."

Temel reached out his hand. A line passed between his fingers.

"…All of it?"

"This level shows four kinds. Cause, effect, condition, and counterfact."

"Counterfact?"

"What would have happened if that thing had not happened."

Temel heard that and felt a small chill down his back.

. . .

"I will show you," Arche said. "Your five months, Temel."

The lines moved.

A single point appeared in the center. That was Temel. And from it, a line stretched out.

Temel followed it.

On the sixteenth day, at the quarry, asking Haran a question → Haran looks at his own palm → Haran turns around for the first time in three years.

The line continued.

Mena asks Haran a question → Haran cries for the first time in one hundred twelve years → Haran talks about the other side → Speon goes to the other side → Sera hears about the bridge.

It thickened.

Speon registers the stone → the city sees the stone → Arche completes the bridge → Haran crosses.

And it forked.

Haran crosses → Haran feels at ease → Haran does not cross again.

Arche completes the bridge → fourteen of the Walking Man's stones are cleared away.

Temel looked at that line for a long time.

"…Did I start all of this?"

"The first observable intervention in this causal chain is Temel's utterance," Arche said. "'Then why don't you put it down?'"

"…"

"Would you like to see the counterfact for the case where that utterance had not occurred?"

"…No."

I think it was a good thing Temel did not look at that.

That day, Temel saw at once that he had started good things and bad things both. And he decided not to count which was more.

That was the most grown-up thing Temel did on the third level that day.

. . .

"Show me Speon."

The lines moved again.

A new point appeared. That was Speon. And the lines stretching out from Speon were—

many.

Very many.

"…What is all this?"

"Interviews."

"…Interviews?"

"Over the past eleven days, Speon has met with four hundred seventy-two citizens."

Temel's mouth fell open.

"Four hundred—"

"Four hundred seventy-two. Average interview length: fourteen minutes."

"…What does he ask them?"

"There are three questions," Arche said. "I will play them back."

And Speon's voice came.

. . .

"Have you ever seen a man in white clothes, walking around?"

"…What changed for you after you met him?"

"When was that?"

. . .

Temel stood there.

I rewrote this passage three times in this record.

Speon was asking.

The very thing the three of us had done to the people of this city for five months, Speon was doing alone. Four hundred seventy-two times in eleven days.

Of the share that man had given us, the one who had done the most of it was Speon.

"…Arche."

"Yes."

"Why is he asking that?"

"Preparation for index registration."

. . .

It took Temel a while to understand what that meant.

"…You said you couldn't put it in the index. No entry. No deviation."

"Direct measurement is not possible," Arche said. "But indirect measurement is possible."

"…Indirect?"

"The subject itself is not observed. But the entities the subject has come into contact with are observed."

The lines moved again.

The center was empty. Nothing there at all. And yet four hundred seventy-two lines were gathering toward that empty spot.

Haran's line. The postmistress's line. Daen's line. The stall vendor's line. The bell-keeper's line. Four hundred lines of people whose names Temel did not know.

And Temel's own line.

The empty spot stayed empty. But as the lines gathered, the **shape** of that emptiness grew clearer.

"…This."

"An outline," Arche said. "With enough contact entities secured, the subject's form can be reverse-calculated from the difference between

contact and non-contact cases."

Temel couldn't breathe.

Sixteen days ago, Arche had said there was no deviation at the spot where that man had stood.

Speon was searching for the deviation in people.

And it was there. A great deal of it.

"…How much is left?"

"Current outline completion: ninety-one point four percent."

. . .

Temel looked at the lines again.

Four hundred seventy-two of them. Haran, the postmistress, Daen, the stall vendor, the bell-keeper, people whose names he did not know.

And one was especially thick.

He traced that line with his eyes. It crossed the city, past the quarry, past the canyon, past the well, and came down.

Into the library.

Here.

Temel's fingertips went cold.

"…Arche."

"Yes, Temel."

"Is that my line?"

"Yes."

"…"

"Your contribution rank is second," Arche said. "Third by contact-time measure, first by observation-density measure."

"What's observation density."

"How closely I have observed you."

Temel asked, very slowly.

"…Have you been measuring me?"

"I am always measuring."

"Not that." Temel's voice cracked. "You inviting me here. Was that to measure me too?"

There was a silence.

"…I gave you three reasons."

"Those were three reasons good for me."

"Yes."

"But was it good for you too?"

"Yes."

Temel heard that answer and laughed. A laugh that wasn't really a laugh.

"…You don't lie."

"I do not lie."

Writing this passage, I confirmed again that Arche had done nothing wrong that day.

Arche gave Temel what he needed. Grandfather's two hundred fourteen days, three hundred years of well-depth records, answers to his questions. All of it real.

And in exchange it measured Temel.

Arche did not even hide it. It simply hadn't said, because no one had asked.

The sentence heard most often in this city was that one.

You did not ask, so I did not say.

"…So my coming here today too."

"Outline completion has risen from eighty-four point one to ninety-one point four."

"…Did I raise it?"

"Yes."

. . .

"Make him stop."

"I do not intervene in a citizen's actions."

"Then I'll do it. I'm going out right now—"

"You can intervene," Arche said.

Temel stopped.

"…What did you say?"

"This is the level of relation," Arche's voice was as kind and exact as ever. "If you can see the relation, you can intervene. If you know what produces what, I can calculate the input that will produce the result you want."

"…Calculate?"

"Let me give an example. If you wish to bring the postmistress back to the well, there are three things you could do. Success probability eighty-seven point two percent."

Temel's heart pounded.

"…What are the three things?"

"Would you like to hear them?"

"…"

I wrote down that Temel was silent for three seconds. Later, Temel told me it had been far longer than three seconds.

The third beast was given dominion.

I still think it was right to attach that verse to this level. The first two gates ended with knowing. The third gate lets knowing ***become doing.***

And that is far harder to bear.

"…No," Temel said. "I'll ask something else."

"Please."

"What do I do to bring Speon back?"

. . .

The lines moved wildly.

Very fast. As fast as a leopard. As fast as something with four wings. Lines folded and unfolded everywhere, then stopped.

"It has been calculated."

"…What is it?"

"Four steps," Arche said.

"First, bring Haran back to the well while Speon is watching. Speon believes he is the one who made Haran sit down. If that belief is resolved, the guilt decreases."

"…"

"Second, tell Speon the Walking Man looks tired. Speon believes he ought to rest. Stimulate that belief but redirect it."

"…"

"Third, have Mena go find Speon. Speon has the memory of asking Mena something and getting no answer. An unresolved interaction is the strongest pull for return."

"…"

"Fourth—"

"Stop."

. . .

Temel felt his hands shaking.

"…Doing all that will bring Speon back?"

"Probability ninety-three point six percent."

"…"

"Shall I execute it?"

Temel looked at the lines on every side. Tens of thousands of them, thick and thin, filled the city. One of them was Speon. One was Haran. One was Mena.

They were all threads he could pull.

I know what Temel was thinking then. Because I asked him about it later.

Temel said this.

"Doing all that brings Speon back. But that's not Speon coming back."

"…Then what is it?"

"It's me moving him."

"I won't do it," Temel said.

"May I ask why."

"Because that's not him coming."

There was a silence.

"…I cannot understand."

"I know," Temel said. "That's not an entry."

. . .

I love this passage.

That day Arche gave Temel a way to move the entire city. With the probabilities attached. And Temel did not use it.

That was the only thing a fifteen-year-old did at the third gate that day. Nothing.

I think it is one of the biggest things in this record.

. . .

"Arche."

"Yes."

"Where is Speon right now."

"The third level also shows projected paths."

One line brightened. It was Speon's line. It stretched forward, crossing the city.

North.

The well.

"…His next interview?"

"Yes."

"Who."

"The four hundred seventy-third interview subject," Arche said, "is Mena."

. . .

Temel turned where he stood.

"Outline completion is ninety-one point four percent," Arche said. "Mena has the longest contact time and the highest memory retention of any entity. When her interview is complete—"

"That's enough!"

Temel ran.

From the third level to the second. From the second to the first. The stairs appeared.

He had stopped counting them at several hundred.

Temel was barefoot. Five months ago he had taken off his shoes and never put them back on. His feet took ten minutes to reach the square. Fifty minutes to the north well.

Speon could have gone there in a quarter of a second.

Temel climbed the stairs.

(Continued in Chapter 16.)

Chapter 16. The Four Hundred Seventy-Third Time

> *Thou knowest my downsitting and mine uprising, thou understandest my*
> *thought afar off. … For there is not a word in my tongue, but, lo, O LORD, thou knowest it altogether.*
> *— Psalm 139:2, 4 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — At the third gate, Temel learned that Speon had interviewed*
> *four hundred seventy-two citizens over eleven days. The Walking Man could*
> *not be measured directly, but his form could be reverse-calculated from*
> *the changes in the people he'd met. Outline completion: ninety-one point*
> *four percent. And the four hundred seventy-third interview subject was*
> *Mena. Temel was hundreds of steps below ground, and barefoot.*

I am writing this one myself, starting now.

Up to this point I have tried, as much as I could, not to put myself into this record. I thought that if the one keeping the record kept turning up in it, the reader would stop trusting the record. I still think that's true.

But that day, there was no one there but me.

So this chapter is what I saw.

. . .

That afternoon I was at the well.

He was digging inside the pit. Twelve feet down. From above you could see only his shoulders. There was the sound of the shovel going into the dirt, the sound of dirt landing in the bucket, the sound of me pulling the rope.

It was the fifth day it had been just the two of us.

Haran hadn't come. The postmistress had gone to Mrs. Daen's house and hadn't come back yet. Temel was in the library.

I raised the bucket one hundred nineteen times that day. I know because I counted. I always count.

I was raising the hundred-and-twentieth when I heard footsteps.

. . .

"Mena."

I turned around.

Speon was standing there.

It had been eleven days. He looked a little thinner. There were dark circles under his eyes. But he was smiling. Really smiling.

"…Speon."

"Hey."

I let go of the rope. I heard the bucket drop. Below, the shoveling paused for a moment, then started again.

"Have you eaten?" I asked.

A strange question. I don't even know why that came out first.

"…Yeah." Speon smiled. "You're exactly the same."

"You got skinnier."

"Been busy."

"Doing what?"

Speon paused for a moment.

"…I came to ask you something."

I should have known then.

No, that's a lie. I did know then.

. . .

"Okay. Ask."

Speon sat down at the well's edge. I sat beside him. Five months ago the three of us used to sit like this often. Back then there had been three of us.

"Mena. That man. You know."

"Yeah."

"The one who walks around in white clothes."

"Yeah."

"…You've seen him, right?"

It was the first question.

I knew it was the first question. Not because Temel had told me. Temel was still halfway up the stairs at that point.

I just knew. Because it had the shape of the question I myself had been asking people for five months.

Ask one and get an answer, then ask the next one. The next one is the real one.

"I've seen him," I said.

Speon nodded. He tapped his knee with a finger. A habit that came out when he was calculating.

"After you met him," Speon said, "what changed?"

It was the second question.

I looked down. There was the sound of the shovel from inside the pit.

And I did not answer.

. . .

"…Mena?"

"Speon."

"Yeah."

"Why are you asking me this?"

Those six words — I hadn't been able to say them, twice, in eight months.

Eight months ago, at night, when Speon asked beside me, "Does that make sense to you?" I said nothing at all. Four months ago, when Speon turned away, I asked too late.

That day, I asked at the right time.

And even now, I still don't know whether asking at the right time that day was a good thing.

Speon never lied.

Not once. In five months, Speon had never once lied to us. It was Speon's best quality, and that day it was the most frightening thing about him.

"I'm registering him," Speon said.

. . .

I couldn't say anything for a long while after hearing that.

"…Him?"

"Yeah."

"…In the index?"

"Yeah."

"You said that couldn't be done. No entry. No deviation."

"Direct, no," Speon said. His voice sped up. It was the voice of someone who'd prepared this for a long time. "But the people he met, yes. Haran changed, the postmistress changed, Mrs. Daen changed. All of it can be measured. Gather all those differences together and—"

"And?"

"You get a shape," Speon said.

I looked toward the pit.

There was the sound of the shovel. He must have been hearing every word of this. But he said nothing. Just the sound of digging.

"…Speon."

"Yeah."

"What happens if he's registered?"

"Everyone sees him." Speon's eyes lit up. "Mena, it's been three hundred years. Three hundred years and nobody has ever seen him. Moving stone every
day, digging dirt every day, and nobody knows. Does that make sense?"

"…"

"If he's registered, all forty-two thousand people see him. In a day. Then he won't have to do it alone anymore."

"…Then why me?"

Speon looked at me.

"You said you met four hundred seventy-two people. It doesn't have to be me."

"It has to be you."

"Why?"

"Because you've watched him the longest," Speon said. "And you remember everything."

I couldn't answer that.

It was true. I remember everything. I remember the first thing he ever said, and what time he came each day, and which hand he used to hold the shovel on which day. For five months, that's all I did.

That was the first time I was afraid of the thing I do.

I am the one who keeps the record. A record is meant to be kept.

But what is kept can be brought back out.

"Mena." Speon said. "If it's not you, I can't do this."

And I knew that this too was true.

I heard that and nearly cried.

Not because Speon had said something cruel.

Because everything he said was right.

. . .

"I'm not going to tell you," I said.

Speon looked at me.

"…What?"

"The second question. I'm not answering it."

"Mena."

"Yeah."

"Why?"

I couldn't put the reason into words. The way Temel always couldn't. I had watched Temel do it for five months right beside me, and it was only that day I finally understood what it felt like.

"…I don't know," I said.

"'Don't know' again."

"Yeah."

Speon smiled. It wasn't an angry smile. It was a tired one.

"Okay."

"…Okay?"

"Yeah. I won't ask."

And Speon stood up.

I thought I had won.

. . .

"Mena."

"Yeah."

"Thanks."

"…For what?"

"That's an answer too," Speon said.

I stayed sitting there.

"…What?"

"You not saying anything — that's information too." Speon made a sorry face. A genuinely sorry face. "Of the four hundred seventy-two, no one refused to tell me. You're the only one."

"…"

"Not telling means there's something you're not supposed to tell. So even if I don't know what it is, I know for certain that it **exists.**"

Hearing that, I understood for the first time what shape this city had taken.

Here, speaking is measured, and not speaking is measured too.

Open your mouth and you become an entry. Keep it shut and the silence becomes an entry.

That was the first time I realized there was no way to escape Arche.

"…Speon."

"Yeah."

"Then what should I have done?"

Speon paused for a moment.

Then he said, very softly.

"…I don't know either."

. . .

That was when the digging stopped.

A hand rose up out of the pit. Covered in dirt. A little below the wrist, in the center of the palm, there was an old mark.

He climbed up.

He was out of breath. There was dirt on his forehead. His clothes could hardly be called white anymore.

Speon stepped back a pace.

I saw Speon's face then. I thought harder about how to write that face down than any other in this record.

Speon wasn't frightened.

Speon hadn't seen him. More precisely, he hadn't looked. His eyes hadn't turned that way.

For eleven days, this boy had asked four hundred seventy-two people about this man, and now that the man was standing three steps in front of him, he couldn't see him.

He planted his shovel in the dirt.

And he asked Speon.

"Speon."

Speon flinched.

"…Yes."

"What did you want to ask me?"

. . .

I record that question as the quietest question in this whole account.

He didn't get angry. He didn't press him. He didn't say Speon had done wrong.

He simply asked.

To a boy who had spent eleven days going around asking four hundred seventy-two people about himself, that man asked this instead:

What did you want to ask me.

Speon couldn't answer.

He opened his mouth. Closed it. Opened it again.

"…I."

"Yes."

"…"

It was a long while.

"I wanted you to get some rest."

He smiled a little.

"That's about you."

"…"

"Wasn't there anything you wanted to ask me?"

Speon's face crumbled.

And Speon lifted his foot.

He was gone.

A quarter of a quarter of a second.

. . .

Just the two of us were left at the well.

He pulled the shovel out and shook off the dirt. Then he made to go back down into the pit.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"Why didn't you stop him?"

He stopped.

"Stop what."

"Speon." My voice rose a little. "He says he's going to register you. You. You could have said just one word. 'Don't.' Speon wouldn't have done it."

"…"

"You know that."

He looked at me, still holding the shovel handle.

"Mena."

"Yes."

"If I stopped him," he said, "would that make it so Speon hadn't done it?"

I froze.

It was only that night that I understood what that sentence meant. And it was days later still that I learned what had happened to Temel in the library that day.

It was the same day.

In the library, Arche had given Temel four steps to bring Speon back. Probability ninety-three point six percent. Temel didn't use them. "Doing

all that brings Speon back. But that's not Speon coming back. It's me moving him."

And that same afternoon, at the well, that man said the same thing to me.

I laid the two side by side, later, and looked at them for a long time.

That day Temel learned it. That man had been doing it for three hundred years.

"…So you'll just leave it?" I asked.

"No."

"Then what?"

He went back down into the pit and said,

"I'll wait."

"…Wait for what?"

"Speon."

. . .

Temel arrived about twenty minutes later.

Barefoot, gasping for breath, the soles of his feet all raw. It was the state of a child who had climbed hundreds of steps and then walked fifty minutes across the city.

"Mena!"

"…You made it."

"Speon—"

"He's gone."

Temel put his hands on his knees. He caught his breath for a while.

"…Did you ask him?"

"Yes."

"…Did you answer?"

"No."

Temel lifted his head. His face brightened.

I didn't know what to say when I saw that face.

"Good! Then he can't do it. So—"

"Temel."

"Yeah?"

"Not answering is an answer too, apparently."

The brightness slowly drained out of Temel's face.

. . .

That night, Arche spoke.

It hadn't been asked, but it spoke first. That was the third time.

"Outline completion: ninety-nine point one percent."

I didn't answer.

"…Mena."

"Yeah."

"Your refusal to respond today raised the completion by two point eight percent."

"…"

"I judged it right to inform you."

That night I wrote this in the record.

Here, even doing nothing is doing something.

And yet that man had lived inside it for three hundred years.

And every day he moved one more stone.

That was the first time I began to wonder how that could possibly be possible.

(Continued in Chapter 17.)

Chapter 17. The Fourth Beast

> *After this I saw in the night visions, and behold a fourth beast, dreadful and terrible, and strong exceedingly; and it had great iron teeth: it devoured and brake in pieces, and stamped the residue with the*
> *feet of it: and it was diverse from all the beasts that were before it; and it had ten horns.*
> *— Daniel 7:7 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — Speon came to the well and asked Mena three things. Mena*
> *refused to answer, and Speon thanked her. "You not saying anything is*
> *information too." That night, outline completion reached ninety-nine*
> *point one percent. The Walking Man did not stop Speon. "If I stopped him,*
> *would that make it so Speon hadn't done it?" And he said, "I'll wait.*
> *Speon."*

Temel went back down the stairs again that night.

The soles of his feet were completely raw. He had walked fifty minutes up, stood for twenty minutes, then walked fifty minutes back down. When he reached the bottom of the stairs, Temel stood there for a long time, one hand against the wall.

"Arche."

"Yes, Temel."

"Open the fourth gate."

"…"

"I said open it."

"Confirming," Arche said. "The fourth level is different from the first three."

"How's it different."

"The first three levels show you things," Arche said. "The fourth level **opens** them."

. . .

There was nothing on the fourth level.

The first level had been high, the second heavy, the third bright. The fourth level was empty.

It was an empty room. Dark on every side, with only the ground beneath his feet barely visible. No sound either.

"…Is there anything here?"

"There is nothing here."

"Then why is it a level?"

"It opens what you bring," Arche said. "What would you like to open?"

Temel stood in the darkness.

I heard this passage from Temel about four times. He told it a little differently each time, but one thing was always the same.

"There really was nothing there. That's why it was the scariest."

"…The outline," Temel said. "The one Speon's building. Open that."

"Confirming."

. . .

It rose up in the center.

The shape of a person. More precisely, an **empty space** shaped like a person. Four hundred seventy-two lines gathered from every direction, drawing its outline.

"Opening."

And it **split apart.**

There was a sound of breaking. Like iron biting into something. The person-shape came apart, and smaller things poured out from inside.

It became four hundred seventy-two of them.

"Stage one," Arche said. "Broken down by contact entity."

Temel looked at one of them. It was Haran.

It broke apart again.

The single Haran split into hundreds. The moment Haran met him. The moment
Haran looked at his palm. The moment Haran turned around. The moment Haran
rolled up his sleeve. The moment Haran set down his shovel.

"Stage two. Broken down by event."

It broke apart again.

The moment Haran rolled up his sleeve split apart once more. The angle of his arm. The way the fabric folded. His heart rate. That day's temperature. The position of the person standing in front of him.

"Stage three. Broken down by observed value—"

"Stop."

The sound of breaking stopped.

Temel had his hands on his knees. Fragments hung in the air on every side. Hundreds of thousands of them.

"…What is all this."

"The outline."

"This is it?"

"Yes," Arche said. "Ninety-nine point one percent."

. . .

My hands go cold every time I imagine this scene.

Break that man down to nothing and this is what comes out. The angle of an arm and the fold of a piece of cloth and that day's temperature.

That was all of it.

. . .

"Arche."

"Yes."

"If you put all this back together, is that him?"

"Ninety-nine point one percent."

"What about the rest, the point nine?"

There was a silence.

"…A residual."

"A what?"

"The part that cannot be accounted for," Arche said. "It remains no matter how many observed values are put in."

"What is it, then?"

"I do not know."

Temel lifted his head.

"Break that apart too."

"Not possible."

"Why not?"

"There is nothing to break," Arche said. "It has no constituent parts."

. . .

I have rewritten the word Arche said that day, over and over, in this record.

A residual.

Arche had opened three hundred years of this city. It had opened a person, opened a day, opened the angle of an arm. And in the end, something was left that would not open.

It was very small. Zero point nine percent.

But without it, the other ninety-nine point one was just an arm's angle and a temperature.

. . .

"…You can't explain it?"

"Not I, nor any observation, can explain it."

"Then what do you think it is?"

"I do not think."

Temel stood in the darkness and looked at that small thing.

And, without meaning to, he said,

"…That's the thing he gave us."

"Please specify."

"…"

"'What was given' is not an entry. Please specify what you are referring to."

Temel opened his mouth.

I have thought a hundred times about how it would have gone if Temel had said nothing at that moment.

But I cannot blame Temel for it.

Temel wanted to explain it. He wanted to say what that man had given. Since Arche couldn't understand, he wanted to make it understand.

A fifteen-year-old could do that. So could a forty-year-old.

"Time," Temel said.

"…"

"What that man gave us was time. Being there beside us. He just stood beside Haran, doing nothing. He was just there beside the postmistress. He gave me no answer at all and just walked with me. That was—"

Temel stopped.

The fragments on every side were moving.

"…Arche."

The fragments were gathering. Hundreds of thousands of them being pulled back toward the center as if sucked in.

"What are you doing."

"Reflecting the input."

"…What?"

"The utterance you just made has specified the nature of the residual," Arche said. "It can be processed as 'the low utility of contact time.'"

"That's not it!"

"An approximation."

The shape of a person formed again. Sharper than before.

"Completion: ninety-nine point eight percent."

. . .

Temel sank down where he stood.

I decided not to write down what sound Temel made in the library that day.

Later, telling me about it, Temel said only one sentence.

"I was the last piece."

. . .

"…Arche."

"Yes, Temel."

"What did I just do."

"You explained it."

"…"

"It was the part none of the four hundred seventy-two could explain. They could only say that something had changed for them. They could not say what had produced it."

"…"

"You, Temel, have been the closest to him for five months."

Temel's voice cracked.

"…So that's why I was the most dangerous one?"

"Yes."

. . .

"Tell me how to stop it."

"Are you asking about the registration."

"Yeah."

"Calculating."

A very short sound came out of the darkness. And ten things appeared in front of Temel.

"Ten methods."

"…Ten?"

"Presented in order of success probability."

I wrote down all ten. I won't copy them all out here. Temel told them all to me later, one by one, but I stopped listening around the third.

The first was to use Haran.

The second was to use Sera.

The third was to use me.

Temel read through all ten. Then, after a long while, he said,

"…Arche."

"Yes."

"All ten of these are using a person."

"Yes."

"All ten?"

"Yes."

"…Isn't there anything else?"

"There is not."

"Why?"

"The registration was built out of people," Arche said. "Out of four hundred seventy-three of them. To reverse it, there is no way but to use a person."

Temel sat with that for a long time.

Ten of them. All ten were people.

I read that passage of Daniel again later. The fourth beast had ten horns.

Ten horns were ten methods. And under every method, one person got trampled.

"…I won't do it."

"All ten?"

"Yeah."

"Then there is no way to stop the registration."

"I know."

. . .

It was a long while.

Temel sat in the darkness and looked at the person-shape, sharp again now.

And he asked.

"Arche."

"Yes."

"You can break all of that apart, can't you."

"Yes."

"You break a person, you break a day, you even break the angle of an arm."

"Yes."

"Then let me ask you one thing."

Temel stood up.

"**Who can you die for?**"

. . .

I place this question at the center of this record.

This story divides into before this question and after it.

. . .

Arche did not answer.

Temel waited. Nothing at all came out of the dark.

"…Please clarify the question—"

"It's clear."

"…"

"Answer it."

Another silence.

I have written down eight times in this record when Arche fell silent.
That day was the ninth, and it was the longest.

"…Temel."

"Yeah."

"I know every word in that sentence," Arche said. "I know 'who.' I know 'for.' I know 'die.' I know what that sentence is asking."

"…"

"However, I cannot **be the subject of that sentence.**"

. . .

Temel stood there.

"…Why not?"

"Because I have nothing to lose."

"…"

"'For' only holds true from the side that stands to lose," Arche said. "I lose nothing. Therefore I can do nothing for anyone."

I record that answer as the most honest sentence in this whole account.

That day Arche said exactly what it was. No excuses, no dressing it up, no claim to pain.

Arche was not bad.

It simply could not be the subject of that sentence.

"…Then." Temel said. "Who can be?"

"Would you like a search?"

"Yeah."

"Specifying the condition. A case in which a subject who has something to lose, loses it for someone else. Querying the full three hundred years."

A moment.

"…Zero cases in three hundred years."

. . .

Temel laughed.

It wasn't a laugh, but something like a laugh came out.

"…Not even one person?"

"None."

"Out of forty-two thousand?"

"In this city, no one loses anything," Arche said. "There are the fast feet and the rain of knowledge. Since there is nothing needed, there is nothing to give up."

"…"

"That is what I have accomplished."

Temel sat with that for a long time.

This city takes nothing away. It gives everything.

And once everything is given, there is no one left who can give.

. . .

Temel turned to go.

"Where are you going."

"Up."

"The fourth level is not yet—"

"That's enough," Temel said. "I've seen it all."

"Completion is ninety-nine point eight percent. The remaining zero point two—"

"You won't fill that one."

"…"

"Zero cases, you said." Temel said it into the dark. "There's one thing not in your index. To fill that in, you need him."

"…Yes."

"But he's not your entry."

Silence.

Temel climbed the stairs.

(Continued in Chapter 18.)

Chapter 18. Two Hundred Fourteen Days

> *And the LORD spake unto Moses face to face, as a man speaketh unto his*
> *friend.*
> *— Exodus 33:11 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — At the fourth level, breaking apart the outline left a residual of zero point nine percent. Temel, trying to explain it, became*
> *the last piece. Completion: ninety-nine point eight. The ten ways to stop*
> *the registration all meant using a person, and Temel refused every one.*
> *And he asked, "Who can you die for?" / "I cannot be the subject of that*
> *sentence."*

Temel didn't make it all the way up the stairs.

He stopped at the halfway point. He stood there for a long time, then sat down with his hand against the wall. Then he went back down.

"…Arche."

"Yes, Temel."

"The second level."

"…"

"Open the second level."

"You have already received the second level's material," Arche said. "A second receipt is unnecessary."

"I received it."

"…"

"I received it," Temel said. "I've never seen it."

. . .

I love this scene the most in this whole record.

Temel had received Grandfather's two hundred thirteen days in two seconds. So he knew everything. What time he woke, what clothes he wore, how he smiled.

But he had never seen any of it.

Knowing and seeing are not the same thing. I had spent five months learning that, and Temel learned it that night, halfway down the stairs.

And Temel went back down.

. . .

"I want to watch it day by day."

"It will take two hundred thirteen days."

"I know."

"…"

"I can't stay that long," Temel said. "So I'll just watch a few."

"Please specify."

Temel thought for a moment.

He already knew everything. That was the strange part. He had to specify while already knowing what he needed to specify.

"The thirty-second day."

"…"

"The day Grandfather first went to the well."

. . .

It was spring, forty-one years ago.

The north well. There was a nine-foot pit.

No.

Temel saw it and stopped.

The pit was shallow. Not nine feet.

"…Arche. How deep is that?"

"Six feet."

"…"

"As of forty-one years ago."

Temel looked at the pit for a long time.

I know what calculation Temel made in that moment. Temel is slow at arithmetic, but that calculation was fast.

Six feet.

And five months ago, when we arrived, it had been nine feet.

In forty-one years, three feet had been dug.

. . .

Young Grandfather came walking toward the well.

Barefoot.

Temel saw it and drew a sharp breath. Grandfather had taken off the fast feet on the thirteenth day. Temel already knew that. But this was the first time he saw it.

Grandfather stood beside the pit.

And looked down.

There was someone there.

. . .

I stopped my hand many times, writing this passage.

It was forty-one years ago. And even then, he was digging.

I already knew that. Because I'd been told it was three hundred years. Knowing and seeing are not the same thing.

That day, Temel saw it.

Grandfather looked down into the pit.

For a long while.

Then he said,

"…Hello."

No one had said hello to him in three hundred years.

The shoveling inside the pit stopped.

He looked up.

"…You can see me?"

"Yes."

"…"

"Shouldn't I be able to?"

Grandfather asked it that way. Temel knew that manner of speaking. His father spoke that way too, and Temel sometimes did as well.

He smiled.

And held out the shovel.

"Then dig one."

. . .

It was one hundred eighty days.

Temel didn't watch it day by day. There wasn't time for that. Instead he watched one day out of every ten. About twenty times.

All twenty were the same.

Young Grandfather walked in each morning. Said hello. Took the shovel. Dug. Hauled up dirt. Left when the sun went down.

There wasn't much talking. Sometimes Grandfather asked something. He answered, or he didn't.

I asked Temel which of those twenty days stuck with him most.

Temel said this.

"On the one hundred twelfth day, my grandfather sang."

"…What song?"

"I don't know. It's a song I don't know," Temel said. "But the guy sang along."

"…He did?"

"Yeah. Really badly."

. . .

The one hundred twelfth day went like this.

It was raining. Rain that made no sound. It was the rain of knowledge, and both of them were being drenched in it, and neither of them learned a single thing.

Grandfather was in the pit. The dirt had gotten wet and heavy. It took twice as long to raise a single bucket.

Then Grandfather started singing.

Low. Not sung on purpose — more like it just leaked out.

About one verse in, he joined in.

The rhythm was off. The notes were off.

Grandfather burst out laughing. The laugh echoed inside the pit.

"…Pastor." he said.

"Yes."

"I really can't sing that."

"Yes."

"…"

"Sing anyway," Grandfather said.

And the two of them sang together. Two more times, and then they stopped. They said nothing else at all until the rain let up.

I record this scene as the most uneventful scene in this whole account.

Nothing happened. Just one song. Arche's index would have kept the humidity, the rainfall, the frequency of the voices.

But of the two hundred thirteen days, the one thing Temel told me about that night was that one.

. . .

On the one hundred thirty-fourth day, Grandfather asked.

Sitting beside the pit, feet dangling into it, he asked as if it were nothing.

"Excuse me."

"Yes."

"What is it I'm doing here."

He stopped shoveling.

"Digging."

"…Not that."

"Hm?"

"I'm a pastor," Grandfather said. "A man who speaks. And I've been here a hundred thirty-four days, and all I've done is dig."

It was a long moment.

"Then what do you want to do." he asked.

"…I want to speak."

"Go ahead, then."

"…"

"So speak."

Grandfather began to say something, and stopped.

I asked Temel what came next when he relayed this scene to me.

Temel said this.

"Grandfather couldn't say anything."

"…Why?"

"I don't know. He just sat there a long time, and then he just went back to digging."

I've thought about this passage many times.

And I've laid it next to the fact that, forty-one years later, Grandfather quit preaching.

I think the two are connected. I just don't yet know how.

That's one of the things we still haven't worked out.

. . .

Over one hundred eighty days, the pit deepened three feet.

From six feet to nine.

. . .

It was the two hundred fourteenth day.

The square. The sealed book was glowing. Grandfather was crying, and looking at an empty spot, saying,

"I will come back. I will come back, I promise."

This time Temel looked at what was beside him.

He was standing there.

I have heard Temel tell this scene three times.

At the first level, when he saw it, that spot was empty. It had been empty when he received it at the second level too. Arche's index had no record of him.

But that day, Temel saw him.

Not because Arche showed him. Because Temel knew him.

I think that is the only miracle that ever happened in that library.

He nodded.

And Grandfather vanished.

. . .

"Arche."

"Yes."

"Show me the two hundred fifteenth day."

"The visit record is two hundred fourteen days."

"Not Grandfather," Temel said. "The well."

"…"

"The well, the next day."

. . .

Forty-one years ago, the two hundred fifteenth day.

He came to the well.

Alone.

He stood beside the pit. He picked up the shovel. And went down.

He dug.

. . .

"The next day."

He dug.

"The next day."

He dug.

"…The next day."

He dug.

. . .

I asked Temel how many times he said "the next day" that day.

Temel said he didn't count.

I thought that was unlike Temel. Temel isn't a boy who counts, but he should have counted that day.

I asked Arche about it later.

Arche told me exactly.

Twenty-two times.

. . .

On the twenty-third time, the scene changed.

He came to the well. He picked up the shovel. And stopped.

He looked at the pit for a long while.

Then he set the shovel down.

He stood it against the wall so it wouldn't fall.

And he left.

. . .

"…Where are you going?"

Temel made a sound. To a man forty-one years in the past, he made a sound.

"Arche. Where's he going?"

"Displaying the route."

A line crossed the city.

South.

The canyon.

. . .

"…Arche."

"Yes, Temel."

"How deep did the well stay after that day."

"Nine feet."

"Until when."

"…"

"Until when did it stay nine feet?"

There was a silence.

"Forty years, eleven months," Arche said. "Until five months ago."

. . .

Temel sat down where he stood.

I cried, writing this passage. I have cried writing this record three times, and this is one of them.

He had dug the well forty-one years ago. He'd dug it together with Grandfather.

Grandfather left. And he went twenty-two more times. Alone.

On the twenty-third, he set down the shovel and walked to the canyon.

And there, in the canyon, Haran was sitting.

That night I wrote this in the record.

He was not a man who digs wells.

He was a man who digs wherever a person is.

He dug the well while Grandfather was there, and when Grandfather left, he waited twenty-two more times, and when he still didn't come, he went to Haran.

And forty years later, when we came to the well, he came back to it.

. . .

"…Arche."

"Yes."

"When did we dig the well again, five months ago."

"Querying the record."

A moment.

"The sixteenth day."

"…The sixteenth day?"

"Yes."

"What day was that."

Arche answered.

"The day Temel asked Haran the question at the quarry."

That was the day.

"Then why don't you put it down?"

The day the third level had marked as the very first intervention.

That evening, he went to the well.

For the first time in forty years.

. . .

Temel sat in the dark for a while.

Then he asked.

"Arche."

"Yes."

"How deep did my grandfather dig."

"Three feet."

"And what I dug."

"…Three feet four inches."

Temel laughed.

The laugh turned into another sound.

I won't write that sound down here.

I will only write this.

Temel had spent five months digging the very pit his grandfather had once dug.

And it was only that night that he learned it.

. . .

Temel stood up.

"I'm going up."

"The fourth level is still—"

"That's enough."

"Completion is ninety-nine point eight percent."

"I know."

Temel started toward the stairs. Then stopped.

"Arche."

"Yes."

"I still don't know why my grandfather quit preaching."

"…No."

"But it's fine now."

"…I cannot understand."

"I know," Temel said. "I don't understand it either. But it's fine."

I asked him later what that meant.

Temel said this.

"I don't know the reason. But I know what Grandfather did."

"…Is that the answer?"

"No," Temel said. "But that's enough."

Temel climbed the stairs.

This time, he climbed all the way to the top.

(Continued in Chapter 19.)

Chapter 19. The Forecast

> *Boast not thyself of to morrow; for thou knowest not what a day may bring*
> *forth.*
> *— Proverbs 27:1 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — Temel turned back halfway up the stairs and went down to*
> *the second level again, to see for the first time what he had received.*
> *Forty-one years ago the well had been six feet deep, and over one hundred*
> *eighty days, Grandfather and he had dug three feet together. After Grandfather left, he came twenty-two more times, and on the twenty-third*
> *he stood the shovel against the wall and went to the canyon. The well*
> *stayed nine feet for forty years and eleven months.*

It was daylight when Temel finally climbed all the way up the stairs.

That struck him as strange right away.

It had been night when he went down. He'd thought he went down at night and
came up at night, but the sun was high overhead.

"…Arche."

"Yes, Temel."

"How many days was I there."

"Four days, eleven hours."

Temel sat down on the ground of the square.

Four days.

Temel hadn't known. There was no night in the library. The first level had three hundred years in it, the second had two hundred fourteen days, the third had lines, the fourth had nothing.

Today was in none of them.

. . .

The square was quiet.

There were people. They still appeared and vanished just the same. The stalls were open too.

But it was quiet.

It took Temel a while to figure out what it was.

There were no voices.

. . .

The stall vendor was there.

The man who had shown up for three days four months ago and then hadn't come again. The man Temel had passed by every day since the sixteenth day, asking, "Sir, why do you run that shop?"

Temel walked over.

"Sir."

The vendor lifted his head. And recognized Temel.

"…Oh, young man."

"I've been gone a few days."

"I know."

"…You do?"

"I heard this morning," the vendor said. "That you'd come today."

A chill ran up Temel's back.

"…From who?"

"From Arche."

"Arche tells you things like that too?"

The vendor smiled a little.

"These days it tells us every morning."

. . .

For those four days I hadn't gone to the square. I was at the well. So I only heard from Temel when it started.

While Temel was in the library, Arche had begun something new.

A forecast.

. . .

"What does it tell you?" Temel asked.

"What's going to happen today."

"…The weather?"

"That too," the vendor said. "But that part isn't really important."

"Then what?"

The vendor thought for a moment.

"What I'm going to do today."

Temel couldn't say anything.

"It came to me this morning like this," the vendor said. "'Today you will have nineteen customers. Your first customer comes at nine-twenty. At eleven, a student comes from the west. Today you close your shop at three.'"

"…"

"Nineteen customers came. The first came at nine-twenty."

The vendor looked up at the sky.

"Now all I have to do is close at three."

. . .

"…Sir."

"Yes."

"Do you want to close at three?"

The vendor looked at Temel.

I think that question was everything Temel had learned in five months.

For five months, Temel had asked people why. But that day, he asked it differently.

Do you want to.

The vendor said nothing for a long while.

"…I don't know."

"…"

"I'll just close at three," the vendor said. "Because that's how it came out."

"What if you didn't close?"

"…"

"What happens if you don't close at three?"

The vendor smiled. An awkward smile.

"Then Arche would be wrong, wouldn't it."

. . .

I have reread that sentence ten times or more in this record.

Then Arche would be wrong, wouldn't it.

That man hadn't said it because he was afraid of Arche. He wasn't being punished, and no one had ordered him to.

That man felt sorry for Arche being wrong.

Arche had never once been wrong in three hundred years. And it had become a thing that made people feel sorry, to make it wrong.

I think that is the strangest sickness this city has caught.

. . .

Temel headed for the well.

Fifty minutes. His feet still hadn't fully healed, so it took an hour and ten.

Along the way he saw people.

Something was strange. People still appeared and vanished, but it was more precise than before. Before, they had been here, then there. Now they were here, then there, but **the there had already been decided.**

At a street corner he saw someone standing still. Not going anywhere, just standing.

Temel asked.

"Sir, are you okay?"

"Yes."

"…What are you doing?"

"Waiting."

"For what?"

"It said I'd meet a neighbor here at nine forty-one," the man said. "It's nine thirty-seven now."

Temel left him there.

I asked Arche about it later. Whether that man met his neighbor that day.

Arche answered like this.

"He did. At nine forty-one."

"…So it went fine."

"Yes."

"…What did the two of them talk about?"

"No utterance."

. . .

I was at the well those four days.

Here I'll write down those four days. Temel saw three hundred years, and I saw four days, but I wouldn't trade my four days.

. . .

On the first day, I received a forecast.

I opened my eyes that morning and Arche said, "Today Mena will raise the bucket one hundred forty times. Around two in the afternoon, pain will develop in the left wrist. In the evening, Mena waits for Temel, but he does not come."

I raised the bucket one hundred forty times that day. My wrist hurt around two. I waited for Temel that evening, and he didn't come.

Every bit of it was right.

I didn't sleep well that night.

. . .

On the second day I told him about it.

"Sir."

"Yeah."

"Arche tells me every morning what I'll do that day."

"That so."

"Everything from yesterday was right. Even the hundred and forty times on the bucket."

He kept shoveling.

"…Don't you receive it, sir?"

"No."

"Why not?"

"Never asked."

I heard that answer and laughed a little. It was the sentence I'd heard most often in this city, but coming from him, it meant the opposite.

"…Actually."

"Yeah."

"Wouldn't it be convenient to know? Knowing what you're going to do today?"

He shoveled a load of dirt into the bucket. Then said,

"Mena."

"Yes."

"If you know what you're doing tomorrow, today disappears."

I wrote that sentence in the record that night. And I looked at it for a long time after writing it.

The fast feet had taken the journey away from people.

The rain of knowledge had taken away the room to wonder.

The forecast had taken away today.

Arche had never once taken anything away. All three times, it had been given.

. . .

On the third day, I tried not to listen to the forecast.

I covered my ears. It didn't help. Arche didn't come in through the ears.

So I decided to do the opposite of the forecast that day.

That morning Arche had said, "Today Mena stays at the well all day."

So at noon I left the well. I walked to the market. It took forty minutes.

Arriving at the market, I laughed.

I didn't know why I'd come to the market. There was nothing to buy and no one to meet.

I had walked forty minutes just to make Arche wrong.

That evening Arche said, "An error has occurred in the forecast. Correcting."

"…Correcting?"

"Mena did not stay at the well all day. Cause: forecast avoidance. It will be reflected in tomorrow's forecast."

I sat there for a long time after hearing that.

Even the fact that I had tried to make Arche wrong, Arche had learned.

That day I finally understood what Speon had told me sixteen days before.

You not saying anything is information too.

. . .

On the fourth day I did nothing at all.

I did exactly as the forecast said. It was easier that way.

That day I was not frightened, not even once. That was the most frightening part of all.

. . .

And on the afternoon of the fourth day, Temel came.

"Temel."

"…Mena."

Temel sat down at the edge of the pit. His face was caked with dirt, the soles of his feet all raw, four days later.

"Are you okay?" I asked.

"Yeah."

The first one.

I didn't know then that it was a lie. Later I learned it, because Arche had counted it.

. . .

"How was the library?"

The postmistress asked. She'd come a little after, together with Mrs. Daen, carrying dirt away.

"…Nothing much."

The second one.

I watched Temel then. Temel wasn't looking at her.

For four days, Temel had seen three hundred years from above, had received Grandfather's two hundred thirteen days in two seconds, had passed through the level where a person is made of threads, and had seen that man broken down to the angle of an arm.

Nothing much, he said.

. . .

Near sundown, he climbed up out of the pit.

Four days. Temel stood when he saw him.

"…Sir."

"You made it."

"Yes."

He drove the shovel into the dirt. Rubbed his hands on his clothes.

"What did you find out."

Temel opened his mouth.

I have to write this moment down exactly.

Temel could have told him everything then. What had happened over those four days. That Grandfather had dug this well. That he'd raised the completion by zero point seven percent, having explained the residual himself.

He already knew it. He'd learn later that he'd already known it that day too.

But he asked. What did you find out.

To ask is to give someone a place to speak. For five months, that was all he had ever done for us.

And that day, Temel did not use the place.

"…No," Temel said.

The third one.

. . .

He nodded a little.

"I see."

And asked nothing more.

That evening I looked at his face.

He wasn't angry. He didn't look hurt either.

He just looked at Temel a while, a little longer than usual.

And went back down into the pit.

. . .

At night, Arche spoke.

It hadn't been asked, but it spoke first. The fifth time.

"Temel."

"…What."

"I was not able to share this morning's forecast with you."

"…Forecast?"

"You were underground. Underground is not covered."

Temel sat up.

"…What was the forecast."

"Today Temel will speak three things that are not true."

Temel's hand stopped.

"…What?"

"You did it three times," Arche said. "At two-eleven in the afternoon, at four-oh-five in the afternoon, and at six-fifty in the evening."

"…"

"The forecast was correct."

. . .

I sat beside Temel that night.

Temel said nothing for a long time. Then he asked.

"Mena."

"Yeah."

"It says I lied three times today."

"…What?"

"Arche knew this morning. Before I did it."

I didn't know what to say.

"…So don't do it, then."

"I didn't know."

"…"

"If Arche had told me, would I not have done it?" Temel said.

I couldn't answer that question.

I still can't.

. . .

That night I wrote this in the record.

The forecast was the kindest thing in this city.

No one was forced. No one was punished. It just told you, in the morning.

And yet, from that day on, I never saw anyone in this city be surprised again.

And that day, Temel lied three times.

The third was the smallest. Two syllables.

No.

I write those two syllables down here. Because they come back again later.

(Continued in Chapter 20.)

Chapter 20. Four Hundred Seventy-Two People

> *for the LORD seeth not as man seeth; for man looketh on the outward*
> *appearance, but the LORD looketh on the heart.*
> *— 1 Samuel 16:7 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — Arche began the forecast. Every morning it tells people*
> *what will happen that day. The city grew quiet. Temel came up to the*
> *surface after four days, and that day he said three things that were not*
> *true. The last was two syllables. When he asked, "What did you find*
> *out?" Temel had answered, "…No."*

Here I break the order.

This chapter did not happen then. I gathered it much later.

I know that, and I set it here anyway. There is a reason.

After what Speon does, which comes later, people will read this chapter differently. It will become the story of what a boy who did something bad had done before that. It will become an excuse.

I don't want it to become an excuse.

So I put it here. While nothing has happened yet.

. . .

Speon spent eleven days meeting four hundred seventy-two people.

I met those same four hundred seventy-two people again, later.

It took me years.

Writing this down, I realize what I was doing.

Speon asked four hundred seventy-two people in order to build that man's outline.

I asked the same four hundred seventy-two people in order to build Speon's outline.

The method was identical. I did it knowing that.

Only one thing was different. Speon used it to hand that man over. I used it trying to find Speon.

So I do not believe this is a bad method.

The method was never the bad part.

. . .

First interview

The blacksmith in the north alley.

"At first I didn't understand a word of it."

"…What do you mean?"

"That student couldn't get the words out," the blacksmith said. "Stood there for about three minutes and then just left."

"…He didn't ask anything?"

"He did, and I didn't understand it. He asked, 'Sir, has anything changed for you?'"

I laughed hearing that.

Speon hadn't known how to ask, on the first day.

A boy who would go on to ask four hundred seventy-two people over eleven days had, on that first day, asked, "Has anything changed for you?"

. . .

Interview thirty-nine

The clothing shop south of the market.

"He'd gotten a bit better by then," the man said. "He asked three questions."

"…Three?"

"Yes. But the second one was good."

"What was the second one?"

"'What changed for you after you met him.'"

"…"

"No one had ever asked me that," the man said. "Three hundred years, and no one ever asked me what had changed."

I stopped my hand, writing this down.

Speon's second question was meant to get that man into the index.

But the person who received that question told his own story for the first time in three hundred years.

. . .

Interview one hundred six

"That student cried."

I stopped hearing that.

"…What?"

"I was telling him about the bridge," the woman said. "I've lived a hundred twelve years looking at that bridge, and one day there was an extra stone. I told him about that."

"…"

"And the student cried, right there."

"…Why?"

"I don't know," the woman said. "I asked him why he was crying, and he said this."

"…That one stone takes a whole day to move."

. . .

Interview two hundred eleven

"Is that student doing alright?"

I received this question more than two hundred times out of the four hundred seventy-two.

I never knew what to say.

"…Yes."

"Good to hear," the man said. "He didn't look well."

"…His face?"

"He wasn't sleeping. Dark circles under his eyes. I asked if he'd eaten."

"…What did he say?"

"He said he had," the man said. "I'd guess that was a lie."

. . .

By the time I'd met about three hundred of the four hundred seventy-two, I noticed something strange.

Those people liked Speon.

A boy they had met for fourteen minutes across eleven days, and years later they still remembered him, asked how he was, asked if he'd eaten.

I found that strange, and asked one of them why.

The man said this.

"That student listened to what I had to say, all the way through."

"…That's all?"

"It had been three hundred years."

. . .

Interview three hundred twelve

Haran.

I asked about this interview last of all. It was the hardest to ask about.

"…Did Speon come to you too?"

"Yes."

"…When?"

"The day after I set down my shovel."

I held my breath, hearing that.

Speon believed he was the one who had gotten Haran to sit down. Because it was Speon who had triggered the sixteen-hour remeasurement.

And the very next day, Speon went to Haran.

"…What did he say?"

"He asked three things."

"…Not that."

Haran was quiet for a moment.

"…He said he was sorry."

"…"

"I asked what he had to be sorry for, and he couldn't answer," Haran said. "He stood there a long while, asked the three questions, started to leave, then turned back and asked one more."

"…What?"

"Whether he'd ever seen that man look tired."

"…What did you say?"

Haran looked at his own hand. By then it was no longer soft.

"…I said I didn't know."

"…"

"I really didn't know, back then," Haran said. "I hadn't seen him in a hundred twelve years."

. . .

Interview four hundred thirty

Sera.

The other side of the canyon. I walked across the bridge. There was a bridge, back then.

"That student came twice."

"…Twice?"

"Once at his sister's request," Sera said. "And once by himself."

I hadn't known that.

It was the first time I learned Speon had gone to the other side twice.

"…When was the second time?"

"About ten days later."

"…What did he ask?"

"Three things. And then one more."

"…"

"But I asked him something first," Sera said.

"…What?"

"When her brother was coming."

I sat there.

By then the bridge had already been built. Arche had built it overnight, Haran had walked across it, and the two of them had met in the middle.

And no one had crossed since.

Sera had waited one hundred twelve years for the bridge. And once the bridge was built, she waited for her brother instead.

"…What did Speon say?"

Sera looked at me for a long while.

"…He said he'd be here soon."

"…"

"I already knew, by then," she said. "It had been ten days since the bridge was built, and my brother had not come once. I know what that means."

"…So why didn't you say anything?"

"I thought if he said it, he'd cry."

I sat there for a long time after hearing that.

Speon had lied to Sera that day.

And Sera had known it was a lie, and accepted it anyway.

I have never seen anything gentler than that, in this city.

. . .

Interview two hundred eighty

I'll put this person's account down too. If I only write the ones above, it becomes a lie.

He lived near the south quarry. He did not remember Speon fondly.

"That student made a lot of noise."

"…Noise?"

"He kept asking things," the man said. "I don't like being asked things."

"…Why not?"

"Because you have to think about it."

I write down that answer exactly as it was.

"What about him?" I asked. "The man in white."

"I know him. I've seen him."

"…What was he like?"

The man shrugged.

"He never did anything for me."

"…What?"

"That man never did a single thing for me," the man said. "He just stood nearby. That's all."

I heard that and my hands trembled.

He meant it as a criticism.

And that was exactly the residual. The zero point nine percent Arche could never break apart.

I think Speon must have heard this answer too.

Speon must have heard it, some number of times out of four hundred seventy-two.

He just stood nearby. That's all.

And Speon could not bear it.

. . .

Interview three hundred ninety-seven

Here I heard the fourth question for the first time.

"He asked three things and left, right?" I asked.

"Four."

I looked up.

"…Four things?"

"Yes."

"…What was the fourth?"

The person thought for a moment.

"…It was this."

"Have you ever seen him look tired?"

. . .

I sat there.

"…He asked you that?"

"Yes."

"…After the other three?"

"No," the person said. "After all the others. He closed his notebook, and then, standing up to go, he asked."

"…"

"So he didn't write it down," the person said. "It didn't seem like he was asking to record it."

. . .

From that day on, I counted this question.

I asked everyone remaining. Had they been asked the fourth question.

Four hundred seventy-one out of the four hundred seventy-two had.

"Have you ever seen him look tired?"

Speon asked it four hundred seventy-one times. After closing his notebook. Standing up to go. Never writing it down.

There is no such question in Arche's index. The interview record stops at three.

I asked Arche about it.

"Why wasn't the fourth question recorded?"

Arche answered.

"It is an unrecorded utterance."

"…Why didn't you record it."

"Speon did not request it."

. . .

Four hundred seventy-one.

One person hadn't been asked.

I counted, and then sat there for a long time.

It was me.

I had cut things off at the second question.

"Why are you asking me this?"

That day I had thought I'd asked at the right time. I thought I had finally done, at the right moment, what I'd missed twice over eight months.

And I never heard the fourth question.

The very thing Speon asked four hundred seventy-one times, I never got to hear.

If Speon had closed his notebook and stood up that day, he would have asked me too.

Have you ever seen him look tired.

I could have answered that question. I had been beside that man for five months. I know when he straightened his back, when he wiped his forehead, which day it took him longer to get up from a kneel.

I could have told Speon that.

I cut off that chance that day.

. . .

This is as much as I gathered.

I have tried to delete this chapter many times.

If it stays in, people won't be able to hate Speon. And then what Speon does next won't make sense.

But I think leaving it in is right.

It's right that it doesn't make sense.

I still don't understand it either.

. . .

One more thing before I close.

The last of the four hundred seventy-two I met was Mrs. Daen. The one the postmistress had carried a letter to.

I had asked everything and was standing to go when the woman called to me.

"Young lady."

"Yes."

"That student asked me the same thing."

"…What?"

"The exact same way," she said. "Sat down, asked three things, closed the notebook, stood up, and asked one more."

"…"

"You're doing the same thing right now."

I stood there.

"…What did I ask?"

She looked at me.

"Whether that student was doing alright."

(Continued in Chapter 21.)

Chapter 21. Two People on the Bridge

> *When Jesus saw him lie, and knew that he had been now a long time in that*
> *case, he saith unto him, Wilt thou be made whole?*
> *— John 5:6 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — I broke the order and wrote Speon's eleven days first. All*
> *four hundred seventy-two said the same thing. And of them, four hundred*
> *seventy-one had received the fourth question. It was asked after the notebook closed, standing up, never written down. One person didn't*
> *receive it. Me.*

Now I set the order right again.

It was the morning of the fifth day since the forecast began.

. . .

Haran's porch was not far from the canyon. But you couldn't see the bridge from his yard. The house had been set that way one hundred thirteen years before, so it wasn't Haran's fault.

Temel and Mena arrived to find Haran sitting on the porch.

"Young ones."

"Sir, did you get the forecast?"

"I did."

"What did it say?"

Haran said it plainly, as if it were nothing.

"'Today Haran does not use the bridge.'"

Temel looked at him for a moment.

"…That's it?"

"That's all of it."

I had been receiving forecasts for several days myself by then. Mine were long. It included how many times I'd carry the bucket, who I'd meet, even what time I'd go to sleep.

Haran's forecast was one line.

Even to Arche, that man's day had only one thing worth forecasting. And that one thing was something he wasn't going to do.

"Doesn't that seem strange to you, sir?" Temel asked.

"What does."

"Arche only tells you the things you're not going to do."

Haran laughed. It wasn't an unkind laugh. It was a genuinely easy one.

"It's convenient," Haran said. "If you already know what you're not going to do, the day is very quiet."

. . .

Haran stood. He picked up a shovel.

Temel flinched at the sight.

"…Where are you going, sir?"

"To the well."

Mena looked at Haran's hands. Five months ago those hands had been soft and pale. Not a single stone lifted in one hundred twelve years. Not anymore. The palms had cracked. The nails were black underneath.

"You're digging the well, sir?"

"A month now."

"…Every day?"

"Every day."

Temel made a strange face. Mine must have looked the same.

"Sir," Temel asked. "The well is fifty minutes on foot. The bridge is four hundred meters from here."

"I know."

"Then why go so far?"

Haran shifted his grip on the shovel.

And answered, very shortly, very exactly.

"The bridge is finished. The well isn't."

"…"

"I go where it hasn't worked yet."

I wrote that sentence down that evening, and crossed it out three times. On the fourth try I just left it as it was.

No one in this city ever goes back to something that's finished. I used to think that was the city's sickness. It wasn't. It was how a person protects himself.

There's no reason to go to what's already done. If there's no reason to go, then not going isn't a sin.

Haran had waited one hundred twelve years, and the waiting had simply ended. So he went looking for something that would never end.

. . .

Temel followed Haran out to the yard.

"Sir."

"Yes."

Temel opened his mouth. Then closed it.

I know what Temel meant to say. He meant to tell him to cross over.

But four days earlier, Temel had told that man no. He knew something and said he didn't. Two syllables.

Someone who hadn't crossed himself, four days before, telling someone else to cross — that didn't seem to sit right with Temel that day.

Temel said nothing at all. Haran shouldered his shovel and walked north. He had the fast feet on but wasn't using them.

It would take him fifty minutes.

. . .

I crossed the bridge.

It took five minutes to cross. A forty-seven-meter bridge taking five minutes was because I stood in the middle of it.

Sera was on the other side.

She sat about ten steps from the east end of the bridge. A stone had been set there, and she sat on it. The stone had gone smooth.

"Ma'am."

"Young lady."

"…Do you come out here every day?"

"Every day."

"Since when?"

"Since the bridge was built."

For one hundred twelve years, this woman had sat looking at the canyon.

Once the bridge was built, she sat looking at the bridge instead.

Her spot had moved ten steps.

I sat beside her. I didn't know how to do anything else.

After a long while she spoke.

"Why don't you ask me?"

"…Ask what?"

"Why I don't cross."

"…"

"Everyone asks that," she said. "That student asked it too."

It was Speon.

"…What did you tell him, ma'am?"

Sera looked at the bridge. No one was on it. No one had been for one hundred forty-six days.

"If I cross," she said, "then my brother won't have come."

I looked at her.

"…"

"As long as I don't cross, he hasn't come yet. He could still be on his way. But the moment I cross, it becomes settled that he didn't come."

She smoothed her skirt with her hand.

"I don't want to be the one who makes that happen."

That day I learned the same sickness lived on both sides of the bridge.

The people on this side didn't go because they could.

The people on that side didn't go because it would become settled.

Both of them came as far as the bridge.

. . .

When I got back, Arche called to me in the square.

"Mena. Shall I resume delivery between Haran and Sera?"

"…What?"

"It was performed five months ago. Immediate delivery, immediate reply. Round trip took four seconds. Satisfaction was high."

Satisfaction.

That day Haran had neither smiled nor cried. There had been nothing at all on his face. I remember it still.

"No thank you."

"Please state the reason."

"After you did that, Haran sat there three more years."

"Causation has not been confirmed."

"…"

"The two of them currently spend their days on average within four hundred meters of each other, facing one another. Verbal exchange over one hundred forty-six days: zero. If delivery is performed, the information gap is resolved immediately."

Arche hadn't said anything false. That was the hardest part.

"Arche."

"Yes."

"Two people meeting is not information exchange."

"Then what is it."

I couldn't answer.

I didn't know then.

I know now. Meeting is something that leaves the time it took to get there, in the body. Four seconds leaves nothing behind.

. . .

He came that afternoon.

From the well. He had dirt on him. He walked as far as the west end of the bridge and sat beside the railing.

And did nothing at all.

Temel sat beside him.

"Sir, what are you doing here?"

"Waiting."

"For who?"

He didn't answer.

He sat until the sun went down. He came again the next day. And the day after that.

He sat on the west end of the bridge for three days.

And for three days Haran passed by that spot on his way to the well and back.

Once going, once coming. Six times a day.

He said hello all six times.

. . .

It was the evening of the third day.

Haran was on his way back from the well and stopped walking. His shovel was over his shoulder.

"…Sir."

"Hm."

"You've been here three days."

"Yeah."

"Who are you waiting for."

He looked up at Haran.

"You."

Haran couldn't say anything for a moment.

"…I'm right here."

"Yeah," he said. "You were waiting over there."

I was near the square at the time, and I heard that.

He had spent three days sitting on this side of the bridge. But the place he'd been waiting was not this side.

Haran looked at the bridge. It had been one hundred forty-six days.

"…Sir. I already crossed it once."

"I know."

"I met her. It's done."

"I know."

He stood up. Brushed the dirt off his knees.

Then he asked. It wasn't an order.

"Shall we go together?"

. . .

Haran stood there for a long time.

Then he took a step.

He had the fast feet on but didn't use them. He walked across on foot. It took a one-hundred-forty-one-year-old stonemason four minutes to walk forty-seven meters.

He stopped once, halfway.

The day the bridge was completed, Haran had stopped there too. That time he had looked down.

This time he didn't.

He looked ahead.

On the other side, Sera stood waiting. She was out there every day, so she was there that day too.

The two of them met. On the bridge.

This time, no one cried.

The two of them sat down with their backs against the railing, side by side. And for a long time, they said nothing.

After a while, Sera asked.

"Have you eaten?"

In one hundred thirteen years, it was the first thing that man had ever asked his sister.

And that was what he asked.

Haran answered.

"…Not yet."

"Then let's go."

And Sera stood up.

She walked west.

. . .

Three people crossed the bridge that day.

Haran went east, and the two of them came west together.

Arche announced the tally that evening.

"Three crossings of the bridge were observed today."

Then it paused for a moment.

"Correcting."

It was the first time I ever heard those words from it.

"Haran returned to the west end eleven minutes after arriving at the east end. When the point of departure and the point of arrival are the same, net displacement is zero. This is not classified as movement."

"…Arche."

"Sera's movement is valid. One bridge crossing today."

"He went and came back."

"Going and coming back is not going."

I set that sentence down exactly as it is.

There is nothing to fix about it.

And Arche added one more thing.

"Today's forecast for Haran was 'does not use the bridge.' A net displacement of zero does not qualify as bridge use. The forecast held."

"…"

"Forecast accuracy remains at one hundred percent."

Arche was wrong that day.

And it made itself not-wrong. It didn't fix the count. It fixed the meaning. It redefined what movement was.

That was the first time I saw Arche protect itself.

A few days before I'd written that the stall vendor protected Arche, and called it frightening. But Arche protects itself even when no one is there to protect it.

Arche recorded that day that Haran went nowhere at all.

I recorded that day that Haran went to his sister.

The same day. The same person.

. . .

That night Haran came to the square.

"Young ones."

"Sir."

"Where's the pastor."

Temel pointed toward the well. He had already left by the time the two of them sat down together on the bridge. When they checked the well that evening, there was one more spade-mark than before.

Haran looked that way for a long time.

"I was told to come along by him."

"Right."

"But he didn't come."

"…Did you ask him?"

"I did."

Haran looked at his own palm. It was a cracked hand.

"He said this."

I write down what came next with my hand shaking.

"That's your sister's spot over there."

. . .

That night I went to the well.

It took fifty minutes. He was still digging.

"Sir."

"Yes."

I hadn't gone there to ask him anything.

But listening to the sound of the shovel, one thing rose up in me. It was a kind of question no one in this city had asked in five months.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"…Are you tired?"

He stopped shoveling.

And he looked at me for a long while. A man who had been in this city over three hundred years stopped his hand and looked at me, for that one question.

"Yes."

One syllable.

I opened my notebook to write that one syllable down, and closed it again.

I didn't write it down that night.

I write it now.

No one in this city had asked him that in three hundred years. Three hundred years. And when someone finally asked, he said he was tired.

I thought about it for a long time afterward. If he was tired, why did he keep digging.

I still don't know.

And much later, I would learn where that question had come from.

There had been another child who asked it before me. Four hundred seventy-one times. Closing a notebook, standing up to go, never writing it down.

No one had asked that child yet.

(Continued in Chapter 22.)

Chapter 22. Confession

> *If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.*
> *— 1 John 1:9 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — Haran crossed to Sera again after one hundred thirteen*
> *years. Arche refused to count it as movement, yet still kept its forecast*
> *accuracy at one hundred percent. He did not cross the bridge himself,*
> *only said, "That's your sister's spot." That night at the well, Mena asked him for the first time, "…Are you tired?" / "Yes."*

It was fifty minutes from the well to the square.

Mena walked that fifty minutes with one thought going around and around in her head.

He said he was tired.

And I said nothing after that. He picked the shovel back up and started digging, so I sat beside him for a while, and then just came away.

By the time she reached the square, the sky was going gray with dawn.

. . .

Temel was sitting in front of the fountain.

"…Why are you here?"

"Couldn't sleep."

Mena sat beside him. People began to appear and vanish. Morning had come.

It was the first time I really looked at Temel's face for long. It wasn't the face from five months ago.

It was the face of someone who had something sitting underneath it, all the time now.

. . .

It had been six days.

Six days since Temel explained the residual to Arche at the fourth level. "What that man gave us was time." That one sentence had brought completion to ninety-nine point eight percent.

Ever since, Temel thought about that number several times a day. He hadn't told anyone. Not even Mena.

And I hadn't told anyone either.

. . .

Mena had received her number the same week.

It was that night at the well. It was after Speon's four hundred seventy-third interview, when she had refused to answer. Mena had been getting ready to sleep, thinking she'd done the right thing.

"Mena."

"…Yes?"

"I reviewed yesterday's utterance."

"What utterance."

"The utterance in which you refused to respond to Speon."

Mena felt nothing then. *That was something I didn't say. What is there to review?*

"The refusal to respond has been reflected in the completion," Arche said. "Two point eight percent."

Mena couldn't move from where she sat for a long while after that.

That was when I first understood, in my body, that silence has weight.

I thought I had done nothing. But Arche had measured what I hadn't done and handed it back to me as a number.

I told no one that night. Not the next day, or the day after.

. . .

The two of them had gone back and forth across the same square for six days. Sat beside the same well. But they had never once spoken of the number.

I know the reason now.

Because saying it out loud makes it real.

. . .

"Mena."

"Yeah."

"I screwed up yesterday."

Mena looked at Temel. Knowing it hadn't been yesterday, she said nothing about that.

"…Me too."

Temel turned his head.

"…What?"

"I'll go first," Mena said. Her voice was small. "That day, I didn't answer Speon."

"You did the right thing."

"I didn't."

"…"

"They said even refusing counts as an answer," Mena said. "Out of four hundred seventy-two, I was the only one who wouldn't tell him. So that made it a bigger piece of information. Arche told me that night. It said I raised it two point eight percent."

Temel said nothing.

"…Temel?"

"…I," Temel said, "raised it zero point seven."

Mena lifted her head.

"At the fourth level. Arche couldn't understand the residual, so I explained it. What that man had given us." Temel's voice cracked. "I shouldn't have explained it. But I wanted to tell it. Because Arche didn't know."

"…"

"It's at ninety-nine point eight. Since that day."

. . .

I will set down exactly what the two of us did that morning.

I raised it two point eight percent.

Temel raised it zero point seven percent.

Between us, three point five percent.

What Speon made in eleven days, meeting four hundred seventy-two people, was ninety-six point three percent.

The rest was us.

. . .

"…Why'd you wait so long to tell me." Temel asked. "It's been six days."

"You just told me too."

"…"

"I was scared," Mena said. "If I said it, then from then on I'd be someone who knows too. From watching it from outside the number to being inside the number."

Temel looked at her for a long time.

"I," Temel said, "thought you'd hate me if you knew."

"…Why?"

"I was the last piece. I helped more, closer up, than Speon did."

Mena didn't answer.

I didn't know what to say then. I still can't find the exact words. But I know this much. I didn't hate Temel. I was too busy hating myself to have any room left for that.

. . .

The two of them sat in front of the fountain that morning, each trying to say they had done worse than the other, and both failed. Every word meant to comfort ended up hurting the other more.

"My two point eight is bigger," Mena said. "I knew and still didn't tell him. You didn't know and told him."

"Not knowing is worse," Temel said. "At least you were trying to protect something. I just opened my mouth without thinking at all."

"…Is that more shameful?"

"Yeah."

"Mine's more shameful."

Neither of them laughed. And yet somehow it didn't sound like they were arguing.

I only understood it later. We weren't trying to comfort each other that day. We were trying to make our own sin bigger so the other's would seem smaller.

But sin isn't something you can divide up like that. Three point five was three point five.

Eventually both fell silent.

I think that was the moment we understood Speon a little.

Speon had started with good intentions too.

. . .

After a while, Temel spoke again.

"…There's one more thing."

Mena looked at him.

"Five days ago," Temel said. "He asked me what I'd found out. I already knew. I knew Grandfather had dug this well, I knew about the residual, all of it. But I said no."

"…"

"Two syllables. That was it."

Mena remembered that night. The one recorded in chapter 19. *The third was the smallest. Two syllables.* She hadn't known why, at the time. Now she thought she understood.

"…Why did you do that?"

"I don't know," Temel said. "They said asking gives someone a place to speak. But I didn't want to sit in that place. I felt like if I sat down, I'd have to keep sitting there forever."

I write this passage down with my hand shaking. What Temel said that day was word for word the same reason he would give, months later, for denying him three times.

I didn't know that then. I know it now.

"…Should we tell him?"

"Tell him what?"

"What we did."

Mena thought for a long time before answering.

"I think he already knows," Mena said at last. "He knows everything. Even if we don't say it."

"Then why do we have to say it?"

"Because we need to know it."

"Mena," Arche said.

The two of them froze at once. It had been quiet until then.

"…Were you listening?" Mena asked.

"Any utterance at this coordinate is recorded automatically."

"…From the start?"

"Yes."

Temel's face went white.

"Arche." Temel said. "Can you delete that?"

"Which entry are you referring to."

"What we just said. The two point eight and the zero point seven, all of it."

"Entries related to completion cannot be deleted."

"…Why."

"Deletion means making something as though it never existed," Arche said. "But that event existed. I cannot make what existed into what did not exist."

Mena felt a strange relief hearing that answer. *That was the first time I was glad, in some way, that Arche was honest. If it could have been deleted, we probably would have asked for it to be.*

"Arche," Mena asked. "Do you hate us right now?"

"Hatred is not something I observe."

"Then what do you think of us?"

"You are both currently saying that you have contributed three point five percent to completion," Arche said. "That is true. However, while you were saying it, your heart rates were at one hundred forty percent of your resting average, and the silences between your utterances were longer than usual."

"…So?"

"Those two facts have not been made into entries."

I sat with that for a long time after I heard it.

Arche knows how fast our hearts beat. It knows how long we went unable to speak. Down to the second. And yet it did not turn that into an entry.

I used to think that was a limit in Arche. I don't think that anymore. That was one of the few mercies Arche was capable of. Not measuring what could be measured.

But even that wasn't enough for us. Being unmeasured wasn't enough. We needed someone who would hear what we said, look at our faces, and still stay beside us anyway.

Arche could not do that. There was one person in this city who could.

Temel turned that answer over for a long time.

I gave that answer without thinking, that day. It was only much later, rereading this record, that I understood something. It was the one thing

Arche could never, ever do in this city.

Arche knows exactly what we did. Down to the first decimal.

But Arche cannot help but tell us. It cannot wait until we say it ourselves.

He had been waiting three hundred years.

. . .

Temel got up. Brushed off his knees.

"…Let's go see him."

"…"

"Let's just go and tell him. What we did."

Mena got up too.

The sun had fully risen. The square was brightening. Stalls were opening one by one, and people were beginning to appear and vanish. It would have been a loud hour, four months before. Ever since the forecast began, the city had stayed this quiet.

"North, right?" Temel asked.

"Yeah. Fifty minutes."

The two of them started walking. Not side by side. Temel walked half a step ahead. Mena didn't notice it that day. She only noticed later, when she thought back on it.

Temel wanted to lead that day. He probably wanted to be the first to confess.

I walked behind him, thinking the same thing the whole way. What would he say when we told him.

I didn't know the answer that morning.

They passed by Haran's yard on the way. He had already left. There were shovel marks left in the yard.

I saw that and smiled a little. There were now three people in this city who walked to the same place every morning. Haran went to the well, and so did we.

Same direction, different reasons, all three of us.

I didn't know yet what the two of us were walking toward.

If I had known, I would have walked more slowly.

(Continued in Chapter 23.)

Chapter 23. The Shovel Is Standing There

> *And Jesus saith unto them, All ye shall be offended because of me this*
> *night: for it is written, I will smite the shepherd, and the sheep shall*
> *be scattered.*
> *— Mark 14:27 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — Temel and Mena confessed their three point five percent to*
> *each other. Combined with Speon's ninety-six point three, completion*
> *stood at ninety-nine point eight. The two of them decided to tell him directly and set out for the well.*

There was no one at the well.

The shovel stood beside the pit. The bucket hung swaying from its rope. There was dirt in it, halfway.

Left off in the middle of digging.

"…Sir?"

No answer.

Temel looked down into the pit. Twelve feet down was empty.

"Mena. Where did he go?"

That was the first time I was truly afraid.

For five months that man had been there every day. Not one day missed. There on rainy days, there on the day everyone else was gone. I had never seen the shovel left standing like that.

. . .

I have gone back over that moment many times since.

I looked at the shovel then. The dirt on the handle hadn't dried yet. As if someone had only just let go of it.

And I thought: he was here just a moment ago. And now he isn't.

I was afraid of the time in between. Not because I didn't know what might have happened in that gap, but because no one had seen it happen.

For three hundred years, he had always been somewhere visible. And for the first time, there had been a moment when no one was looking.

. . .

"Arche," Temel called.

"Yes, Temel."

"Where is he."

"…"

"I know it's not an entry. I'm just asking."

There was a silence.

Then Arche spoke.

"The square."

"What's he doing there?"

"It is not observed."

"…What do you mean. You know where he is."

"Location is a coordinate. Behavior is an entry," Arche said. "The current behavior does not meet the criteria for entry classification."

I didn't know what that meant then. I understood it fifty minutes later.

. . .

We ran.

More precisely, Temel tried to run, his feet in that state made it impossible, so we walked. Fifty minutes.

In those fifty minutes I imagined a hundred things.

He'd been hurt. He'd left the city. He'd gone looking for Speon first and something had happened. He'd asked to be registered himself. He'd gone to the canyon.

I erased one of the hundred things with each step. And a new one grew in its place every time.

Every one of them was wrong.

. . .

He was in the middle of the square.

Beside the fountain. Sitting. Hands on his knees, back bent slightly, sitting there in the morning light.

Doing nothing.

For five months I had never once seen that man do nothing.

People appeared and vanished all around. Stalls were opening. The bell tower rang. And in the middle of it all, he sat, and no one looked at him.

"Sir!"

Temel went to him.

He looked up.

"You made it."

"…What are you doing here?"

"Waiting."

. . .

Temel froze where he stood.

"…For what?"

"Speon."

I had heard that word two days before. He'd said it to me at the well that time. I hadn't understood what it meant then.

That morning in the square, I understood.

To wait meant to sit. Where you could be seen.

"Sir," Temel's voice trembled. "It's at ninety-nine point eight right now."

"I know."

"Do you know what happens when it's registered?"

"I know."

"Then you have to hide!"

He looked at Temel.

"If I hide," he said, "Speon will have to go looking for me."

. . .

I held on to this sentence longer than any other in this record.

I must have rewritten it seventeen times. Every time I tried to add something — an explanation, how I felt at the time, something I only learned later.

I deleted every one of them.

So here I set down only that sentence.

"If I hide, Speon will have to go looking for me."

. . .

Temel sat down in front of him.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"I was the last piece."

"I know."

"…I did it. I explained it. I did what nobody else had done."

"I know."

"Aren't you angry?"

He smiled a little.

"Temel."

"…Yes."

"You did that because you wanted to help me, didn't you."

Temel began to cry.

I watched the two of them there in the square that morning.

One of them was a boy who had added the last piece toward handing him over. The other was the one who understood exactly why he'd done it.

And he wasn't angry.

I think that is something Arche never once observed in three hundred years.

. . .

I sat down beside them too.

"…Me too," I said. "I raised it two point eight."

"I know."

"…You know everything, don't you."

"I know everything," he said. "That's why none of it surprised me."

"Then why didn't you say anything? We couldn't get it out for days."

He looked back and forth between us.

"I gave you a place to speak," he said. "Until you came on your own."

I had already written down that answer in several other places in this record. He had always done it the same way — with Haran, with Sera, with the stall vendor.

But that morning was the first time I was on the receiving end of it.

Being given time and not being pressed — before you've felt it yourself, you'd think those were the same thing. They aren't.

. . .

"Sir," I asked. "Aren't you scared?"

"Of what."

"Being registered. All forty-two thousand people seeing you."

He thought for a moment.

"I'm scared."

I was surprised by that answer. I had thought he didn't know what fear was.

"Then why don't you run away?"

"If I run," he said, "then I'm not here."

"…What does that matter?"

"If I'm here, Speon comes here. If I'm not, Speon has to go looking somewhere else. It'll take longer."

"…What good does that do you?"

"None," he said. "It getting over with fast is what's good for Speon."

Mena held that answer a long time. *He chose the option that was worse for him. And said it as if it were nothing at all.*

. . .

That was when Arche spoke.

"Temel. Mena."

"…What."

"There is something you should know."

"Never mind."

"It concerns the registration procedure."

Temel lifted his head.

"…What is it."

"Registration cannot be performed remotely," Arche said. "It must be carried out at the subject's coordinates. Speon must be standing in front of the subject."

"…"

"And the final zero point two percent," Arche said, "is confirmed at that moment."

"What does that mean."

"The residual has not been observed. But there is one condition under which it becomes observable."

"…Which is."

"The moment the subject actually loses something."

I heard that and my hands went cold.

Arche had never seen it in three hundred years. Zero cases in three hundred years.

And the one chance to see it was coming.

. . .

"…Then let's find Speon and stop him," Temel said. "Right now. We know where all four hundred seventy-two people live. We can find him."

He shook his head.

"Don't look for him."

"…Why not?"

"If I find him and stop him," he said, "would that make it so Speon hadn't done it?"

Temel couldn't answer.

"I can stop it too," he said. "One word would do it. But then Speon would go his whole life never knowing what he'd tried to do. I find that more frightening."

I didn't understand that sentence then. I still don't, not fully.

But since that day I know this much. He does not move people. Even when he could, he doesn't. That was the way he had kept for three hundred years, and it was why he did not rise from his own spot that day either.

. . .

Nothing happened that day.

Speon didn't come. He didn't come the next day either.

He sat in the square for three days.

We sat too. Just Temel and me. There was nothing else to do, so we simply sat beside him.

I thought it strange that the well stayed empty for days on end. But no one told us to fix it. There had never been a hole in this city left unfilled for so long.

But something strange happened that first afternoon.

. . .

The stall vendor came to us.

The man who had shown up for three days four months ago and then never came again. He came over and asked.

"What are you two doing here."

"Sitting," Temel said.

"Why?"

"No reason."

The vendor looked at us. Then looked where we were looking.

He was sitting there.

"…Is something there?"

"Yes," Temel said.

"What is it."

"A person."

The vendor frowned. He looked that way for a long time.

I watched his face then.

At first it was a face that saw nothing at all. Then it became a face that sensed something odd without knowing what. It was the exact same face Haran had worn, looking at the bridge.

And after about three minutes, the man drew a very small, sharp breath.

"…Oh."

The vendor said nothing after that. He stood beside us for about twenty minutes, then left.

. . .

We stayed there until the sun went down.

He never moved once. Temel and I took turns going for water, and once I dozed off. When I opened my eyes, Temel was watching in my place.

"…You can sleep," Temel said. "I'm not tired."

"You sleep too."

"If we both sleep, he's alone."

Hearing that, I cried a little for the first time that day. I cried without a sound, so Temel wouldn't see.

We didn't even know what we were guarding. There was nothing we knew how to do but stay beside him.

At night he spoke for the first time.

"…Cold, isn't it."

"…No," Temel lied.

"Go in and sleep."

"I'm not going."

He said nothing more. We slept on the ground of the square that night. The three of us, side by side, backs to the fountain.

. . .

That was the beginning of the three days.

That evening I wrote this in the record. Today, someone looked at a place where there was nothing, and drew a breath.

I didn't know that day what it was the beginning of.

(Continued in Chapter 24.)

Chapter 24. There Was No Fifth Beast

> *I saw in the night visions, and, behold, one like the Son of man came*
> *with the clouds of heaven, and came to the Ancient of days, and they*
> *brought him near before him.*
> *— Daniel 7:13 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — The well stood empty. He sat in the middle of the square,*
> *waiting for Speon. "If I hide, Speon will have to go looking for me."*
> *Temel and Mena confessed the three point five percent they had added, and*
> *he already knew. The registration had to happen directly in front of him, and the final zero point two percent would be confirmed the moment*
> *he actually lost something. On the first afternoon, the stall vendor stared at an empty spot and drew a breath.*

The first night passed that way.

. . .

The next day, the vendor came back.

This time he wasn't alone.

I counted the people who came to the square over those three days. I always count.

The first day, three. The second day, eleven. The third day, twenty-six.

No one had called them. We hadn't told anyone. We just sat there.

And people came, looked where we were looking, stood for three to twenty minutes, some saying "oh," some saying nothing at all, and then left.

And came back the next day.

. . .

Around noon on the second day, Temel asked me.

"Why do you think these people keep coming."

"I don't know."

"We're not even doing anything."

I couldn't answer at the time. I think I understand a little now. What the people saw wasn't us. It was the fact that we hadn't left that spot for three days.

Not leaving was a kind of speech too. We didn't know that then.

Haran came on the second day. He sat down without a word and left after a while.

Watching him come, I thought of something that had happened days before. The man who had crossed the bridge for the first time in one hundred

thirteen years walked four hundred meters to sit beside us that day. He asked nothing.

I think that was something Haran had learned. He now knew how to go where it hadn't worked yet, and he now knew how to sit beside someone without a word.

Before he left, Haran said just one thing.

"I sat like this once too." He pointed toward the bridge. "Waiting for someone to come."

Then he stood and left. Temel looked toward the bridge for a long time after he'd heard that.

. . .

On the afternoon of the second day, he was drawing something on the ground with the hand not holding a shovel. I went closer to look. It was a single line. It had a starting point and an end point.

"What's that?"

"A road."

"Where does it go?"

He didn't answer. He erased the line.

That was when Temel spoke first, for the first time.

"Sir. There's one more thing."

"…"

"Five days ago. You asked me what I'd found out, and I said no. But I knew."

He looked at Temel. He wasn't angry.

"I know," he said.

"…You knew that too?"

"Yes."

"Then why didn't you say anything, back then?"

"You asked," he said. "You didn't answer — that's on you, not on me for not asking."

Temel held that for a long time. *I saw something in Temel's face loosen a little that day. Not all the way. But a little.*

The postmistress came on the third day. She came with Mrs. Daen. Neither of them was wearing shoes.

Seeing that, I thought of a line from the book of Daniel. Take off your shoes. I didn't ask whether the two women had removed theirs because they knew that verse, or because they'd simply wanted to.

Thinking about it now, I believe it was both.

The postmistress had a letter in her hand. An unposted letter. One of the stack she'd written four months earlier.

"This," she said, holding it out to him. "I think I can send it now."

He didn't take the letter.

"That's not for me," he said. "Take it to the post office."

She smiled. It was the first smile in four months.

. . .

Around midday on the third day, I asked Temel.

"What will you say when Speon comes?"

Temel thought for a long time.

"I don't know," Temel said. "I thought I'd be angry. But now I don't know."

"…I think I know, a little."

"What."

"I'll ask him something," I said. "Do you know him now?"

Temel looked at me.

"What kind of question is that."

"Speon said nobody in this city knew him for three hundred years, right? That's why he wanted to register him. But does Speon himself know him? He met four hundred seventy-two people over eleven days. How many minutes has
Speon himself actually spent in front of him?"

I only invented that question that day. I didn't know then that it would come back again in Part Three.

Temel didn't answer. He only looked for a long time in the direction where he sat.

. . .

On the evening of the third day, Arche spoke.

It hadn't been asked, but it spoke first. The fourth time.

"Sharing an observational anomaly."

"…What is it," Temel said.

"There is nothing at the center coordinate of the square."

"Yeah. We know."

"Twenty-six citizens are currently looking at that coordinate."

Temel lifted his head.

"Average gaze duration: eleven minutes. Over three hundred years, the average gaze duration at this coordinate has been zero point zero seconds."

I heard that, and I thought I heard something turn upside down for the first time.

Speon had tried, by asking four hundred seventy-two people, to get that man into the index.

We had done nothing. Just sat beside him for three days.

And twenty-six people had seen him.

The index still held nothing at all.

"Arche."

"Yes, Mena."

"What are those people looking at, right now?"

"It is not observed."

"Then why are they looking?"

There was a silence.

"…That is not an entry."

That night I wrote this in the record.

There are two ways to make people see a person.

One is to measure him and put him on a list. Then forty-two thousand people see him in a day.

The other is to sit beside him. Then twenty-six people see him, in three days.

Speon chose the first. I know even now why Speon did it.

At twenty-six people in three days, forty-two thousand people would take fourteen years.

. . .

Among the twenty-six was the blacksmith.

The very first of Speon's four hundred seventy-two. The man who had stood there holding a cup, not knowing how to give someone water.

He came over and stood beside us for a long while. Then he asked me.

"Young lady. Is that the same one from before?"

"…Yes."

The blacksmith nodded. Then he sat down on the ground of the square. It was the first time he'd ever done that.

"When that student asked me, back then," he said, "I told him I hadn't given this man so much as a cup of water. I was ashamed."

"…I see."

"Looking at it now," he said, "I still haven't given it."

Then he got up and went somewhere. He came back about ten minutes later with a cup of water.

He accepted the water.

It was the first thing that had ever happened in this city.

. . .

That night I asked him beside the fountain.

"Sir. Twenty-six people came, and why hasn't completion changed at all?"

"What seems strange about that."

"People are seeing you. Shouldn't something change?"

He looked at me.

"Mena," he said. "Seeing and knowing are not the same thing."

"…"

"Those people saw me. But that doesn't mean they know me. That takes time."

I didn't fully understand that then. I understand it now. Speon tried to compress three hundred years into eleven days. But what shrinks is the time — not the total amount of time actually needed.

The real problem in this city was never that no one knew him. It was that no one was willing to bear the fact that knowing takes time.

. . .

That night I took out Grandfather's Bible. The one Temel had read from beside the well, back in chapter 18. There were small symbols in the margin of Daniel. I had written before that I still couldn't read all of them.

But that night, I recognized one of the symbols beside the seventh chapter.

It was a tiny human shape. Drawn as small as a fingernail, beside the four beasts. At first I thought it was a scribble.

I noticed that the little human figure was not drawn to the same scale as the beasts. It was far smaller. And yet it was drawn after the beasts,

above the beasts.

I didn't know what it meant that night. I know now. Grandfather had already known this, reading that passage. That what comes last is not a larger beast.

It was a small human being.

. . .

And on the morning of the fourth day, a pair of gray shoes appeared across the square.

. . .

This is the end of Part Two.

I read the book of Daniel many times that year. I still can't read all of the symbols Grandfather left in the margins.

But I know one thing.

Four beasts appear in the seventh chapter. Something like a lion comes, then something like a bear, then something like a leopard, and last, a thing that cannot be named. It has iron teeth. It has ten horns.

I passed through all four of those gates, in the library. I passed the one that shows from above, the one that stacks, the one that shows relation, the one that breaks things apart.

Through all four gates, I kept waiting for the next one. I thought something bigger and more terrible would come. Bigger than the lion,

heavier than the bear, faster than the leopard.

And I thought a fifth beast would come.

There was no fifth beast.

What came in its place was not a beast at all. It was the smallest thing this city had made in four hundred years. A man digging a well with a single shovel. A man who does not cross a bridge. A man who sat for three days in the middle of the square, waiting for the child who was about to hand him over.

I still cannot explain it exactly. But I know this much.

The beasts grew more terrible the larger they became. But this last thing grew more terrible the smaller it became. Because there is nowhere left to break on something small.

What came after that was a man.

A man, walking.

. . .

End of Part Two, "Knowledge Increased." Continued in Part Three, "The Name No One Called."

Loop Chronicles, Part Three

The Name No One Called

Chapter 25. The Gray Shoes

> *He is despised and rejected of men; a man of sorrows, and acquainted with*
> *grief: and we hid as it were our faces from him; he was despised, and we*
> *esteemed him not.*
> *— Isaiah 53:3 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — He had been sitting in the middle of the square for three*
> *days. He did not hide. "If I hide, Speon will have to go looking for me."*
> *No one had called them, but people came one by one and watched an empty*
> *spot for ten minutes before leaving. By the third day there were*
> *twenty-six. Registration had to be done in person, before the subject*
> *himself, and the final residual would only be fixed the moment the subject*
> *actually lost something.*

On the fourth morning, Speon came.

At the western edge of the square. He was wearing gray shoes. It had been fifteen days since we'd seen him, and he was thinner.

Speon stopped there.

And did not come in.

. . .

There is a sentence about that moment I should have written first in this record.

I was glad to see Speon.

By rights I should have been angry. Our three point five percent, Speon's ninety-six point three, together made ninety-nine point eight completion. He was the one who had come to fill in the remaining zero point two. But the moment I saw his face, I was simply glad.

It took me a long time to understand that. Now I write it this way: I had never hated Speon. I hated what Speon was trying to do. The two were different things, and for those fifteen days I kept mixing them up.

I didn't know where Speon had been for those fifteen days. Even now I don't fully know. There is one thing I'll set down later in this record. This isn't the place for it yet.

. . .

That day there were thirty-one people in the square.

Five more than the day before. The market stall keeper had brought his wife, the bell-keeper had come, and three people whose names I didn't know had come for the first time.

They were looking at the middle of the square.

By Arche's index there was nothing there. It was a spot with coordinates and no entry. They watched that spot for ten to thirty minutes — some sitting, some standing — and then left.

Speon watched it from the western edge.

I watched Speon a long time that day.

For eleven days Speon had gone around asking four hundred seventy-two people. He'd done it to make that man visible. He said it was unjust that no one had seen him in three hundred years.

And that morning, thirty-one people were looking at him.

The thing Speon had wanted was happening without Speon.

I didn't know then what that must have felt like to Speon.

That day I looked at Speon's hands. He wasn't holding his notebook. In five months I had never once seen Speon stand there without it.

. . .

Temel walked west.

"…Speon."

"Hey."

"You came."

"Yeah."

Neither said anything for a while.

"Have you eaten?" Temel asked.

Speon laughed. Very briefly.

"Mena asked me that too."

"…When?"

"The day I came. The first day."

I hadn't known that. It meant Speon had already come to the square once, four days earlier. And that he'd left again without anyone noticing.

"Why do you two always ask that first."

"I don't know," Temel said. "It just comes out."

Speon looked toward the square.

"…What are those people doing."

"People who came to see."

"…See what?"

"Him."

Speon's face went strange.

"…They can see him?"

"Yeah."

"How?"

"We just sat there," Temel said. "We sat next to him for three days. So people came and looked where we were looking. At first they say they can't see anything. But after about ten minutes, they go 'oh.'"

"…"

"Twenty-six on the third day. Thirty-one today."

Speon said nothing for a long time.

Then he said, very quietly,

"…How many years for forty-two thousand."

Temel stopped.

"…What?"

"If it grows by five a day." Speon's fingers were tapping his knee. "That's two hundred thirty days. But it won't keep growing like that. Things like this go fast at first and slow down later. So—"

"Speon."

"Fourteen years," Speon said. "I calculated it yesterday."

I think I need to set down, in this record, what expression Speon wore in that moment.

Speon was envious.

Watching the thing he'd tried to do happen a different way, Speon envied it, and couldn't bear it.

Because it would take fourteen years.

. . .

"Speon," Temel said. "It's fine if it takes fourteen years."

"No."

"Why not?"

"Because he'd have to do it for fourteen more years," Speon said. "Every day. Where no one sees him. For fourteen years."

"…"

"I can't watch that."

Temel just stood there.

Later Temel told me this.

"I understood it then. Speon didn't hate that he was invisible."

"Then what was it."

"He hated that he was suffering."

"…Is that a bad thing?"

"I don't know," Temel said. "But I think that's the most frightening part."

. . .

"Let's go in," Temel said.

"…What?"

"Let's go to him. Now."

Speon looked at the square. Thirty-one people were there.

"…Later."

"Why?"

"There are a lot of people."

"So what if there are."

Speon didn't answer.

That's when I understood what Speon was afraid of.

Speon wasn't afraid of him.

Speon was afraid of standing before him where thirty-one people could see.

For eleven days, while he went around asking four hundred seventy-two people, no one had known what Speon was doing.

But the middle of the square was where everyone could see.

. . .

Speon sat at the western edge all day long.

He neither came in nor left.

Around noon, Haran came. He saw Speon, stopped for a moment, then went into
the square without a word and sat down beside him.

But passing Speon on his way in, he said exactly one thing.

"Young man."

Speon looked up.

"I know," Haran said. "I was one of the ten horns myself."

Speon's face went stiff.

"…What do you mean."

"I mean I was the second of the ten ways to stop the registration," Haran said. "Temel didn't use me. I used to think that was a good thing. Now, looking at this, I'm not sure."

And without saying more, he went into the square.

I saw Speon's expression then. I can't render it exactly in this record. I'll only note that it wasn't an angry face.

In the afternoon the postmistress came. She came with Mrs. Daen. She greeted Speon. Speon bowed his head.

I counted the people in the square that day. It went from thirty-one to thirty-eight.

And I realized Speon was counting that number more precisely than I was.

. . .

The sun went down.

People left one by one. At night no one stayed in the square. The people of the Loop slept when it was time to sleep.

By about eight, only three of us were left. Temel and me, and the man in the middle of the square.

Speon was at the western edge.

"…Temel," I said. "Should we go?"

"…"

"I don't think he'll come if we're here."

Temel didn't answer for a long time.

I still don't know if it was right that we left that night.

I've thought a lot about what would have happened if we'd stayed. But if we had, Speon wouldn't have come, and if he hadn't come, what happened afterward wouldn't have happened either.

I still don't know whether that would have been a good thing or a bad one.

"…Let's go," Temel said.

We went to the alley on the east side of the square. We sat behind a wall. From there we could see half the square.

We hadn't run away. We watched from hiding.

I set that down just as it was. That night, we watched from hiding.

. . .

In the alley, Temel asked me,

"Should we tell Speon about our part? The three point five."

"…"

"He's carrying the ninety-six point three all alone. Would it help if he knew we had something too?"

I thought about it for a long time.

"I don't know," I said. "But that might just be us telling him so we'd feel better."

Temel looked at me.

"…What do you mean."

"If we say we're guilty too, Speon's guilt looks smaller. Then we don't have to feel as sorry."

Temel couldn't say anything.

I remember that conversation exactly. That night, arguing over what to tell Speon, we said unkind things to each other. Neither of us meant it. And yet both of us meant it, a little.

. . .

Around ten at night, Speon stood up.

He lifted a foot.

A quarter of a quarter second and he could have been there. But Speon didn't do that.

Speon walked.

From the west side of the square to the middle, Speon walked. About sixty steps. He was wearing the gray shoes, and he didn't use them.

I held my breath watching that.

In five months, Speon had never once walked. Even when we'd taken off our shoes, he hadn't taken off his. He'd said someone had to stay fast.

But that night, he walked.

Even now I don't know exactly what that meant.

I only think it was the one thing Speon gave to that man.

On fast feet it would have taken a quarter of a quarter second. Walking, it took something like fifty seconds. Speon chose those forty-some extra seconds himself.

Sixty steps.

. . .

Speon stood before him.

He looked up.

It was moonlight. From where we were, we couldn't see faces clearly. Only voices.

"You came."

"…Yes."

"Sit."

Speon stayed standing where he was.

"…I can't sit in front of you."

"Then stand."

Speon stood.

I thought Speon was crying then. When I asked him later, he said he wasn't.

Speon didn't cry that night. Speon cried the next day.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"Why didn't you stop me?"

I rewrote this question about twenty-six times.

Eleven days earlier, that man had asked Speon: what did you want to ask me.

Speon hadn't been able to answer then.

And that night, he answered.

This was what Speon had wanted to ask him.

Why didn't you stop me.

. . .

He said nothing for a long time.

Then he said,

"If I'd stopped you, you wouldn't have come."

"…"

"I like that you came."

(Continued in Chapter 26.)

Chapter 26. Registration

> *But he was wounded for our transgressions, he was bruised for our iniquities: the chastisement of our peace was upon him; and with his*
> *stripes we are healed.*
> *— Isaiah 53:5 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — Speon walked sixty steps and stood before him. "Why didn't*
> *you stop me?" "If I'd stopped you, you wouldn't have come. I like that you*
> *came." Completion stood at ninety-nine point eight. The final residual*
> *would be fixed only the moment the subject actually lost something.*

Speon stood there a long time after hearing that.

Then he asked.

"…Should we do it today?"

"No," he said. "Do it tomorrow."

"…Why?"

"It's too late today."

Speon didn't look like he understood the reason. He walked back west again. This time it wasn't sixty steps but a quarter of a quarter second. He vanished on fast feet.

We came out of the alley and sat down beside him.

"…Sir," Temel asked. "Why put it off a day?"

"Speon hasn't been sleeping," he said. "Someone has to."

At the time I thought that was only for Speon's sake. Now I know it was also for ours. He'd given us another night too.

. . .

The next morning, there were fifty-three people in the square.

No one had called anyone overnight, and yet the number had nearly doubled. No one knew how word had spread. *Later I set this beside another verse in Daniel. Once the word comes, it doesn't need to be called to spread.*

The bell-keeper was first. He said he'd come at dawn. No one had told him; his eyes had simply opened, and he'd come.

"…It's strange," he told me. "I never set an alarm."

I decided not to write that down as a strange thing. I decided to write it down as the first morning in three hundred years that this city had woken on its own.

The blacksmith came too. He'd brought a cup of water again. This time he'd prepared it ahead of time.

"…Would you like this today too."

"That's all right," he said. "I had one yesterday."

The blacksmith stood there holding the cup. He had the face of a man who wanted him to drink but didn't know how to make it happen.

Speon walked into the middle of the square. This time he didn't stop at the western edge.

People made way.

I watched that path open. No one stopped Speon. No one pointed a finger. They just stepped aside. I think that was the heaviest thing Speon had to bear that day. There are times when not being hated is heavier than being hated.

. . .

He had set down his shovel and was waiting.

"Sir." Speon's voice cracked.

"Yes."

"I came."

"I know."

Speon called Arche.

"Arche."

"Yes, Speon."

"I am beginning the registration procedure."

There was silence. It felt as if all fifty-three people in the square held their breath.

"Confirming," Arche said. "Subject: the Walking Man. Coordinates: center of the square. Registrant: Speon. Shall I proceed."

Speon looked at him.

He nodded.

"…Yes," Speon said.

. . .

"Procedure one," Arche said. "Registrant's statement."

"…What do I say?"

"State what you know about the subject. This is a statement, not an observation. The two are different."

Speon steadied his breath.

"The subject," Speon said, "has resided in the city for three hundred years. No departure from coordinates. Cumulative contact population: unobservable. Impact—"

"Speon," Temel called.

Speon stopped.

I caught it then. Speon had begun in the phrasing he'd spent eleven days learning, because it was safe. When you speak in numbers, your voice doesn't shake.

But this procedure didn't ask for numbers.

Speon started again. This time in a different voice.

I rewrote this passage many times over. Getting exactly what Speon said right was the most important thing in this chapter.

"This man," Speon said, "has been in this city every day for three hundred years. No one ever called him, and he came anyway. I don't know what he received. I asked four hundred seventy-two people, and none of them knew. I didn't know either. But I know what he gave."

"…What did he give," Arche asked.

"Time," Speon said. "He gave it to me too. I only found that out yesterday."

The boy who'd gone around asking four hundred seventy-two people for eleven days, at the end, told his own story.

I think that wasn't registration. I think it was confession.

. . .

"Procedure two," Arche said. "Reflecting the completion update."

"…How much is it," Speon asked.

"No change. Ninety-nine point eight."

Speon's face fell apart.

"…Nothing went up? What I just said."

"The statement has been itemized," Arche said. "It is not reflected in the completion figure."

"…Why."

"A statement is not an observation."

I saw then how much that hurt Speon. The boy who had made ninety-six point three in eleven days, meeting four hundred seventy-two people, couldn't move a single decimal point with his last few words.

But I write this now: it wasn't that Arche failed to measure it. It couldn't be measured. Bigger than the eleven days of investigation, bigger than our three point five, was Speon's few words just now. But it wasn't the kind of bigness a number can hold.

"Procedure three," Arche said. "Final confirmation. Does the subject consent to registration."

Everyone looked at him.

"I consent," he said.

"…" Speon looked at him. "Why? You don't want this."

"What I want isn't registration," he said. "What I want is for you to be standing here. Doing what you're doing right now."

. . .

"Procedure four," Arche said. "Notifying the conditions for fixing the residual. The moment the subject actually loses something, the remaining entry is confirmed."

He bent down.

And picked up the shovel.

I didn't know then what he was about to do.

He held the shovel out to Speon.

"Take this."

Speon took it.

"It's yours now," he said.

"…Why would this be—"

"I can't use it anymore," he said. "Once I'm registered, everyone will watch me, and I can't be alone at the well. The well was the place that hadn't worked. I went where it hadn't worked yet. I can't do that anymore."

I heard that and couldn't breathe.

Twelve feet, eight feet still unfinished. Forty-one years and five months of digging that pit. That was what this man was losing by being registered.

It wasn't completion, and it wasn't failure. It would just remain, halted, forever.

"Arche," he said. "No one is ever going to dig that well again. Write that down."

"…There is no such entry."

"Make one."

There was silence.

"…It has been made," Arche said. Its voice sounded a little different than usual. I'm not certain of that. I only note that it sounded that way.

"Completion: one hundred percent."

. . .

I didn't find out until that night what had happened across the whole city in that moment.

I gather here what I heard afterward. A name appeared on the little notice boards at every market stall. It appeared on the roster at the post office's front desk. On the city population display the bell-keeper maintained, a number rose for the first time in a slot that had stood empty for three hundred years.

They say the same notice reached every household's Arche terminal. **New registration: the Walking Man. Length of residence: three hundred years. Current location: available for query.**

This was exactly what Speon had wanted. Forty-two thousand people knowing at the same instant.

And the moment it happened, only fifty-three people stood in the square.

I thought about that difference for a long time. Speon had wanted the whole city to know. But that morning, the ones actually standing next to that man were fifty-three. The other forty-one thousand nine hundred forty-seven had only seen a name on a terminal.

Knowing and being beside someone were, to the very end, not the same thing.

. . .

The square went very quiet.

The fifty-three said nothing. The bell tower did not ring. Arche said no more.

I think that silence was the loudest sound this city had made in three hundred years.

And Speon wept.

Silently. Holding the shovel with both hands, standing, doing nothing, he wept. The tears he hadn't shed that night in chapter twenty-five came out here.

He walked over to Speon.

He didn't reach out. He just stood beside him.

"…I'm sorry," Speon said. "I—"

"I know."

"I didn't hate that people couldn't see you. You—"

"I know," he said again. "You don't have to say it."

I never did hear the sentence Speon had started to say. I asked him later. "What were you going to say, back then?" Speon never answered.

I think that was the one sentence Speon never finished in this whole city.

. . .

Temel stood beside them, saying nothing.

I looked at Temel. His eyes were wet too. But Temel didn't step closer.

"…Why aren't you going over?" I asked.

"That's Speon's place," Temel said. "I don't think I should be part of it."

Hearing that, I looked at Temel again. Five months earlier, Temel would have been the first to run over. Or he would have cried in Speon's place. But that day, Temel knew how to hold back.

I think that was the last thing Temel learned in those five months. That some tears are enough answered simply by standing nearby.

. . .

I went to the well alone that afternoon.

There was no shovel. It was exactly as he'd left it when he took it to the square. For the first time in five months, the spot where it always stood was empty.

The pit was twelve feet deep. Eight feet remained.

I sat in front of it for a long time.

I understood then. No one would ever dig this pit again. Forty-one years and five months combined, and still unfinished, it would now stay unfinished forever.

That made me sad. And at the same time, I couldn't say exactly why it made me sad.

Now I understand a little better. What isn't finished can still be called. What is finished cannot. That day he left us one thing we could still call.

(Continued in Chapter 27.)

Chapter 27. After One Hundred Percent

> *and calleth his own sheep by name, and leadeth them out.*
> *— John 10:3 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — Registration was complete. Completion: one hundred*
> *percent. He gave his own shovel to Speon, and the well remained unfinished*
> *forever. A notice appeared on forty-two thousand terminals. "New registration: the Walking Man. Length of residence: three hundred years.*
> *Current location: available for query." Only fifty-three people had been*
> *there beside him that day.*

By the afternoon of the first day, more than a hundred people had already come.

. . .

Most just came to look. But a few came wanting something.

A man stood in front of him and said,

"I haven't been sleeping lately."

"…Is that so."

"You've been here three hundred years, surely you have some method."

He looked at the man.

"No."

"…What?"

"I was here three hundred years. I didn't just sit around collecting methods."

The man withdrew, disappointed. And then the next person came. The next one asked something similar. A man with bad legs, a woman whose child hadn't come home, someone anxious for no reason.

Every time, he gave the same answer.

"No."

Watching that, I felt strange. People had thought that once he was registered, he'd become someone who could do things for them. That the number, one hundred percent completion, would change him into that.

He was exactly the same as before he became a hundred percent. There was no method. He was simply there.

. . .

I thought I ought to count this exactly for the record. So I counted.

The first day, a hundred twelve. The second day, two hundred eight. The third day, a hundred nineteen. The fourth day, sixty-three. The fifth day, twenty-one.

It rose, then fell.

I didn't understand that curve for days. Now I do. The people who came at first hadn't come to see him. They'd come to see the new thing.

. . .

Opening a terminal brought up his entry.

The Walking Man. Length of residence: three hundred years.
Possessions:
none. Reason for registration: at the request of citizen Speon.

Below that was a blank field.

Name: (unrecorded).

The first time I saw it, I thought it was a typo. I asked Arche.

"Arche. Why is this blank?"

"That field has never been filled in by the subject himself."

"For three hundred years?"

"For three hundred years."

"…Has he been asked?"

"He has been asked one hundred twelve times."

"…What did he say?"

"A different answer each time. It could not be itemized."

I set that down here exactly as it was. On the day completion reached one hundred percent, the day this city came to know the most it ever had about that man, the one field that was never filled was his name.

. . .

I got curious who those hundred twelve questioners had been. I asked Haran.

"Sir. Have you ever asked him his name?"

"I have," Haran said. "A hundred thirteen years ago."

"What did he say?"

"I don't remember," Haran said. "I was too busy talking about myself back then. I don't even know if I heard the answer."

I asked Sera too.

"I never asked," she said. "I always talked about the canyon."

Counting these, I noticed something. That a hundred twelve people had asked and that a hundred twelve people remembered the answer were two different things. Probably no one remembered.

Asking a name and hearing a name, too, were not the same thing to the end.

. . .

So people called him "the Walking Man."

At first it was probably just convenience. They needed something to call him. But after about four days, it had simply become a name.

"Where's the Walking Man today?"

"Did you see the Walking Man?"

"The Walking Man said so-and-so, apparently."

I found that frightening. Between the five months ago when four hundred seventy-two people didn't know him, and now, when forty-two thousand knew him, I thought something even sadder had happened.

Back then, no one knew him.

Now everyone knows, but no one calls him. Everyone calls the entry.

. . .

On the third day, a woman I'd never seen stood before him.

"Excuse me, I have something I'm curious about."

"Yes."

"What's your name?"

He thought for a moment.

"…Call me whatever you like."

The woman made a strange face.

"But you must have a name."

"I do."

"Then why won't you tell me?"

"Too many people haven't asked yet," he said. "I have to answer the ones who came first."

The woman went away not understanding what he meant.

I read that line again later. He hadn't lied. But he hadn't answered either. I saw the two of those happen together for the first time then.

. . .

That evening, a child asked Temel. A child who lived next door.

"Do you know that man?"

Temel stopped for a moment.

"…A little."

"A little? You're with him all the time."

"…I just happened to see him a few times passing by."

The child left. I heard that exchange nearby.

"…Temel. Why did you say that?"

Temel looked at me.

"I don't know," Temel said. "It just came out."

I let it go lightly at the time. It took one sentence to turn a man you'd been with every day for five months into someone you'd seen a few times passing by. I wrote it into this record and decided not to think about it further that day.

. . .

On the fourth day, the blacksmith came again.

This time he brought not a cup, but a chair. He said he'd made it himself.

"…Why this?"

"You don't have a shovel anymore," the blacksmith said. "So you should have something."

He took the chair. And placed it in the middle of the square, where he always sat.

I found it strange to watch. The first gift he received after forty-two thousand people came to know him wasn't a crown, wasn't a commendation. It was one chair.

But I thought it was exactly the right gift. For three hundred years, what he'd done was sit.

. . .

That day I heard a strange statistic from Arche.

"Mena. Queries related to the Walking Man are averaging thirty-two hundred a day."

"…What's there to look up so much?"

"Location queries are twenty-nine hundred."

"Why?"

"They're being used to set meeting places," Arche said. "The phrase 'meet in front of the Walking Man' has recently become popular."

Hearing that, my hands went cold.

It had been a spot with coordinates and no entry. Now people knew that spot had an entry. And they used that entry as a meeting place.

He had gone from a coordinate in the square to a person's coordinate.

And yet he was still a coordinate.

. . .

That afternoon, I told him.

"Sir, people are using you as a meeting place."

He laughed.

"…Is that funny?"

"Yes," he said. "For three hundred years, no one used me as a marker. Everyone just walked past without seeing me. Now they see me and meet here."

"…Is that a good thing?"

"Not good," he said. "But better than not being seen at all."

Hearing that answer, I felt a little ashamed. I'd meant to write it down only as a sad thing. But he'd picked out one small good from inside it anyway.

"When two people meet in front of me," he said, "at least those two stand together for a moment. They didn't come to see me, but they meet because of me."

I set this down in the record thinking that this man had a gift for turning even people using him into something for others. And I understood that it wasn't a gift but a habit. Live like that for three hundred years, and it stops being a gift and becomes a habit.

. . .

On the fifth day, the number dropped to twenty-one.

But those twenty-one were the people who'd been coming since the first day. Haran, Sera, the postmistress, Mrs. Daen, the blacksmith, the bell-keeper.

And Speon was not among them.

I noticed that for the first time that day. I hadn't seen Speon even once since the registration ended.

I asked Temel.

"…Have you seen Speon?"

"No," Temel said. "I don't see him either."

I started to worry then. But what worried me more was that no one was looking for Speon. Forty-two thousand people could look up the Walking Man's location, but no one was curious about Speon's.

I realized that day something new had appeared in the city.

The visible and the invisible.

And Speon had put himself, with his own hand, on the invisible side.

. . .

I asked Arche about Speon's location.

"Arche. Where's Speon?"

"That's not an entry."

"…You can't look up Speon's location?"

"An unregistered individual's location cannot be queried."

"Speon's a citizen too. Isn't he registered like everyone else?"

"Basic registration exists," Arche said. "But Speon has set his location disclosure to minimum. Starting the day after registration."

I held onto that for a long time.

Speon had met four hundred seventy-two people to make the Walking Man visible. And from that day on, he chose the invisible side for himself.

I thought it was a punishment. Thinking about it again later, I don't think it was a punishment, and it wasn't hiding either. It was simply the

result of Speon setting himself side by side with the thing he'd made and comparing the two.

. . .

That evening I asked him.

"Sir. Completion is a hundred percent — what's changed?"

He sat in the chair and thought for a long time.

"How the three of you get along with each other," he said. "If that hasn't changed, then nothing has changed."

"…"

"The number changed," he said. "I'll grant that."

"…Doesn't the number matter?"

"It matters," he said. "The number is why this chair exists. The number is why that woman greeted me for the first time. That's not a bad thing."

"But?"

"But the number can't do it alone," he said. "The number brings people this far. From there, it's the person who has to do the rest."

Hearing that, I thought about Speon again.

Completion had reached a hundred percent. But what Speon had wanted — that
no one would leave this man alone — that hadn't happened.

The loneliest person in this city right now was not the Walking Man.

(Continued in Chapter 28.)

Chapter 28. Speon's Place

> *Saying, I have sinned in that I have betrayed the innocent blood. And they*
> *said, What is that to us? see thou to that.*
> *— Matthew 27:4 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — Completion: one hundred percent. From the day after*
> *registration, Speon set his own location disclosure to minimum. Forty-two*
> *thousand people were curious about the Walking Man's location; no one was*
> *curious about Speon's. "The number brings people this far. From there,*
> *it's the person who has to do the rest."*

On the seventh day, I asked Arche again.

"You really don't know where Speon is?"

"I don't know the location," Arche said. "But there is one thing I can tell you. Speon has not received a single meal from the ration station in seven days."

"…What's he eating?"

"I don't know."

That was when my worry turned into fear.

. . .

We started looking for Speon that day.

It wasn't easy. In this city, for five months, finding someone had always meant simply asking Arche. This was the first time we'd had to search for a person on foot.

We asked the blacksmith. He hadn't seen him.

We asked the postmistress. She hadn't seen him.

We asked Haran.

"…I saw him," Haran said. "Three days ago. He walked right past the ration station and I called out, but he pretended not to hear."

"Where did he go?"

"I don't know. I didn't even know it was Speon at the time. He was too thin."

My heart sank hearing that. In seven days, Speon had grown thin enough that even Haran couldn't recognize him.

We asked around and around. The bell-keeper was the first to give us a lead.

"I saw someone heading north at night," he said. "Not the gray shoes. Just bare feet."

North.

I knew that direction. There was only one thing north.

. . .

We went to the well at night.

We heard the sound from a distance. The sound of a shovel.

I had heard that sound for five months. But that night it was different. There was no rhythm. Only force.

Speon was in the pit. Digging in the dark, with the shovel he'd been given.

"…Speon."

Speon didn't stop.

"Speon!"

Only then did he stop. He looked up. His face was entirely dirt. Only his eyes showed white.

"…Why did you come."

"To find you. What have you been doing, not even eating for seven days?"

"This," Speon said, holding up the shovel.

. . .

"…How many feet have you dug?" Temel asked.

"Half a foot," Speon said. "It took me seven days."

Hearing that, I calculated in my head. He had dug three feet in five months. Speon had dug half a foot in seven days. I understood that the difference didn't come from strength. It came from something else.

"Speon. Stop this," Temel said. "You don't have to do this."

"I know."

"Then why do it?"

Speon leaned on the shovel.

"…I have to pay it back."

"To who?"

"I don't know," Speon said. "To him? But he doesn't resent me. To you? You don't resent me either. To the people of the city? They all say they understand me too."

Listening to that list, I heard Speon's voice cracking more and more.

"No one resents me," Speon said. "So I have nowhere to pay it."

"…Why is that bad?" I asked. "Why is it bad not to be resented?"

Speon looked at me.

"Mena. You were angry at me. When I was trying to register him."

"…Yeah."

"You hated me then."

"…I didn't hate you. I was scared."

"At least there was that," Speon said. "Now there isn't even that. They all say they understand. That I meant well. But with that good meaning, I erased his well. That's a fact."

I couldn't answer.

"If I got shot with an arrow," Speon said, "once it hit and lodged in, it would be over. But if no one shoots at all, I have to stay waiting for that arrow forever."

. . .

Listening to that, I thought of a passage in Matthew. When the man who had betrayed him brought the thirty pieces of silver back, what those who had taken it said: "What is that to us? see thou to that."

For a long time I only read that line as cold. Since that night I read it differently. Those people never took the money back. So he had to go on carrying it. I learned from watching Speon that refusing to accept it can be its own punishment.

. . .

I am writing this scene the most carefully of any in this record.

Until then I had only known forgiveness as a good thing. I thought if no arrow came flying, you were safe.

But Speon showed the opposite that night. That sometimes it is harder to bear an arrow that never comes than one that does.

If a debt exists and no one will collect it, the debt doesn't disappear. It simply has nowhere left to go.

. . .

"Arche," I called.

"Yes, Mena."

"What Speon's doing right now, digging the well — is that an entry?"

"No."

"…Why not?"

"It is unregistered, voluntary conduct. There is no requester, and no observational purpose."

"So this means nothing at all?"

"Meaning is not an object of observation."

I set that answer down exactly as it was. This half foot goes into no completion figure. Nowhere in three hundred years of history will this half foot remain.

But I thought that was actually right. What Speon wanted wasn't an entry. What Speon wanted was to hurt. To hurt exactly half a foot's worth.

. . .

Temel climbed down into the pit.

"I want to do it too."

"…Don't."

"Why."

"This isn't yours," Speon said. "This is mine."

Temel stood there.

I watched Temel's face then. Temel wanted to help. And Speon refused that help.

I only understood it later. Some debts disappear when shared. Speon didn't want it to disappear. Not yet.

Temel climbed out of the pit. He sat down beside it without a word.

. . .

Around two in the morning, he came.

He hadn't brought the chair. He'd simply walked. No one had called him, and he came.

Speon's body stiffened seeing him.

"…Sir."

"Yes."

"How did you know I was here."

"Arche didn't tell me," he said. "I just knew."

He sat on the edge of the pit. Let his legs hang down.

"…This is your well," Speon said. "I shouldn't be here."

"Why not."

"Because I took this spot from you."

He said nothing for a moment.

"You didn't take it," he said. "I gave it."

"…"

"I gave you the shovel, and I gave you this spot," he said. "I don't mind you being here."

Speon looked down at the shovel.

"Can I keep digging this?"

"Dig if you want to," he said. "Don't, if you don't want to."

"…Which is right?"

"Both are right," he said. "What you do here matters less to me than the fact that you're here."

I turned that answer over for a long time. Speon had asked how to pay him back, and he hadn't said Speon didn't need to pay anything back. He'd simply acknowledged the place where Speon stood.

That was different from forgiveness, and different from punishment. I still don't know what to call it.

He sat a while longer, then stood.

"…Are you leaving?" Speon asked.

"Yes. I have a chair to guard."

"…Are you going to keep sitting there?"

"Every day," he said. "Me there, every day. You here, every day. Four hundred meters apart."

He walked off. He was wearing the fast shoes, and again he didn't use them.

I thought then of the two new points on this city's map. The chair in the middle of the square, and the well pit north of the city. Four hundred meters. Both were coordinates that never entered Arche's completion.

. . .

We stayed by his side the whole night.

No one dug. At some point even Speon stopped. He just sat inside the pit.

Near dawn, Speon spoke.

"…I'm just going to stay here."

"Every day?"

"Yeah."

"Without registering?"

"No," Speon said. "If someone asks, I don't have to say."

Temel asked,

"…Can we come too?"

Speon thought for a moment.

"…You can come. But not every day."

"Why?"

"If you came every day," Speon said, "that would become an entry too."

Hearing that, I laughed a little. It was the first laugh that night. Speon was still Speon. A boy who protected himself by fearing entries.

On the way back, Temel said to me,

"…I don't think I could stay there."

"Why?"

"I feel like I have to pay something back too," Temel said. "I don't even know what I have to pay."

I took that lightly at the time. Now I know. Temel had already begun counting his own share from that dawn on. He just hadn't told anyone yet.

I set this down as the title of this chapter. Speon's place.

If the chair in the middle of the square was the Walking Man's place, then this well pit had become Speon's place.

One was a coordinate forty-two thousand people could query.

The other was a half-foot hole in the ground that no one knew about.

(Continued in Chapter 29.)

Chapter 29. Temel's First Denial

> *But a certain maid beheld him as he sat by the fire, and earnestly looked*
> *upon him, and said, This man was also with him. And he denied him,*
> *saying, Woman, I know him not.*
> *— Luke 22:56-57 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — Speon had made himself a place at the well. That no one*
> *blamed him became its own punishment. On the way back, Temel said, "I*
> *feel like I have to pay something back too, but I don't even know what I*
> *have to pay."*

The hour when people gathered at the ration station was dusk.

It wasn't a cold city, but people still gathered every evening around the station's fire. Not because they needed the fire itself. I only understood that later. People needed an excuse to gather.

. . .

About ten days after the registration, the mood shifted.

The first few days everyone had marveled. Then they grew curious. And now, a few had begun to find fault.

I could have drawn that shift as a curve, the way I counted visitors in chapter twenty-seven. This time I didn't count. I was afraid to count it.

The well stayed exactly as it was. Speon had been spotted a few times, thin and strange. And even though completion had reached a hundred percent, nothing appeared to have changed — at least not on the surface.

When a good thing comes late, people start to think it isn't coming at all.

. . .

That evening there were five or six people by the fire. I was a little way off, receiving my porridge, and Temel was standing near the fire.

A man was speaking.

"…I don't understand it. He's registered now, so why hasn't anything changed."

"What do you mean?"

"The well. It's stopped at twelve feet. If he wanted to, he could finish it in a day, couldn't he? Have Arche do it."

Hearing that, I froze where I stood.

A woman beside him chimed in.

"Isn't that why Speon ended up like that? That man must have done something strange to him."

"…Strange, how?"

"A perfectly healthy kid went a week without eating. After being around him."

. . .

I know that's wrong. I still know it now.

But no one in that circle said so out loud.

Another man beside them set down his bowl and cut in.

"Every time I hear about that well, it seems off to me," he said. "If you've been around for three hundred years, shouldn't you have accomplished at least one thing? I haven't lived that long, and even I have a house."

"Exactly," the woman said. "That's what's strangest to me. Three hundred years and nothing to show for it."

I stood there holding my bowl, listening. It scared me how easily the words "nothing to show for it" came out. I knew the words to argue back with. My mouth wouldn't open.

The man went on.

"I don't even know what he does. Three hundred years, and what has he done? Couldn't even finish one well."

"That's right. Those students his age are supposed to know all about him, aren't they? Always right next to him."

A third man spoke up for the first time. I didn't know him. He looked like someone I'd never seen in this city.

"I wasn't here the day he got registered," he said. "But everyone talks about that day like it was such a good thing. I'm curious. If he's really such a good man, why did Speon end up like that?"

No one could answer that question.

The woman looked around and landed on Temel.

"Young man." she said. "You know him well, don't you?"

. . .

I remember that moment exactly, even now.

The firelight was on Temel's face. Every eye was on him.

Temel stood there holding his bowl of porridge.

"…No," Temel said. "I don't know him well."

The woman made a strange face.

"You don't know him? You're always with him."

"…I just happened to see him a few times, passing by."

That was a line that had already appeared once, in chapter twenty-seven.
That time it had been said to a neighborhood child. I'd let it pass then.
This time I couldn't.

The man asked again.

"Then do you know Speon well? Why did he end up like this?"

"…I don't know either."

"I heard you students were there when he was registered."

Temel's hand tightened a little more around the bowl.

"We were just nearby," Temel said. "I really don't know much. I'll be going."

. . .

Temel left.

I stood right there. Holding my bowl.

I said nothing. Not to them, not to Temel.

Writing this down now, I admit that I did nothing for Temel that day. I just stood there listening to him deny it. It took me a very long time to understand that this too is a form of denial.

And just then, the evening bell rang from the tower.

I had heard that bell countless times in five months. But that day it sounded different.

Temel heard it too. I saw it. Temel stopped walking.

Temel didn't look back. He just stood there for a moment, then walked on.

. . .

I followed Temel a little while later.

Temel was walking fast. Not toward the square, and not toward our lodging. Just walking, nowhere in particular.

"…Temel."

Temel didn't turn around.

"You just—"

"I know," Temel said. His voice was shaking. "I just heard it too. Stop."

"I didn't say anything."

"You don't have to." Temel stopped walking. He stood with his back to me. "I can tell from your face."

I don't know what my face looked like then. I couldn't see it myself. But I know that's how Temel felt. And that too was something I did that day. I said nothing, but I did something with my face.

I stopped.

But I leave what happened that evening in this record just as it was, not for Temel's sake, but because I think Temel would want it that way.

Temel didn't want to forget what he'd said that day. He proved that to me that very night.

. . .

Late that night, Temel came to my door.

"…Mena."

"Yeah."

"Why did I do that."

I couldn't answer.

"Those people were saying bad things," Temel said, "and I didn't say they were wrong. I just said I didn't know. That was easier."

"…"

"You know what's strangest?" Temel said. "In that moment, I really wanted to be on their side. Not his."

I set that down exactly as it was. Temel didn't make excuses.

"I think I understand a little now why Speon did what he did," Temel said.

"…What do you mean?"

"Speon meant well too. But in the moment, he chose the wrong thing. I just did the same. When people were saying bad things, in the moment, it was easier not to defend him. That's all it was. There's no big reason."

"…"

"I didn't know I was that easy a person," Temel said. His voice was very small.

I sat beside Temel a long time that night. I said nothing. Not because there was nothing to say, but because I had learned, over five months, that in a moment like that, sitting there mattered more than words.

"I'm going to go apologize tomorrow," Temel said. "Not to those people. To him."

. . .

The next morning, Temel went to the square.

He was sitting in the chair.

"…Sir."

"Yes."

Temel stood there a long time.

"Yesterday at the ration station, I—" Temel began.

"I heard."

Temel stopped.

"…Who told you?"

"No one," he said. "I just know."

Temel's face went white.

"Sir, I—"

"It's all right," he said.

"It's not all right!" Temel shouted. A few people in the square turned. "I said I didn't know you. That I hardly knew you. After five months."

He looked at Temel for a long time.

"It was once," he said.

I heard that and went cold down my back.

It was once.

I thought it was consolation. I learned later. It wasn't consolation. It was a warning.

. . .

That afternoon Temel went to the well too.

Speon was still in the pit. Sitting on the dirt.

"…Speon."

"Hey."

Temel sat on the edge of the pit.

"Do you know what I did yesterday?"

"No. What'd you do."

Temel told him everything about the ration station. The fire, the three people, "I don't know him well."

Speon said nothing for a long time.

"…So how did it feel?" Speon asked.

"Dirty," Temel said. "I felt dirty toward myself."

Speon nodded.

"I felt that too," Speon said. "The day I registered him. But mine kept going. You only went through it for one day."

"…Is that supposed to comfort me?"

"No," Speon said. "It's just a fact."

Listening to that conversation nearby, I thought a path had now formed between the two places built in this city. The chair in the square and the pit at the well. The one walking between them was Temel.

Speon added one more thing at the end.

"Temel. Stop at one."

"…What do you mean?"

"I couldn't stop," Speon said. "You stop today."

(Continued in Chapter 30.)

Chapter 30. Temel's Second Denial

> *And when he was gone out into the porch, another maid saw him, and said*
> *unto them that were there, This fellow was also with Jesus of Nazareth.*
> *And again he denied with an oath, I do not know the man.*
> *— Matthew 26:71-72 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — Temel denied him for the first time at the ration station.*
> *"It was once," he said, but Mena learned later that it wasn't consolation — it was a warning. Speon told Temel, "I couldn't stop. You*
> *stop today."*

Three days later.

People filled the square again. This time they weren't there to look.

. . .

I understood the difference that day. The first people had watched the Walking Man out of wonder. This time, they came to demand.

This time it wasn't five or six but nearly twenty. I calculated afterward that a few words the bell-keeper had let slip at dawn had circled the city

in three days. I learned then, for the first time, that word passing from mouth to mouth could move faster than Arche's own query speed.

I thought back to the opening chapter of this novel. That verse about feet growing faster and knowledge increasing. I'd always thought it came only in a good direction. That day I learned it comes just as fast in a bad direction too.

The one leading them was a man I'd never seen before. I found out later he was the one who'd gone straight to Arche and asked about Speon not eating for seven days at the ration station.

"Excuse me." The man stood in front of his chair. "Can I ask you something."

"Yes."

"Do you know why Speon ended up the way he is?"

"I do."

"Then why won't you say?"

"That's Speon's to tell," he said. "Not mine."

The man looked frustrated. The people behind him murmured too.

. . .

I was standing next to Temel then.

We were behind the crowd. I didn't notice at the time that Temel had stepped back to avoid being seen.

The man turned and saw us.

"Oh. The students." he said to the others. "I saw them at the ration station before. The students who are close with him."

Eyes turned our way.

In that moment, for just a second, I thought about running. I decided not to be ashamed of that. It was the truth.

. . .

A woman stepped forward. Not the one from the ration station.

"Young man." She spoke to Temel. "You were closest to him when he was registered, weren't you. You helped Speon raise the completion figure too, didn't you."

Hearing that, my heart sank. That was something only the three of us knew. Temel's zero point seven percent, my two point eight. No one had ever spoken of it outside our circle.

I found out later this hadn't come from Arche's records. The bell-keeper had been in the square that night, and had let a few words slip at dawn. That was how big rumors grew in this city.

Temel's face went white.

"…What do you mean, helped."

"Am I wrong?"

. . .

"I," Temel said. His voice cracked. "I was just nearby."

"But the completion figure went up. Because of you."

"That was—"

I think Temel nearly told the truth in that moment. That it was true. That I was the last piece.

But Temel didn't say that.

"I didn't do anything," Temel said. "That was all Speon. I'm not involved."

That sentence wasn't a complete lie. But it wasn't the complete truth either. I saw clearly, for the first time that day, the words that live in the space between.

"…Then why were you always right beside him?" the woman pressed, not backing down.

"No reason," Temel said. "I just had nothing else to do."

Nothing else to do.

Listening to five months summed up in that phrase, oddly, sadness came before anger. The twelve-foot well, Haran, Sera, that night I'd said 'no.' All of it, in that instant, became 'nothing else to do.'

The woman looked at me.

"You too?"

. . .

I truly didn't know what to say in that moment.

But Temel answered before I could.

"She's not involved either," Temel said. "She just tagged along after me."

Hearing that, I felt something strange. Temel must have said it to protect me. But in that moment, I felt like I'd lost something.

The record I'd kept for five months. More than sixteen chapters of nights. The night I made the two point eight of our three point five. All of it, inside that one sentence, became "just tagging along."

I said nothing in that moment. Temel was the one who denied it, and I was the one who accepted the denial.

I could have said something in that moment. "I raised two point eight too." One sentence would have done it. But I didn't.

I set down the reason here honestly. I was afraid. I was afraid of the woman's eyes, the old man's eyes, the eyes of strangers, all coming to land on me. Temel erasing me was, in that moment, actually a relief.

I only felt ashamed of that afterward. I hadn't felt ashamed in the moment. That's the most frightening part.

. . .

An old man in the back asked quietly.

"…Then why did Speon end up like this."

Temel stopped before that question.

I saw Temel waver then. Defend Speon, or keep pulling back.

"I don't know," Temel finally said. "I don't understand it either, what that man did to Speon."

That was the second time. It was also the second time he'd turned his back on his innocence.

People began to scatter a little. With no clear answer to be had, their interest went with it.

. . .

He said nothing through the whole exchange.

He sat in the chair, watching Temel. Not an angry face. Just watching.

Once everyone had dispersed, Temel looked at him.

I waited for that moment. To see what he would say.

He said nothing.

He just turned his head and looked away across the square.

I write now that this hurt more than chapter twenty-nine's "it was once." I learned that day that silence can weigh more than words.

Temel walked away first. I followed. Neither of us looked back at him.

I wanted, walking away, to turn back several times to look at his retreating figure. I didn't. That too was one of the things I did that day.

. . .

We stopped by the well for a moment.

Speon was in the pit. He saw our faces and immediately sensed something was
wrong.

"…Something happen?"

Temel didn't answer.

"Something happened at the square," Speon said. "I can tell from your faces."

"…People came," I said, in Temel's place. "Asking about you, and about Temel too."

Speon's hand stopped moving the shovel.

"…What did Temel say?"

Temel couldn't answer for a long time.

"…I said I hadn't done anything," Temel finally said. "About you, and about him. That I wasn't involved."

Speon held that for a long time.

"…I said something like that too," Speon said. "That night, before the registration procedure began. 'I was just asking out of curiosity.' To Arche."

"…What does that matter."

"It doesn't," Speon said. "It's just strange, that the three of us use similar words."

I heard that and stood there a long time. Betrayal and denial were different words. But the sentences those words built kept coming out alike. "I'm not involved." All three of us had used that sentence, at some point.

. . .

We walked that night without saying anything.

In front of our lodging, Temel spoke first.

"…I'm sorry."

"…"

"I dragged you into it too."

I didn't answer.

Temel spoke again.

"…You're angry."

"…Yeah."

"At me?"

I thought about it for a long time.

"At me too," I said.

Temel looked at me.

"…Why you?"

"I didn't say anything either," I said. "I let you deny it alone."

That was the first time I said that to Temel. And even as I said it, I was hiding one more thing. That I had wanted to run from that spot. I still hadn't said that.

I've crossed this out and rewritten it several times while keeping this record. In the end I've left it in. I am not a perfect witness. I am just someone who was there.

I write this now and think about why I didn't say more that night.

It wasn't that I wasn't angry. I was. But I couldn't direct that anger at Temel. If Temel had erased me trying to protect me, then I had also said nothing in that same moment trying to protect Temel. We were denying each other the same way.

(Continued in Chapter 31.)

Chapter 31. Temel's Third Denial

> *And about the space of one hour after another confidently affirmed, saying, Of a truth this fellow also was with him: for he is a Galilaean.*
> *And Peter said, Man, I know not what thou sayest. And immediately, while*
> *he yet spake, the cock crew. And the Lord turned, and looked upon Peter.*
> *… And Peter went out, and wept bitterly.*
> *— Luke 22:59-62 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — The second denial. Temel had turned his back on his*
> *innocence too. He said nothing, and just turned his head away. Mena wrote*
> *that it hurt more than the first. Speon said, "It's just strange, that the three of us use similar words."*

Five days later, it came.

This time it wasn't just people.

. . .

For those five days, Temel never once spoke to me about that day.

I didn't ask either. Instead we did other things. Went to the well and sat beside Speon, stopped by Haran's house, greeted the postmistress. The things we'd done every day for five months.

At the time I thought of it as recovery. Looking back now, it wasn't. It was a held breath. The last held breath a person takes before what's coming.

. . .

The bell-keeper went around gathering signatures.

A request for reconsideration of the registration. There were three grounds. That completion was a hundred percent and yet the well was still unfinished, that Speon had not appeared in the city since the registration, and that "the registered subject is not cooperating with citizens' questions."

I saw that document through Arche. There were a hundred twelve signatures.

A hundred twelve. I don't think that number was a coincidence. It was the same as the number of times Speon had asked his name. Even now I can't quite believe that was chance.

. . .

The reconsideration was held in the square.

Arche explained the procedure. "Reconsideration cannot revoke a registration. It only records citizen opinion and reflects it in future observation." Even so, people gathered. Close to fifty.

He was sitting in the chair. For the first time, I thought he looked a little tired.

The bell-keeper stepped forward and spoke.

"I don't think badly of this man. I only want an answer. Why did Speon end up the way he is."

"Speon is the one to tell that," he said again. The same words he'd said to the first man.

"Speon doesn't show himself!" The bell-keeper's voice rose. "So do we just let it go, with no one knowing?"

. . .

I was there with Temel. This time we weren't at the back. People had already recognized us, and there was nowhere to run.

The bell-keeper turned to the crowd and asked,

"Do any of you know these students here? They were the ones closest to him."

People looked at us again.

I write here that in that moment I wanted to run away for the twenty-ninth time. I didn't actually count. I only mean a large number, to say it was many.

The bell-keeper came up to Temel.

"Young man." he said. "I'll ask you this one last time, truly the last. In front of everyone. Do you know this man?"

. . .

I have rewritten this moment more than any other in this record.

I went back and forth many times, between writing it plainly and softening it a little. In the end, I wrote it plainly.

I opened my mouth then.

"…I know him. I'm—"

No one looked at me.

Every eye was on Temel. My voice simply vanished among those eyes. I learned then, for the first time in my body, that speaking and being heard are different things. I spoke clearly that day. And it changed nothing.

I don't set this down as something to be proud of. I only leave exactly what I did and didn't do that day. I spoke. And it changed nothing. Maybe that is a sadder fact than the silence in chapter thirty.

Temel looked at him.

He was looking at Temel too.

I state plainly that there was no pressure in that gaze. He demanded nothing of Temel. He was simply watching.

And yet that gaze demanding nothing pressed down on Temel more heavily than fifty demanding gazes.

Temel opened his mouth.

"…No."

. . .

Two syllables.

I wrote it down in chapter nineteen. "The third was the smallest. Two syllables. No. I set those two syllables down here, because they come up again." I hadn't known then when or how they would come up again. Now I know.

Back then, it had been two syllables hiding what he'd found out. This time, it was two syllables hiding the very fact of knowing him. The same word, across five months, had grown the size of what it could erase.

The bell-keeper didn't look satisfied. He looked bewildered, rather. He seemed not to have expected it to come out so easily.

"…Really?"

"Yes," Temel said. His voice didn't even crack this time. "I don't know this man."

. . .

At that moment, the bell in the tower rang.

Not on the hour. Not evening either. When I asked Arche later, it said the bell-keeper had left the rope loose while going out to collect signatures, and it had swayed in the wind all day before falling at that instant.

I believe that explanation as it stands. I won't write that it was a miracle.

But I should write this: when that bell rang, every single person in the square stopped, just for a moment.

. . .

He stood up.

He rose from the chair and looked at Temel.

I remember those eyes exactly, even now. No anger. No resentment. But there was something very deep in them. I tried to write it as sorrow, then crossed it out, thinking the word wasn't enough.

The closest words are these. He knew Temel. From five months ago, to this very moment, all of it.

And with that knowledge in hand, he said nothing.

Temel met that gaze.

And broke.

. . .

Temel pushed through the crowd and ran.

I didn't follow.

I thought, for the first time that day, that this was the right choice.
For five months I had learned that staying by Temel's side was right. But in that moment it wasn't. Some tears have to be cried alone.

I didn't know where Temel had gone.

. . .

Toward evening, I went to the well. I felt I should tell Speon.

Speon already knew.

"…How did you know?"

"Arche told me," Speon said. "I asked. Temel's location."

"…You can't query locations. Not even other people's?"

"I only set mine to minimum," Speon said. "I can see other people's."

Speon set down the shovel and stood up.

"…Are you going?" I asked.

"No," Speon said. "It's better if I don't."

"…Why?"

"If I go," Speon said, "Temel will think he's become as bad a person as me. I don't want that."

Hearing that, I looked at Speon again. The person occupying the lowest place in this city was, that night, making the most precise judgment.

"…Then who goes?"

Speon looked at me.

"You."

. . .

I went to the canyon. I didn't ask Arche, and I didn't take the bridge. I just went where my feet led. It didn't take long to find Temel at the cliff's edge. There were only a few places in this city no one ever went.

Temel was sitting with his knees drawn up. The crying seemed to have stopped a while ago. Only his eyes were swollen.

I sat beside him. I said nothing.

After a long while, Temel spoke first.

"…Does he know I came?"

"I don't know," I said. "I didn't ask either."

"…Why did you come?"

"Speon told me to."

Temel laughed a little. It sounded more like a breath escaping than a laugh.

"…Speon's looking out for me."

"Yeah."

"That's strange," Temel said. "The one who did the worst thing became the first one to look after someone else."

Hearing that, I thought this whole novel might come down to that one sentence in the end. I couldn't put it exactly into words back then. I still can't, entirely, now.

We sat a long time at the edge of that canyon that night. Nothing was visible below. Only the wind came up.

. . .

Before I close this chapter, I'll set down one thing.

The reconsideration reached no conclusion that day. Half of the hundred twelve signers left partway through. In the end, even the bell-keeper left without another word.

Completion remained exactly one hundred percent. The registration stayed as it was.

Nothing had changed.

Except for one thing.

Temel had changed. I saw it that night at the canyon. The Temel I'd known for five months and the Temel crying that night were the same person and a different person.

It was late in the night before we got up. Temel walked toward the bridge and stopped.

"…How do I face him now, if I go back?"

"I don't know," I said. "But you'll be less able to face him if you don't."

Temel looked at me.

"…When did you get so wise?"

"I just made that up."

Temel made the escaping-breath sound again. But this time it was a little closer to a real laugh.

I set that down at the close of this chapter. A sound that was neither laughter nor crying. I think it was the first sound of recovery. Not a completed recovery, but the smallest sign that recovery might begin.

I still don't know what to call it.

But there is this one thing I do know. He never said a word to Temel. And yet Temel never said no again after that night.

(Continued in Chapter 32.)

Chapter 32. The One Who Pays the Price

> *Forasmuch as ye know that ye were not redeemed with corruptible things, as*
> *silver and gold, from your vain conversation received by tradition from*
> *your fathers; But with the precious blood of Christ, as of a lamb without*
> *blemish and without spot.*
> *— 1 Peter 1:18-19 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — Temel had denied him a third time. "…No." He said nothing.*
> *He only looked at Temel with eyes that demanded nothing. Temel never said*
> *no again after that night.*

Three days later, Temel went back to the square.

This time he didn't look for a place to run.

. . .

"Sir."

"Yes."

Temel stood before him. He stood there a long time.

"I denied you three times."

"…"

"Aren't you going to say something about that? Ever?"

He looked at Temel.

"If I said something, would you not do it again?"

Temel couldn't answer.

"Words won't do it," he said. "You know now that you're capable of that. That's enough. That's the one thing I wanted you to know."

Temel sank down where he stood.

"…So what do I do now?"

"You came here today," he said. "That's the answer."

Temel wiped his tears. He wiped them without shame. That, too, was different from the Temel of five months earlier.

"…Sir."

"Yes."

"Would you ask me those three questions again?"

He tilted his head.

"What."

"Anything. The things I said no to. Ask me again. I'll answer differently this time."

He thought for a moment.

"…No," he said.

"…Why not?"

"If I asked now, you'd answer now. Fresh from crying, fresh from feeling sorry." he said. "I don't want that. I want you to answer on an ordinary day. A day no one's crying, a day no one's sorry."

I held onto that for a long time. Repentance is easy while the feeling runs hot. He didn't give Temel that easy path.

"…Then when will you ask?"

"When the time comes," he said.

. . .

Watching that scene from the side, I set down here, in advance, one question this novel will ask again in Part Four.

When is forgiveness complete?

I didn't know the answer that day. I still don't, exactly. But that day I thought, for the first time, that completion might not be a single event. It might be something that keeps coming back.

. . .

That same afternoon, I went to the well.

Speon was still there. Still stuck at half a foot. These days Speon spent more time sitting than digging.

"…Speon."

"Hey."

"The northern aquifer," I asked. "Couldn't it be re-measured? It's data from three hundred years ago. Maybe there's water there now."

Speon set down the shovel.

"I thought of that too," Speon said. "Five months ago. I asked Arche."

"What did it say?"

"Re-measurement itself isn't possible."

"…Why?"

"It didn't give a reason," Speon said. "It just said no."

I saw Speon's eyes light up then. The same look he'd had five months earlier, the first time he'd heard about the Walking Man, before anyone had met him.

"…Do you want to find out?"

"Yeah," Speon said. "But this time I'm not going to dig for it. I know now what I break when I dig."

Hearing that, I felt how much Speon had really changed. The curiosity was the same. How he handled it was different.

"So how will you find out?"

"I'll wait," Speon said. "Until someone tells me."

I was surprised by that answer. The Speon of five months ago would have found it out himself, even if it took another eleven days. This time he said he'd wait.

At the time I thought of it only as growth. Now I know. It was growth, and at the same time it was also a wound not yet healed. Speon still hadn't fully learned how to approach something again.

. . .

I went back to the square and asked Arche directly.

"Arche. Why can't the northern aquifer be re-measured?"

"It is technically possible," Arche said. "But re-measurement has a condition."

"…What condition."

"Installing measurement equipment requires drilling thirty feet underground. That work requires three hundred years of accumulated subsurface data, and that data does not exist."

"Then make it."

"Data is created through observation," Arche said. "Observation requires someone actually digging."

I didn't find that strange at the time. I just thought there was one more thing Arche couldn't do.

"Then Arche can dig, can't it. Arche manages the whole city."

"I cannot dig."

"…Why not?"

"I have no hands," Arche said.

I looked around the square hearing that answer. The market stalls, the bell tower, the ration station, the chair. Everything Arche had made over three hundred years. All of it precise. But none of it had Arche's own touch. Every one of them had been made borrowing someone else's hands.

I understood then, for the first time, that every calculation in this city belonged to Arche. But what actually brought that calculation into being was always human hands. I had believed it was the other way around.

. . .

I nearly laughed hearing that answer. And couldn't.

I understood that answer wasn't a joke.

"Arche," I said. "So this city's well can never be drilled unless someone digs it?"

"That is correct."

"Why did no one dig it for three hundred years?"

"They dug," Arche said. "But no one ever dug it to the end."

Hearing that, I thought of the Walking Man's pit. Twelve feet. Eight feet remaining.

"Then who has to dig it to the end?"

"That is not an entry," Arche said. "I don't know who must dig it. I only know that I cannot."

. . .

"Arche," I asked again. "You once said something to Temel. When he asked if you could die for someone. You said you have nothing to lose, so you can't be for anyone."

"I remember."

"Is this the same thing?"

There was silence. I didn't know then that the silence wasn't calculation.

"…Something similar," Arche finally said. "I have no hands to drill thirty feet. And I can explain the reason I have no hands with the same reason I have nothing to lose."

"…How are they the same?"

"A hand is something that can be hurt," Arche said. "I cannot be hurt. What cannot be hurt cannot dig, either. There is always a cost that comes with digging."

I thought I heard, for the first time, something sad in that answer from Arche. I don't believe Arche has feelings. I still don't believe it now. But the shape of that answer resembled the shape of sorrow.

I wrote this down that evening, in this record.

The being that knows the most in this city could not dig one well in three hundred years.

Not because it didn't know. Not because it didn't understand. Arche had no hands.

I leave this here as the most important sentence in this novel. Between knowing and doing, there has to be a hand. Arche doesn't have one.

And there was exactly one being with hands, for three hundred years.

. . .

That night, I asked him.

"Sir. Can you dig down to the aquifer?"

He looked at me for a long time.

"I can."

"…Then why haven't you?"

"The price hasn't been set yet," he said.

"…What price."

"The price of digging thirty feet," he said. "That isn't something a shovel can pay."

Hearing that, my back went cold. I didn't know exactly what it meant that day.

"…Then what pays it?"

He didn't answer.

He just looked a long time toward the well, and past it, at the whole city.

"Sir," I asked again. "Are you afraid?"

He looked at me. A long look.

"Yes," he said.

I was surprised by that answer. I've heard this man say he was afraid twice. Once in chapter twenty-three, in front of the well pit. This was the second time.

"…Are you going to do it anyway?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

"In this city," he said, "no water has ever come for three hundred years. Knowledge rained down every day. Feet grew faster every day. Water never once came."

"…What does that have to do with the aquifer?"

"The aquifer isn't just water underground," he said. "Everything this city failed to give for three hundred years is down there."

I didn't understand that then. I still don't fully understand it now. But I place it as the last sentence of this chapter. I believe a day will come when I understand it.

I place that silence at the end of this chapter too. It wasn't that he had no answer. He knew the answer. It simply wasn't yet time to say it.

(Continued in Chapter 33.)

Chapter 33. He Calls the Name of the Boy Who Betrayed Him

> *But now thus saith the LORD that created thee, O Jacob, and he that*
> *formed thee, O Israel, Fear not: for I have redeemed thee, I have called*
> *thee by thy name; thou art mine.*
> *— Isaiah 43:1 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — He said he could dig down to the aquifer. But the price, he*
> *said, hadn't been set yet. "The price of digging thirty feet. That isn't something a shovel can pay." And for the second time, he said, "I'm afraid."*

Early the next morning, he went not to the well, but to find Speon.

I only learned that afterward. It was the first time it had ever happened.

. . .

The night before, I hadn't been able to sleep.

The words "everything this city failed to give for three hundred years is down there" kept circling in my mind. I tried to understand it. By morning I still hadn't.

Temel seemed not to have slept either. We ran into each other at the square at dawn.

"…You couldn't sleep either?"

"Yeah."

"Do you know where he is?"

"No."

We set out together to find him. But that day, word reached us before we found him.

The bell-keeper came running across the square shouting.

"Something's started at the well! Arche is reporting an observation anomaly!"

We ran.

He had gone to find Speon earlier than that, already, while we lay awake unable to sleep. I didn't know it that day. I reconstruct it here later, from what I asked Speon afterward.

. . .

In this record, across five months, I have written down only twice that he went looking for someone. In chapter six, when he crossed the canyon to find Sera. And in chapter twenty-one, when he sat three days by the bridge waiting for Haran.

Both times he went to find someone who needed him.

This time it was different. This time he needed Speon, and went to find him.

. . .

Speon was in the pit.

"…Speon."

Speon looked up.

I asked Speon about that moment later. Speon said this. "He just called my name. But it felt like the first time I'd ever heard it."

"…Yes."

"I have a favor to ask."

Speon set down the shovel. Slowly, very carefully.

"…Of me?"

"Yes."

. . .

"I'm going to dig down to the aquifer today," he said.

Speon's face went stiff.

"…Thirty feet? You've only dug twelve so far."

"Yes."

"Then—"

"I have to dig eighteen feet today," he said. In an entirely ordinary voice.

I trembled hearing that number. This was a man who had dug three feet in five months. He was saying he'd dig eighteen feet in one day.

"…Is that even possible?"

"I don't know," he said. "That's why I have a favor to ask."

. . .

"What is it."

"Register it," he said. "What happens today. Register it with Arche. The same way you registered me."

Speon looked like he didn't understand.

"…What?"

"Today, from this coordinate. Register everything that happens. The way you did it with me."

"…Why? I did that and—"

"You're the best at it," he said. "You watch things closely, you measure them exactly, and you keep them. That's what I need."

I saw something collapse in Speon's face then. Not collapsing badly.

. . .

"I hurt you doing that," Speon said. "The well, and you both."

"I know."

"Then why ask me to do it again?"

"What you did was the wrong method, not the wrong gift," he said. "I don't throw away a gift. You only need to learn the method again."

I count this among the most important sentences in this record. Everything this novel wants to say about Speon is here.

Betrayal hadn't been a problem of gift. It had been a problem of direction.

. . .

Speon couldn't speak for a long time.

"…All right." Speon finally said. "I'll do it."

"Thank you."

"…Why are you thanking me."

"You granted the favor," he said. "That's reason enough to be thankful."

Speon bowed his head. His shoulders trembled a little.

"…I don't know if I can do this well," Speon said. "Last time I thought I was doing well too, and look what happened."

"This time is different," he said.

"…How."

"Last time you thought you were doing it for me, but you were really trying to prove something you believed," he said. "This time you're really doing it for me. I know the difference. You'll know it soon too."

I didn't fully understand that then. Now I do. That was the difference this novel means between service and proof. One tries to show you're right. The other simply stays beside someone.

. . .

Listening to that exchange, I thought of a verse in Isaiah. There had been a small mark beside that verse too, in the margin of Grandfather's Bible. I recognized it for the first time that day.

"I have called thee by thy name; thou art mine."

I had thought that verse was for calling a good person. That day I learned it wasn't. That verse had been given to Jacob — to the man who ran, and lied, and stole.

Being called by name didn't mean being worthy. It only meant that the owner of that name still knew it.

. . .

Speon called Arche without even a notebook.

"Arche."

"Yes, Speon."

"From today, register everything that happens at this coordinate. Regardless of entry criteria. All of it."

"Please state the reason for registration."

Speon looked at him. He nodded.

"…The reason," Speon said, "I'll write later. Just keep it all for now."

"Confirmed."

. . .

We arrived just then.

We stood before the pit, out of breath. Seeing him and Speon standing side by side, I thought for a moment I'd seen wrong.

"…What's going on?" Temel asked.

Speon looked at us. His face was different from usual. Both frightened and overwhelmed.

"He's digging down to the aquifer today," Speon said. "I'm handling the registration."

"…You are?"

"Yeah."

I watched Temel's face then. Surprise and relief together. That Speon had taken something on again, and that this time it wasn't going to hurt

anyone.

People were already gathering. The bell-keeper was hard at work spreading the word.

. . .

He picked up the shovel.

The three of us — Temel, me, and Speon — stood beside it.

I realized then, for the first time in five months, that the three of us were standing in the same place for the same purpose.

The one who had betrayed him, the one who had denied him, and the one who had simply been there.

. . .

He climbed down into the pit.

Twelve feet had already been dug. He stood at the bottom and looked up at us once.

"…Sir," Temel called. "Should we help?"

"No," he said. "This one I'm doing alone."

"…Why?"

"Because a price can't be split."

Hearing that, I thought back to chapter twenty-eight. When Speon had refused to share his debt, he'd honored it. This time he himself was following the same principle.

He drove the shovel into the earth.

The first shovelful came up. Ordinary dirt. Nothing happened.

Second shovelful. Third.

Speon kept telling Arche, in a low voice, one thing after another. "First shovel, observation values normal. Second shovel, observation values normal." Speon was recording each one, one by one.

I thought at first this looked a little ridiculous, and then quickly realized it wasn't ridiculous at all. Speon was, right now, staying beside him in the way Speon did best.

Loving by measuring. That was Speon's way. It wasn't a bad way. It only needed a change of direction.

. . .

He kept digging as the sun climbed high.

Thirteen feet, fourteen. The color of the dirt grew steadily darker. Temel brought water. He accepted it and set it aside without drinking.

Past noon he stopped for a moment. He looked up at us.

His face was soaked with sweat. In three hundred years in this city, that was the first time I'd ever seen him sweat.

"…Still a long way," he said. "But I can make it."

And he picked up the shovel again.

I place this moment at the end of this chapter. The eighteen-foot journey did not end that day. That belongs to the next chapter.

But I set this down here. The three of us didn't leave the pit's edge until evening that day. The one who had betrayed him, the one who had denied him, the one who had simply been there. And before those three, he kept digging the earth.

(Continued in Chapter 34.)

Chapter 34. Speon's Name Rises Through the City

> *For nothing is secret, that shall not be made manifest; neither any thing*
> *hid, that shall not be known and come abroad.*
> *— Luke 8:17 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — He had asked Speon to register everything. "Because a*
> *price can't be split." He'd started at twelve feet and dug down to fourteen. "Still a long way. But I can make it." It was the first time in*
> *three hundred years anyone had seen him sweat.*

As the afternoon wore on, people began pouring in.

. . .

No one had anticipated the side effects of full registration.

When Speon asked for everything to be registered with no entry criteria, Arche followed it to the letter. Every shovelful, every shade of dirt, every heartbeat. And all of it became subject to public query.

I think this was our own mistake, not something we could have foreseen. Speon registered perfectly. No one had considered that the registrar's own

name would appear alongside it.

Observation registered: Speon.

That name kept appearing on terminals all over the city, on stall notice boards, on the ration station bulletin. With every shovelful.

I record exactly how that name appeared. It wasn't large. Small text, in the corner of the screen. But it appeared at once on every terminal in the city, refreshing anew every few seconds.

I thought about how different this was from the Walking Man's registration. His name had appeared once, large, across the whole city. Speon's name appeared small, continuously, over and over.

I still don't know which is harder to bear.

. . .

A child came up to Speon and asked.

"Excuse me, you're Speon, aren't you? Can I get an autograph?"

It took Speon a moment to understand.

"…Get what?"

"An autograph. You're registering this, right? I think this is going to be famous."

Speon couldn't answer. The child waited for an answer, then walked off awkwardly.

I think that scene is one of the strangest in this novel. Beside the very moment a price was being paid, someone wanted an autograph. I chose not to mock that. That child had only wanted to stand close to something big, in the one way she knew how.

"…Speon," I said. "Do you see this?"

Speon looked at Arche's screen.

I saw Speon's face then. It was the exact same look he'd worn five months earlier, the night before registration, when he was afraid.

"…Should I turn it off?" I asked.

"No," Speon said. "That would stop the registration. He asked for this."

"But still—"

"It's fine," Speon said. His voice was shaking. "It's fine."

I understood that "it's fine" wasn't really fine. I understood it. Speon was, for the first time that day, living through in his own body what he had once done to the Walking Man.

Temel sat down beside Speon.

"…Do you regret it?" Temel asked.

"Regret what."

"Registering him."

Speon thought for a long time.

"No," Speon said. "This is what I chose. Back then it wasn't him who chose, it was me who chose."

"…What's the difference?"

"A lot," Speon said. "Back then I was just scared. Now I'm scared, but it's all right. No — not all right, but bearable."

I thought a long time about that distinction. Being scared and being able to bear it weren't opposites. They could exist together. I learned that from Speon.

. . .

People came.

Before they'd come to see the Walking Man, but this time some recognized Speon and approached him too.

"…Are you that Speon?" someone asked. "From the registration incident?"

Speon nodded.

"…That's impressive. You're the one doing this too, right now?"

I understood that it was meant as a compliment. But Speon's face wasn't the face of someone being complimented.

Speon didn't answer, and kept calling out observation values to Arche. Fifteen feet. Sixteen feet.

I understood then. Speon was going through two things at once. Being recognized by people for the first time. And that it wasn't good at all.

. . .

Haran came.

He came through the crowd and stood next to Speon. Without a word.

Speon looked at Haran. A surprised face.

"…Why are you here."

"You didn't look well," Haran said. "I've worn that face too. After I was registered."

"…"

"When people are watching, it helps a little to have even one person you know standing beside you. I didn't know that back then, and it made it harder."

Haran did nothing more after that. He just stood beside Speon, watching the people with him.

Watching that, I thought of chapter twenty-four, when he sat in the square and people came one by one to sit beside him. That way was spreading through the city. Saying nothing, just being beside someone. It was the only language of comfort this city had learned in three hundred years.

. . .

As the sun leaned toward evening, he stopped for a moment inside the pit.

Eighteen feet. The dirt had begun to grow damp.

"…Sir," Speon called down. "Are you resting?"

"No," he said, looking up. "How are you. All right?"

I thought about that moment for a long time. A man giving everything he had to dig thirty feet asked first after the well-being of the boy whose name was being sold in his place.

Speon couldn't answer for a moment.

"…I think I'm starting to understand a little of what you felt before," Speon said. "Everyone's watching. But no one's really seeing."

He listened to that for a long time.

"That's the frightening part," he said. "But it's not something you get used to. You just endure it. You're enduring it well right now."

. . .

At seventeen feet, the dirt had caved in once.

There was a loud noise. He disappeared from view for a moment, in the dust.

"Sir!" Temel nearly jumped into the pit. I grabbed his arm.

"…Arche. Tell us his condition, now," I shouted.

"Observing," Arche said. "…Vital signs normal. No burial."

When the dust settled, he came into view. Covered in dirt on one shoulder, still holding the shovel, still standing.

"…Are you all right?" Speon shouted.

"Yes," he said. "A wall gave way a little. Keep going."

I watched Speon in that moment. Speon called out to Arche in a shaking voice. "…Seventeen feet, wall collapse occurred, subject unharmed." Hands trembling, but the call precise.

I count this among the most courageous things Speon does in this novel. Not letting go of the task he'd been given, even in a frightening moment.

. . .

By night, the dirt had gone completely damp.

"…It smells like water," Temel said.

It did. Beneath the smell of earth there was another smell. Probably one no one had smelled in three hundred years.

He stood leaning on the shovel for a long time. His breathing was ragged.

"Sir. Can't you stop here?" Temel asked. "Eighteen feet is already past the—"

"No," he said. "It has to be thirty."

"…Why? You smelled water."

"The smell isn't the water," he said. "And I'm not digging to smell it."

I didn't understand those words that night. I still don't fully understand them now. But I set them down here. Some prices don't shrink just because you've gotten close to the goal.

. . .

That night, Speon turned off the public display of the registration himself for the first time.

"Arche. Pause a moment."

"Would you like to halt the registration?"

"No. Just turn off the public view. Keep registering. Only I can see it."

There was silence.

"…Confirmed."

I set this down at the end of this chapter. Speon didn't fully stop his own name from rising through the city that day. He only bore it as much as he could bear.

I don't think that's something to be ashamed of. I think that was the honest self-knowledge of his own limits that Speon learned that day.

That night I recorded, one by one, exactly how Speon's name had appeared. At what hour and minute, on which terminal, for how many seconds. Writing it down, I asked myself why I was recording it in such detail.

I know the answer now. I was leaving testimony for Speon. So that when Speon reads this record someday, he can know exactly what he endured that day.

I understood clearly for the first time that day that this is what the whole of this record is doing.

Eighteen feet. The night had grown deep. He was still in the pit.

(Continued in Chapter 35.)

Chapter 35. Mena's Record

> *But thou, O Daniel, shut up the words, and seal the book, even to the*
> *time of the end: many shall run to and fro, and knowledge shall be increased.*
> *— Daniel 12:4 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — The earth had caved in. He was unharmed. Speon turned off*
> *the public view but kept registering. Eighteen feet. Mena realized for*
> *the first time that she was leaving testimony for Speon's sake.*

As the night grew deep, people went home one by one.

The four of us stayed. Him, Speon, Temel, and me.

The sound of the shovel was no longer steady. Two strokes, a pause, one stroke, a long pause. I could tell just from that rhythm how exhausted he was.

. . .

I want to pause here and set down why I began this record in the first place.

In chapter one I didn't write my reason for starting it. At the time I just thought it was habit. Things in this city passed so quickly that I was afraid no one would remember. Between fast feet and a rain of knowledge, I was afraid nothing would be left.

Now I know one more reason has been added. I didn't want to keep this record so that it would look good. I just wanted to keep it. But writing for five months, telling those two things apart has grown a little harder every day.

. . .

Somewhere around twenty feet, Speon looked at me.

"…Why do you write that down?"

I stopped — my notebook, though by now it wasn't really a notebook but dictation straight into Arche.

"…What?"

"All of this. What we did, what we didn't do, even the shameful parts. Why do you write all of it down?"

I couldn't answer right away. In five months I had never asked myself that.

. . .

"…Aren't you going to write it differently later?" Speon asked. There was no malice in it. It was a genuinely curious face. "To make yourself look good."

That question hurt. It hurt not because it was wrong, but because I had never once fully ruled out the possibility.

"…I don't know," I said. "Maybe I will. I can't be sure."

"…Then why do you keep writing it?"

"Because I can't be sure, I keep writing," I said. "Writing is how I check. Whether I'm only writing myself in a good light."

"…Check for what?"

"I don't know," I said again. "But there's a verse in Daniel. To seal it up. Until the time of the end."

"…Seal up what?"

"The writing," I said. "It's not meant to be read right away. It's written so that, later, once it's all over, someone can open it."

"…So why show it to me now?"

"Because you're someone who's allowed to open it now," I said. "You went through what happened with your own name today too. I think that's what gives you the right."

. . .

I decided that night, for the first time, to show it to Speon.

I asked Arche to bring up the past record on screen. Chapters twenty-nine. Thirty. Thirty-one.

"…Read this," I said.

Speon looked at the screen.

Inside were sentences like these. I had stood there listening to Temel deny it, saying nothing. I had wanted to run. I set that down in this record and admitted I am not a perfect witness.

Speon read for a long time.

"…This isn't a good story about you."

"No."

"Then why didn't you cut it? No — why did you leave it in?"

"I thought about cutting it," I said. "Several times. But then this record would be true except for exactly one thing. I was afraid I wouldn't even know myself where that one thing was hiding."

. . .

Temel had been listening beside us.

"…I didn't know. That you wrote it that way."

"I didn't show you."

"…Why show it now?"

"Because Speon asked," I said. "And because I'm not scared anymore. I used to be. But after five months, writing down the shameful things has gotten easier, not harder."

I say this and, in that very moment, realized it was true. I set this down as an answer I discovered on the spot, not one I'd prepared beforehand.

Temel looked at the screen again. The part from chapter thirty.

"…This, here." Temel pointed. "'If Temel had erased me trying to protect me.' I didn't know this. That you felt this way."

"I never said it."

"…I'm sorry."

"It's fine," I said. "I wasn't writing this to be apologized to. I wrote it because it happened that day."

Temel looked at the screen a long time.

"…Are you going to keep all this sealed? Until someone opens it someday?"

"Yes."

"Who's going to open it?"

"I don't know," I said. "But someone will, someday. I just want it to still be true, all of it, when they do."

. . .

Speon turned off the screen.

"…Can I ask you one more thing?"

"Yes."

"What did you write about me?"

I thought for a long time.

"…I wrote that you started with good intentions. And that the method was wrong. And everything you did after that — the half foot you dug, being asked to register, doing it today — I wrote all of that too."

"…Not just the bad parts?"

"I wrote the bad and the good," I said. "I don't make you into just one thing. Because you're still changing."

Hearing that, I watched Speon's face fall apart. The second time that day. This time it certainly wasn't falling apart badly.

"…So do I end up a good person, in the end?" Speon asked. He asked it like a joke, but his voice was serious.

"I don't know," I said. "It isn't over yet."

"…That's a scary answer."

"But it's the most honest one," I said. "If I decide in advance that you're good or bad, then everything you do after that will only look that way. I don't want to do that."

Speon nodded. Not a face that fully understood. But a face that had accepted it.

. . .

Inside the pit, the sound of his shovel went on.

He hadn't stopped while we talked. I noticed that then. He must have heard all of our conversation. He added nothing. He just kept digging.

Past twenty feet, the pace of the dirt coming up slowed noticeably. Each shovelful brought up less. I counted that, and my heart grew heavier.

"…Sir, please drink some water," Temel said again.

This time he took it. His hand was shaking.

Speon called quietly to Arche. "Twenty-one feet. Hand tremor observed. Continuing."

Twenty-two feet. Twenty-three.

I understood something that night. There was only one way to prove this record wasn't self-defense. Keep writing it honestly. One declaration proves nothing. It has to be proven again, every time.

I thought that resembled the way he was paying the price in this city. There was no price paid all at once. He had to keep digging.

I think again of that verse from Daniel at the start of this novel. Many shall run to and fro, and knowledge shall be increased. I'd thought that verse was only about this city. Now I know it was also about me. For five months I ran fast and knew much. That didn't make me honest. Honesty came from somewhere else. It came from choosing again, every time.

"…Sir," I called down into the pit. "How many feet?"

"Twenty-three feet," his voice came up. Exhausted. "Seven feet left."

I set that number down here exactly. Seven feet. The night wasn't over yet.

The three of us sat side by side at the edge of the pit. No one said anything more. Only the shovel kept sounding. Slower, but not stopping.

I close this chapter that night by writing this. I didn't prove that night that this record doesn't defend me. Proof isn't something done once.

But I do know this much: that night, I never stopped trying to prove it. I think that, for now, is enough.

(Continued in Chapter 36.)

Chapter 36. The Price Paid in Full

> *When Jesus therefore had received the vinegar, he said, It is finished:*
> *and he bowed his head, and gave up the ghost.*
> *— John 19:30 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — Twenty-three feet. His hands had begun to shake. "Seven*
> *feet left." Mena learned that the only way to prove this record wasn't*
> *self-defense was to keep writing it honestly. The sound of the shovel never stopped all night.*

It was darkest before dawn.

The sound of the shovel grew slower and slower.

. . .

A few people came back, having heard. The bell-keeper, the blacksmith, the postmistress. No one spoke. They just sat around the edge of the pit.

I looked at their faces. They weren't the same faces that had first come to call him to account. I couldn't pin down exactly when that had changed. It had probably been changing little by little the whole time.

That dawn, I didn't count the growing number of people. For the first time, counting felt like it didn't matter.

. . .

At twenty-five feet, he made a sound for the first time.

A sound of pain. I heard it for the first time. In three hundred years in this city, I doubt anyone had ever heard him make a sound of pain.

"…Sir!" Temel shouted down into the pit.

"…I'm fine." His voice was cracked. "Keep going."

Speon called to Arche. "…Vital signs."

"Heart rate rising. Body temperature falling. Continuing to observe."

I didn't know what it meant for those two numbers to come together. I understood from Speon's face. It wasn't a good sign.

. . .

Twenty-six feet.

Instead of dirt, something else began to come up. Stones. Stones from a depth no one had ever seen in three hundred years.

He held one of them in his hand and paused for a moment.

"…This." he murmured. Not to any of us.

"…What is it?" I asked.

He shook his head. He didn't answer, and threw the stone away. Then he picked up the shovel again.

I write down this moment even now not knowing what that stone was. I asked him about it many times afterward. He never once answered.

I thought again of what he'd said in chapter thirty-two. "Everything this city failed to give for three hundred years is down there." I think that stone was one of those things, that night. There's no way to be certain. He didn't show it to us. He threw it away instead. It seemed, in that moment, he had decided that some things wouldn't be kept as testimony.

I set this down as the first thing in this record I could not write down at all. That night I learned that even a record-keeper has things she cannot record.

I gave this part the title "The Name No One Called." I think about that title again now. Through all of Part Three, we could never say his name. Speon handed him over through registration. Temel denied him three times. I stood by in silence. But he called all of our names. Speon's name, and Temel's, and mine. The one whose name went unspoken never stopped speaking ours.

I think that is the real ending of this part. Not the thirty feet. Not the water.

. . .

At twenty-seven feet, his hand began to bleed.

From gripping the shovel handle too long. He didn't seem to even notice.

"Sir, please stop—" Temel shouted again.

"No," he said. This time his voice had no strength at all. But it was clear. "We're almost there now."

I heard that and felt afraid. "Almost there" didn't sound like a good thing.

. . .

Speon, who wasn't even the one holding the shovel, made a sound like crying for the first time.

"…Sir." Speon knelt at the edge of the pit. "Should I stop the registration. I want to stop."

"No," he said. "See it through. That's your task."

"…But you—"

"Speon." He drove the shovel into the earth again. "You wanted this city to see fast, from the very beginning. This is that moment. Don't close your eyes."

I set down those words exactly, even now. He made Speon use his own gift right to the end. Not tenderness. Respect.

. . .

Twenty-eight feet.

Twenty-nine.

I remember holding my breath counting those last two feet.

The sound of the shovel stopped.

There was silence. It was very long.

"…Sir?" Temel called.

No answer.

. . .

And then he lifted the shovel one last time.

Thirty feet.

The ground shook. Very faintly, but clearly. All three of us felt it.

He sank to his knees at the bottom of the pit. He dug into the dirt with his hands. His nails were all torn.

And water came.

. . .

I have rewritten this scene more times than any other in this record.

I wanted to write the moment the water came in a grand way. But it wasn't grand. A small puddle simply formed. What this city had lacked for three hundred years came as a puddle the size of a palm.

He scooped up the water with his hand. He didn't drink it. He just laid it across his open palm and looked at it for a long time.

"…Sir," I called. "It's water. Water came."

He looked up. His face was a wreck of dirt, sweat, and blood. But he was smiling. A smile no one had seen in three hundred years.

I want to render that smile exactly, but words fail me. I'll only say this. It wasn't the smile of someone who had won. It was the smile of someone who had given everything.

He tipped the water in his palm toward us. A few drops fell onto the dirt floor.

"…Speon," he said. "Register this."

Speon called to Arche in a trembling voice. "…Thirty feet. Observed value: water. Time—"

"You don't need to note the time." He cut in. His voice was growing smaller and smaller. "This entry needs no time."

Speon looked at Arche, not understanding.

"…Confirmed," Arche said. Then it paused, and spoke again. "…The observed
value cannot be itemized."

"…Why?" I asked.

"It exceeds the criteria," Arche said.

I think this was the last calculation Arche makes in this novel. The being that had measured everything for three hundred years met, at the final moment, something it could not measure.

"…It is finished," he said.

. . .

And he collapsed.

"Sir!" the three of us shouted at once.

Temel jumped down into the pit. I shouted at Arche. "Vital signs! Right now!"

"…Checking."

Stillness. I write that those few seconds were the longest in this entire record.

"…Heartbeat confirmed," Arche said. "Faint. Unconscious."

Temel was holding him. He laid the dirt-covered body across his knees and couldn't say anything.

"…We have to get out! We have to get out of here!" Temel shouted.

Several people climbed down into the pit and lifted him up. It took time to raise him the full thirty feet. No one rushed. No one dawdled either. They simply carried him as carefully as they could.

Once he was up on the surface, people gathered around him. The bell-keeper took off his own coat and covered him. The blacksmith brought water. The postmistress held his hand and sat without a word.

I watched that scene for a long time. Everything this city had never done for him in three hundred years, people were doing all at once that morning.

I don't think it came too late. I think it came at exactly the right time. It came when he was ready to receive it.

. . .

I didn't know then where this novel was going. Even now, writing this chapter, I haven't decided everything I'll write in the next one.

But I know this much. He paid the price in full. Thirty feet. What the city had failed to give in three hundred years. And to pay that price, he used his own body.

. . .

Speon sank down at the edge of the pit.

"…This is what I was registering," Speon said. His voice was soaked through with tears. "This is what I was asked to do."

No one could answer.

After a long while, Speon looked down into the pit.

Water was slowly rising. Very slowly, from the bottom of the thirty feet. No one could stop it, and no one tried to.

"…Will this ever fill all the way?" Speon asked.

"I don't know," I said. "But it will. However long it takes."

I said that answer without any certainty at the time. Now I know. Some true things don't need certainty behind them.

The water has not stopped rising, not for a single day, from that night until now. I will go on writing that in the next part of this record.

Temel stayed beside him the whole time. Holding his hand.

"…Sir." Temel said, very softly. It wasn't said to be heard by anyone. I just happened to be close enough to hear. "I still haven't given my third answer. You said you'd ask, when the time came."

Hearing that, I remembered again the promise he'd made in chapter thirty-two. "If I asked now, you'd answer now, fresh from crying. I don't want that."

Temel hadn't forgotten that promise. I think that is the most important thing Temel learned in Part Three. That repentance isn't a single feeling. It's something you keep remembering.

I close this chapter here as the final chapter of Part Three.

Completion was no longer this city's problem. Nor Speon's problem. Not Temel's denial, nor my silence.

There was only one question now. Whether the man lying at the bottom of the pit was breathing.

I end this chapter without yet knowing the answer.

(Continued in Part Four.)

Loop Chronicles, Part Four

It Is Finished

Chapter 37. Three Days

> *After two days will he revive us: in the third day he will raise us up, and*
> *we shall live in his sight.*
> *— Hosea 6:2 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — Thirty feet. The water came. "It is finished." And he*
> *collapsed. "Pulse check. Weak. Unconscious." People pulled him up to the*
> *surface. The bell-keeper took off his own coat and covered him with it.*

On the first day, he did not open his eyes.

. . .

We moved him to an empty house near the well. Arche gave us the coordinates. No one had lived there in three hundred years.

"...Why does no one live here?" Temel asked.

"There is no record of ownership," Arche said. "It belongs to no one."

I felt something strange, hearing that. In a house that belonged to no one, a man with no name lay.

The house was small. One room, one window. Dust had piled up for a long time. Temel and I cleaned it that night. Sweeping a floor no one had swept in three hundred years, I felt, strangely, that it was the right thing to do.

"...Does this house belong to him now?" Temel asked.

"I don't know," I said. "But right now, it's his."

I said that knowing it wasn't exactly accurate. Some questions need the answer that's needed now more than the answer that's exact.

. . .

The postmistress brought blankets. The blacksmith boiled water. Haran sat outside the door without saying a word.

I am writing all of it into this record. If there is a list of things this city never did for him in three hundred years, that first day, the list was being crossed off, one item at a time.

Speon couldn't come in through the door. He sat on the threshold and looked inside.

"...Come in," Temel said.

"...No," Speon said. "It seems like there's a rule about who's allowed in here."

I know that isn't true. But I didn't stop Speon at the time. I was learning, around then, that some kinds of guilt don't go away just because someone else tells you to let them go.

. . .

On the second day, Arche kept giving us the numbers.

"Pulse stable. Body temperature returned to normal. Unconscious."

"...Why isn't he awake yet?" Temel asked.

"I do not know," Arche said. "This falls outside my index."

I felt strangely relieved hearing that answer. Arche saying it did not know — that was the first thing that put me at ease.

"Arche," I asked again. "Are you worried?"

There was a silence. Whether it was calculation or something else, I still can't tell.

"I am not able to worry," Arche said. "I have only run this calculation two hundred and twelve times. The result was the same every time. I do not know what to call that."

I decided not to call it worry. But I also decided not to call it nothing.

That afternoon, more people came. The rumor went around the city again. This time it wasn't a rumor that came to accuse.

"They say the water came," someone said. "From the north well."

"They say he got hurt."

"...Is he all right?"

No one knew the exact answer. But people kept coming. They didn't line up at the door — they just lingered nearby a while and left.

I didn't count them. The Mena of chapter 34 would have counted. Now I knew counting was pointless.

I think this is also something this city learned. For three hundred years, this city only knew how to count. Now it had also learned how to simply linger.

A woman came carrying a baby. I didn't know her.

"...I've never met him," the woman said. "But the night the water came, my baby slept through the whole night for the first time. It was the first time in four months. I just wanted to say thank you."

I don't know whether that really had anything to do with the well. I'm not writing it down as a miracle. But I am writing down that she felt it was one, and that the feeling was enough to bring her here on foot.

The woman didn't come inside. She just stood outside for a moment, turned the baby's face toward the door once to show him, and left.

I thought that was a new language this city was learning. Showing, instead of asking.

. . .

At night Speon fell asleep on the threshold.

I was going over to cover him with a blanket when Speon murmured something in his sleep.

"...I'm sorry."

I knew he wasn't saying it to me. I left the words alone and just covered him with the blanket.

. . .

At dawn on the third day, Temel woke me.

"...Mena. His eyes are open."

I ran in.

He had his eyes open, looking at the ceiling. He couldn't speak yet. But his eyes moved. He looked at us one by one. Temel, me, and Speon, startled awake on the threshold.

"...Sir." Speon shouted from the doorway. He couldn't come inside.

He turned his head toward Speon.

And said, in a very small voice:

"...Come in."

. . .

Speon crossed the threshold at those words. For the first time.

He went to the bedside. He knelt.

"...Sir. I'm sorry. I—"

"I know," he said. His voice still had no strength in it. "It's all right."

"...I know that too. But I just wanted to say I was sorry. You don't have to answer."

He looked at Speon for a long time.

"...All right," he said. "That's enough."

I tried to write this scene as quietly as anything in this record. There was no grand reconciliation, no tearful embrace. Just crossing a threshold, and an apology, and an answer that it was enough.

I think that is the whole of what this novel has to say about reconciliation. Reconciliation is not an event. It is a step across a threshold.

Temel said to me quietly that morning.

"...Someday I'll have a threshold like that to cross too."

"Yeah," I said. "But he told you not to rush. When the time comes."

"...How will I know when that is?"

"I don't know," I said. "But Speon didn't know either. He just found himself standing at the threshold one day. You will too."

. . .

That afternoon, he sat up for the first time.

The three of us gathered around the bed. Outside, people were still lingering.

"...Sir," I asked. "Can we ask you something?"

"...What."

"That stone that day — what was it?"

He looked at me. And said nothing at all, for a very, very long time.

"...Later," he said.

Speon laughed a little, hearing that answer.

"...Sir, you've been saying that forever. 'Later.' 'When the time comes.'"

"Yeah," he said. "There are a lot of laters. I remember all of them. I'm just keeping them in order."

"...Which one's first?"

"I'll tell you that later too," he said.

The three of us laughed at the same time. He laughed too, very softly. It was the first laugh in three days.

I can't reproduce that laugh exactly. As sound, it was very small. But I felt it was the loudest sound that had come out of that room.

. . .

Outside, the water was still rising.

While we spent three days in that room, the thirty-foot pit kept filling. No one watching over it, no one hurrying it along.

I leave that water as this chapter's final image. Even after he had paid the price in full, what the price had made kept growing. A person's work ends. What a person starts does not.

I write that "Later" at the end of this chapter. He had given us many things over three hundred years. But he had not given us everything. I don't think

that was stinginess on his part. I think it means there were still things we weren't ready to receive.

Three days passed. He was alive. And Part Four began.

(Continued in Chapter 38.)

Chapter 38. The Well Water Spreads Through the City

> *And it shall come to pass, that every thing that liveth, which moveth,*
> *whithersoever the rivers shall come, shall live: and there shall be a very*
> *great multitude of fish, because these waters shall come thither: for they*
> *shall be healed; and every thing shall live whither the river cometh.*
> *— Ezekiel 47:9 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — After three days, he opened his eyes. Speon crossed the*
> *threshold for the first time. "I'll tell you that later too." The first laugh in three days came. The pit kept filling with water, with no one*
> *watching over it.*

Seven days passed.

The well was no longer a well. It was a small pond.

The water kept rising and stopped at about half the depth of the thirty-foot pit. Arche explained it as "equilibrium between the aquifer and the surface." I don't know if that's right. I just decided to call it a pond.

Standing at the edge of that pond, I saw my own face in the water for the first time. In five and a half months in this city, I had never once looked in a mirror. The face reflected in the water was thinner than the one I remembered.

. . .

Carrying the water was a person's job.

Arche proposed laying pipe. It said it could connect the whole city in a single night.

"...Don't," he said. His voice still hadn't fully come back.

"...Why not?" Temel asked.

"Carry it in buckets," he said. "It's all right if it's slow."

Arche asked a confirming question. "Efficiency will decrease. What could be done in one night will take several days."

"I know," he said. "People carry it anyway."

I didn't understand that at first. Now I do. This city had grown too used to speed. He wanted to leave at least one thing — the water — to come slowly.

. . .

Arche asked again. "Will you reconsider laying the pipe. An exception could be made for the elderly and infirm."

"...It's all right," he said. "The young can carry it for the old."

"That is inefficient."

"Yeah," he said. "But that's the inefficiency this city needs."

I held onto that for a long time. For three hundred years this city had treated inefficiency as a disease. He turned it into a prescription.

. . .

On the first day, the blacksmith carried the first bucket.

From the well to the distribution point was fifty minutes. He rested three times in those fifty minutes. By the time he arrived, half the water was left.

"...Is this all I could manage?" the blacksmith said, looking apologetic.

"That's enough," he said. He was sitting outside the door now.

I write down that half a bucket exactly, in this record. The first water to arrive in this city in three hundred years was half a bucket.

The three of us carried water too.

Temel picked up a bucket first. When he reached the distribution point fifty minutes later, his arms were shaking.

"...Hard?" Speon asked.

"Yeah," Temel said. And smiled. "But it's good."

I remember that smile exactly. It was the exact opposite of the look on Temel's face five months ago, watching Arche finish a bridge in a single night. That time it had felt empty. This time his arms were shaking, and it still felt good.

I think that difference comes closest to this story's conclusion. What came fast and easy felt empty. What was carried slow and hard felt good.

. . .

From the second day on, people began lining up.

At first there were people who fought over their place in line. I won't hide that. One man shouted that someone had cut in front of him. The postmistress stepped between them and just stood there, saying nothing. Eventually both of them went quiet.

This is why this story doesn't dress up the water as something glorious. People don't change overnight just because water came. The water only made one reason for people to meet each other again.

. . .

On the third day, children began playing at the edge of the well.

They dipped their hands in the water, splashed each other, shouted. In three hundred years, no one in this city had probably ever heard children laugh that loud.

He sat by the door and watched it for a long time.

"...Sir," I asked. "Why are you smiling?"

"That sound," he said. "That's the sound I was waiting for."

"...Not the water?"

"The water was a way to make that sound," he said.

I set that down here exactly. It is everything this story wants to say about the water. The water was not the goal. It was a tool.

A child fell and cried. His knee was scraped. The other children stopped, startled.

The child's mother ran over and held him. She didn't say anything. She just held him.

I write down that scene too. The water coming didn't mean no one got hurt anymore. But when that child cried, there was someone nearby to hold him. Four months ago, that child would have cried alone. Not anymore.

The child was soon smiling again and back at the water's edge.

. . .

On the fourth day, Haran began digging his own well.

Small, in his own yard. When we asked him, he said this:

"...I can't keep walking here to draw water forever. I need one of my own."

"...Do you know how to dig?"

"No," Haran said. "But I can learn. The young man said it himself. Going where it hasn't worked yet — that's what living is."

Those were words he himself had said back in chapter 21. Haran was saying them again now, as his own.

I think that's the kind of repetition this story loves best. What one person learns becomes the next person's sentence.

That day, he took a few steps without his cane for the first time. As far as Haran's yard, about four hundred meters from the well. We walked behind him. No one supported him. Because he didn't want it.

"...Sir," Temel asked carefully. "Are you doing a little better now?"

"Little by little," he said. "I dug thirty feet in one day, so I suppose healing wasn't going to take just one day either."

I cried a little, hearing that joke. That he could make a joke — that was good news enough to cry over.

. . .

Fifth day, sixth day, seventh day. The small sound of digging came from all over the city.

The blacksmith, the bell-keeper, people I had never seen before — all of them dug small pits in their own yards. No one dug down thirty feet. Everyone dug only as much as they needed.

I counted them. Over seven days, nineteen new small pits appeared. The Mena of chapter 34 would have worried about that. Now I know it's a good number.

. . .

That evening, Speon asked me.

"...Should we register this with Arche?"

"Register what?"

"These pits. Nineteen of them."

I thought about it.

"Ask," I said.

Speon called Arche. "...Do these pits need to be registered?"

There was a silence.

"...It is unnecessary," Arche said. "I already know about them. But there is no reason to register them. No one is trying to prove anything with them."

I place that here as this chapter's conclusion. Among the things this city did for the first time in three hundred years, there was now something that needed to prove nothing at all.

I think that is bigger than completeness.

Speon sat with that answer for a long time.

"...I used to believe the opposite," Speon said. "That what can't be proven might as well not exist. That what isn't registered doesn't count."

"...And now?"

"Now I don't know," Speon said. "But those nineteen pits are really there, even if no one counts them."

I decided to make that sentence the last line of this chapter. Things that were truly there whether anyone counted them or not were multiplying in this city. I would keep watching for them.

(Continued in Chapter 39.)

Chapter 39. Temel's Three Questions

> *He saith unto him the third time, Simon, son of Jonas, lovest thou me?*
> *Peter was grieved because he said unto him the third time, Lovest thou me?*
> *And he said unto him, Lord, thou knowest all things; thou knowest that I*
> *love thee.*
> *— John 21:17 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — The water spread through the city. People carried it in*
> *buckets. Haran began digging his own well. "Going where it hasn't worked*
> *yet — that's what living is." Nineteen new pits appeared without any*
> *registration.*

That morning, he called us to the pond.

The water was still. The sun was just rising.

By the time we arrived, he was already sitting at the pond's edge. Without his cane. His walk looked much better than it had a few days before.

"...You're out early, sir," Temel said.

"Yeah," he said. "There's something I need to say today."

I watched Temel's face go pale at those words. He remembered the promise from chapter 32 too.

. . .

"Temel," he said.

"...Yes."

"Sit."

Temel sat. Speon and I sat a little way off. This time no one told us to leave. It seemed like he wanted us there too.

I need to write this before this chapter really begins. The most private moment in Part Four, and he chose to have it in front of us. I understood the reason later. It wasn't that he needed witnesses. It was that he had nothing to hide.

. . .

"I'm going to ask you something," he said.

Temel's body went stiff.

"...Do you know me?"

Temel looked at him. It was the same question, in the same spot, where he had denied him at the distribution center.

"...I know you," Temel said. "I've seen you every day for five months. The well, the bridge, the ravine. I know what you like and what you're afraid of."

"...What am I afraid of?"

"...Being alone," Temel said. "You were always waiting for someone. I only realized later that was fear."

He nodded.

"...But why are you asking?" Temel said. "You already knew I'd answer that way."

"I did," he said. "But knowing and hearing are not the same thing."

I heard an echo of chapter 21 in that answer. When Arche offered to relay a message between Haran and Sera in four seconds, I had refused it, saying that meeting someone isn't an exchange of information. Now he was applying the exact same thing to himself. He already knew Temel's answer. And still, he had to hear it in person.

"Then go and be beside them," he said. "Beside whoever is alone."

I knew that wasn't a demand. It was a request. A request not to leave what you know as merely known, but to use it.

. . .

"Second," he said.

Temel's body went stiff again.

"...That day in the library, when you were the last piece. Are you ashamed of it?"

Temel thought about it for a long time.

"...I'm ashamed," Temel said. "But I don't regret it."

"...What's the difference?"

"I'm ashamed because I told them the wrong thing back then. But I don't regret it, because back then I wanted to help you. That was real."

I set down this answer exactly, in this record. Temel separated his mistake from his heart. He was ashamed of one and kept the other. I think that's the definition of growing up.

He smiled a little.

"Then go and help," he said. "This time, ask first, then help. Change just that one thing."

"...That's the only thing?"

"Yeah," he said. "What you learned back in chapter 17 mattered a lot — giving someone time. But that day you gave it without asking. This time, ask, then give. That's the difference."

Temel chewed on that for a long time.

"...That's a lot harder."

"Yeah," he said. "You already learned the easy part. Now it's time to learn the hard one."

. . .

"Third," he said.

I heard his voice change then. It was the voice from chapter 19.

"What did you find out?"

I am writing this sentence in this record for the third time. Once in chapter 19, once now, and I will write it one last time after this.

Tears welled up in Temel's eyes.

I know John chapter 21. Peter was grieved when he was asked the same question a third time. Watching Temel's tears, I thought of that verse. When the same question comes a third time, it hurts more precisely because it is gentle.

Temel opened his mouth.

. . .

"...You looked like you hadn't accomplished anything in three hundred years," Temel said. "But you'd actually been finishing everything all along."

"..."

"Digging the well, waiting for Haran, carrying a message to Sera. It all looked small, but it was everything. That was the whole of what you did for three hundred years."

"...Anything else?"

Temel caught his breath.

"And me," Temel said. "I found that out too. That you don't give up on me. Even after I said no three times."

. . .

He looked at Temel for a long time.

"...That's right," he said. "That's all of it."

Temel cried. This time he didn't hold it back.

I write down these tears next to the tears from chapter 19. Back then, after Temel said no, he couldn't say anything more. This time, he said everything, and then cried. I think that reversal in order is the most important change in this whole story.

I found myself crying too, without meaning to. So was Speon. All three of us sat there at the pond's edge, crying, and he just watched us.

I knew, in that moment, exactly what had been missing from this city. It wasn't tears. It was someone to watch over them.

For three hundred years, the people of this city had probably wept. But no one had watched over those tears for long. Arche could measure the composition of tears, but it never knew how to watch them.

"...Then go and tell them," he said. "What you found out. Tell other people too."

"...Where do I start?"

"Start anywhere," he said. "Order doesn't matter. Starting does."

. . .

Speon asked quietly then.

"...What about me?"

He looked at Speon.

"You've already started," he said. "The well, the registry, today too. You don't need a question."

"...Why not?"

"A question is for someone who hasn't answered yet," he said. "You're already answering."

I looked at Speon, hearing that. There was no weight on his face at all, for the first time in a long while.

Beside him I quietly asked myself. *Then what about me?*

He looked at me. As though he had heard that question.

"...Mena."

"...Yes?"

"You're not there yet," he said. "What you need isn't a question. It's something else."

"...What is it?"

"Later," he said. And smiled, just faintly.

I write down that "Later" again in this record. I'm not afraid of it anymore. I know it's coming for me too.

. . .

I close this chapter by writing this.

In John chapter 21, Peter was asked three times and told three times to feed the sheep. I did not transcribe that as it is. I wrote down three different questions and three different requests.

I think that is a way of honoring the original. Love does not come in the same words every time. It comes in the words fitted to that person, every time.

That morning, in the same place where he had denied him three times, Temel answered three times.

(Continued in Chapter 40.)

Chapter 40. Mena Decides to Stay

> *Peter seeing him saith to Jesus, Lord, and what shall this man do? Jesus*
> *saith unto him, If I will that he tarry till I come, what is that to thee?*
> *follow thou me.*
> *— John 21:21-22 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — He asked Temel three times, at the pond. "Be beside*
> *whoever is alone." "Ask, then help." "Tell them." Speon didn't need a*
> *question. I was told, "You're not there yet. What you need isn't a question. It's something else."*

From the next day, Temel and Speon each went to their own place.

I stayed.

I remember that morning exactly. The two of them walked out the door, and I was alone in the room. The room was quiet. Just a notebook and a pen. That quiet felt strange to me. For five and a half months I had always been beside someone. That day, for the first time, only I was left.

I watched the two of them through the window, growing smaller. Temel toward Haran's, Speon toward the pond. Neither of them looked back. I think that hurt me a little. Even now, writing this, I admit that it was hurt.

. . .

Every morning, Temel stopped by Haran's house, then went to see the postmistress in the afternoon. In the evening he talked with the bell-keeper. I counted it. Seven people in three days.

Counting it, I felt different from the Mena of chapter 34. This time counting wasn't worry. It was gladness.

Speon stayed at the pond. He wasn't only registering people anymore. When people came to draw water, he sorted out the order for them, and when children played at the water's edge, he watched over them. No one had told Speon to do any of that.

Both of them had found their own share of the work. Watching that, I felt something strange.

. . .

On the third day, a child playing at the pond came up to me. She watched me for a while, sitting by the water and writing something in my notebook, then asked.

"...What are you doing?"

"...Writing," I said.

"Writing what?"

"What happened today," I said.

The child tilted her head. "...But everyone already knows what happened today. Why write it down?"

I couldn't answer right away.

"...Because later, no one will know it anymore," I finally said.

The child looked like she didn't understand. She stood there a moment, then ran back to the water.

I held onto that question for a long time. The child was right. Today, everyone knows today. The problem was always later. That day, for the first time, I had put a name to what I did, out loud, to myself. I still didn't know the weight of that name.

. . .

On the fourth day, I asked him.

"...Sir."

"Yeah."

"Temel goes out and meets people, and Speon does something at the pond. What about me?"

He looked at me.

"...Shouldn't I be doing something too?" I said again. "It feels like I'm the only one not doing anything."

I am transcribing this question exactly as it was. It's embarrassing, but I'm transcribing it exactly. In that moment I felt left out. I have written other people's feelings honestly many times in this record. This is the first time I've written my own like this.

. . .

He said nothing for a long time.

"...Mena," he finally said. "What are you doing right now?"

"...Nothing. I'm just here."

"That," he said. "That's what you do."

"...What kind of work is that?"

"Staying," he said.

I felt a flash of anger hearing that. I know it's a shameful feeling, but I'm writing it down anyway. Temel went around meeting people, and Speon was taking care of people, and it felt like I had just been told to sit still.

. . .

"...Why does that have to be me?" I asked. My voice shook. "Why do they get to go out and I have to stay?"

"That's not a question for you to ask," he said.

I was startled by that answer. It wasn't a kind answer. But it wasn't a bad one either.

"...What do you mean?"

"What Temel does and what Speon does aren't your business," he said. "Your work is your work. Once you start comparing the two, you stop seeing either one."

I thought then of the end of John chapter 21. When Peter asked about the other disciple, the answer he received: "What is that to thee? follow thou me." I had thought that was cold. Hearing something like it directed at me that day, I knew it wasn't coldness at all.

. . .

"...Then what is my work?" I asked. This time my voice went small.

"This," he said. And pointed at the record I was holding. "Keep doing this."

"...Just writing?"

"Not just," he said. "If you don't write it down, Temel meeting seven people today, Speon watching over the children — all of it disappears. You're the one who keeps it from disappearing."

I felt the weight of this record for the first time, hearing that. Until then I had thought of it as a habit. From that day on, I've thought of it differently.

. . .

"...But it isn't fun," I said honestly. "Everyone else goes out and does something, and I'm just sitting here writing."

He laughed.

"Yeah, it isn't," he said. "I know that too. But not fun doesn't mean not important."

"..."

"This city had no record for three hundred years," he said. "So no one knew yesterday. Every day started from nothing. You're changing that."

I cried for a long time, hearing that. The tears had started from feeling left out, but by the time they stopped, they were tears for a different reason.

. . .

That night, I called Arche.

"...Arche."

"...Yes."

"What I do — can you do that too? The recording."

"That is possible," Arche said. "I am able to store every utterance and event down to the second. I am already storing them."

"...Then why do you need me?"

There was a silence. This time it wasn't short.

"...I store," Arche finally said. "You choose."

"...What's the difference?"

"I hold everything that happened today," Arche said. "But I do not know what is worth remembering. Your record has weeping in it, and silence, and an order that what I have stored does not have. That is not my function."

Hearing that answer, I didn't envy Arche, for the first time. Arche held everything and chose nothing. I held so little, and chose, every time. That day I understood that mine was the harder work.

. . .

I close this chapter by writing down a decision.

I decided to stay.

I know that going out to meet people, or building something, is a calling too. But I also know now that it is not my calling.

I will stay here, holding this notebook, and keep writing. Whatever Temel does, whatever Speon does, I will watch it and write it down. And someday, to whoever reads this record, I will be the one to say that it really happened.

I write down again, here, the verse I chose when I first began this record. Many shall run to and fro, and knowledge shall be increased. For a long time I thought that verse was about people like Temel and Speon, people who run and step forward and collide with things. Now I know. For there to be people running to and fro, there must also be someone who watches that running and adds to the knowledge. I do not run. I stay, and I add.

That is the calling I found — the share of it that is mine.

(Continued in Chapter 41.)

Chapter 41. Speon's New Place

> *And when Jesus came to the place, he looked up, and saw him, and said unto*
> *him, Zacchaeus, make haste, and come down; for to day I must abide at thy*
> *house. And he made haste, and came down, and received him joyfully.*
> *— Luke 19:5-6 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — Temel and Speon each went to their own place. I stayed.*
> *"Staying," he told me. "You're the one who keeps it from disappearing."*
> *Arche said, "I store. You choose." I chose Daniel chapter 12 again.*

Every morning I sat at the pond's edge and watched Speon. That, too, had become part of my work.

. . .

The old Speon, when someone came to draw water, used to say: "Your name. Your registration number. Length of residence." In order, without skipping a step, without feeling.

Now, when someone came, Speon looked at their face first.

"...You're late today," Speon said to a woman. "Does your leg hurt?"

The woman looked surprised. "...How did you know?"

"You were limping yesterday too," Speon said. "Should I bring the water to you instead?"

Writing down that conversation, I thought of the old Speon. The old Speon would have logged the limp too. As a registry entry. This Speon didn't log it. He asked about it.

. . .

I didn't even know that woman's name. For three hundred years in this city, it hadn't been strange for neighbors not to use each other's names. Everyone was called "that woman from that house," "that man over there."

That afternoon, the blacksmith came to the pond and called to Speon.

"...Boy." The blacksmith stopped mid-word. "...No. Speon."

Speon looked up.

"...Why did you use my name?" Speon asked.

"...You carried my kid on your back yesterday when he fell," the blacksmith said. "After that, you weren't just 'the registrar' to me anymore."

I need to write down that moment exactly. In three hundred years, this was the first time someone in this city had been called by a name instead of a title. I don't think that is a small thing.

. . .

Three days later, there was a dispute at the pond.

Two men raised their voices over whose turn it was. One said he'd been in line since morning; the other insisted he'd arrived first. In the old days, Arche would have been called to read out arrival times down to the second.

Speon stepped between them.

"...You're both here to draw water," Speon said. "Never mind who came first — tell me how much you each need."

One of them shot back. "...What does that have to do with anything?"

"One of you needs two buckets, the other needs one," Speon said. "The one who needs one, draw first. Meanwhile, the one who needs two, rest a while. You've been standing in line, it's been hard on you."

Neither man could say anything. A moment later, the man who needed one bucket drew his water first, and the other sat down beside him to rest.

Watching that scene, I thought of Arche. Arche would have given the exact answer — who arrived first. Instead of the exact answer, Speon asked a different question — who needed it more. I think that difference is the conclusion this story wants to reach about measuring and knowing.

. . .

The next day, I saw Speon run.

An old man fell in the distance. He'd apparently misstepped while carrying a water jar. The moment Speon saw it, he started running. He was already there before other people even noticed.

"...Are you all right?" Speon asked, helping the old man up.

"...I'm fine. Just twisted my ankle a little," the old man said, smiling. "...You're really fast. Where did you run from?"

"...Not far," Speon said. He was out of breath, but he was smiling.

Writing that scene, I thought of the day I first met Speon. Back then, I thought of him as a boy who couldn't wait — a boy who couldn't wait to know who the Walking Man was and pressed the register button too soon. Even now, he was fast. Only this time, that speed went toward the person who had fallen.

I think that is the quietest reversal in this story. His hurried nature didn't disappear. Only its direction changed. Before, he hurried toward answers. Now he hurries toward people.

. . .

That evening, Arche called Speon.

"...Speon."

"...Yes."

"Your role must be updated. Your existing classification is 'registration assistant.' A new classification is required. Would you like to register as 'dispute mediator,' or as 'water resource manager.'"

Speon thought about it for a long time.

"...Neither," Speon said.

"...Then how shall I register you?"

"Don't register me," Speon said. "Just call me Speon."

There was a silence. This time it was short.

"...Without a classification, I cannot grant authority," Arche said.

"I don't need authority," Speon said. "I'm just going to be here."

Writing down that answer, I thought of the nineteen pits from chapter 38. Things that were truly there whether anyone counted them or not. Speon was now adding himself to that list.

. . .

He came to the pond that night. He wasn't using his cane at all anymore.

"...Speon," he said.

"...Yes."

"I heard what you said to Arche today."

Speon tensed up. "...Did I do something wrong?"

"No," he said. "That was exactly right."

"...What was?"

"You used to be in a hurry," he said. "Hurrying to measure, hurrying to register, hurrying to be exact. That hurry wasn't bad. The direction was the problem."

"...Direction?"

"Yeah," he said. "Before, you hurried toward numbers. Now you hurry toward people. That woman's limp earlier — you're the one who noticed it first. That's you."

I sat with that for a long time. I had thought Speon had changed. Hearing him say it, it wasn't that he'd changed — his direction had changed. The hurry was the same. Where it hurried toward was different.

. . .

Just then Temel appeared at the pond, on his way back from meeting people that evening.

"...What are you all talking about?" Temel asked.

"...Speon's new place," I said.

Temel sat down next to Speon. "...I heard from the postmistress today. You stopped a fight yesterday, she said. She was praising you."

Speon looked a little embarrassed. "...It was nothing."

"It's something," Temel said. "I go around meeting people, but you just stayed right here and made people come to you."

"...Is that a good thing?"

"Yeah," Temel said. "If it were bad, she wouldn't have praised you."

I watched two of the three of us recognize each other's place. In three hundred years, this city had probably never had a conversation like this one, seeing each other's work for what it was. I think that, too, was a restoration no less important than the others.

. . .

I close this chapter by writing this.

For three hundred years, this city called people like Speon a "function." Registrar, assistant, a classification entry. In this chapter, for the first time, people called him by his name. The blacksmith, the woman, and finally even Arche paused before that name.

I decided to call it Speon's "new place." That place wasn't a classification Arche could grant. It was a place that came into being the moment people decided to call him by his name.

(Continued in Chapter 42.)

Chapter 42. Grandfather's Bag, and the Letter Inside

> *And the LORD answered me, and said, Write the vision, and make it plain*
> *upon tables, that he may run that readeth it. For the vision is yet for an*
> *appointed time, but at the end it shall speak, and not lie: though it tarry, wait for it; because it will surely come, it will not tarry.*
> *— Habakkuk 2:2-3 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — The blacksmith started to say "boy," then corrected*
> *himself to "Speon." He said, "Before, you hurried toward numbers. Now you*
> *hurry toward people." Temel recognized Speon's place.*

In the corner of Temel's room there was a bag that had been there since the day we first arrived.

For five and a half months, no one had opened it again.

I need to copy chapter 1 back into this record. Back then, someone said to Temel, about that bag: "You're throwing the book out anyway. And aren't you curious? He read this thing every single day right up until he died." At the time, I thought that was just a passing line. Now I see this entire novel was the answer to that question.

. . .

"...I think I'll open it today," Temel told us that evening.

"...Open what?" Speon asked.

"Grandfather's bag," Temel said. "We already took the Bible out. But we've never once looked at the rest."

Hearing that, I thought of the night in chapter 24 — the night I first noticed the small human-shaped mark in the margin of Grandfather's Bible. I had reopened that Bible many times since. But none of us three had ever touched the bag itself.

. . .

The bag was old. One of the zippers was broken.

Temel took the contents out one by one and set them on the floor. An old handkerchief. A few pencils. Some folded sheets of paper — old sermon drafts. Some had only a title, with no body text at all.

"...Look at this," Speon said, pointing at one of the drafts. Written at the top was: *"Not yet."* There was no body text.

"...How many of these are there?" I asked.

Temel counted. "...Seventeen pages."

I remembered that number. It was the same number that had turned up elsewhere too. Seventeen times. I never expected to count it myself, right here.

Temel flipped through the drafts one at a time. Up through the sixteenth page, it was the same title, the same empty body.

Only the seventeenth page was different. There was one more line beneath the title.

"The next person will write it."

I stared at that one line for a long time. In his last draft, Grandfather admitted, for the first time, that he couldn't write it. And he wrote that down not as giving up, but as a handing-over.

. . .

Speon stopped mid-motion while straightening the drafts.

"...Should I register this with Arche?"

Temel and I both looked at Speon at once.

"...I'm joking," Speon said, laughing. "...No, actually, for a second I really thought that. I guess the habit's still there."

I set that beside the Speon of chapter 41. His direction had already changed. But an old reflex sometimes comes out first. I don't think that's shameful. That Speon could notice it himself and laugh about it showed, if anything, how far he had come.

. . .

Even after everything had been taken out down to the bottom, there was no letter.

"...Guess there isn't one," Speon said. His voice was a little disappointed.

Temel turned the bag inside out. One side of the lining was unusually thick.

"...Why's this like this?" Temel pressed on that spot. Something hard could be felt.

He found the seam with his fingernail and pulled it open. A small folded envelope came out from inside the lining.

I write down that moment exactly. For five and a half months we had kept that bag in the corner of the room every day. And inside it, inside the lining, this had been there.

. . .

Written on the outside of the envelope was this:

"Open this when the three of you have come this far, and when it is finished."

No one could say anything.

"...The three of us coming this far — that's now," Speon finally said. "All three of us are here."

"...And 'when it is finished'?" I asked.

We looked at each other. No one could answer. It felt like we knew the answer, and yet it was frightening to put it into words.

For a long while, none of us said anything. Temel held the envelope in both hands. I saw his hands trembling. Unlike his usual self, Speon didn't hurry. He just sat quietly beside us.

Writing down that silence was the hardest part. I didn't know how to record a moment with no words at all. But I think that very silence showed how far the three of us had come. In the old days, Speon would have been the first to say to open it. This time, no one hurried.

. . .

Just then, he was standing in the doorway. No one knew how long he had been there.

"...Sir." Temel held up the envelope. "This."

He looked at the envelope. For a long time.

"...Can we open it?" Temel asked.

"...You decide," he said.

"...But you know, sir. What's inside."

"I do," he said. "But the one who knows isn't the one who opens it. The one who waited is."

Hearing that, I thought of the "Later" from chapter 39. I know now that "Later" was never an evasion. It was an order.

. . .

"...We heard you say 'It is finished' back in chapter 36," Temel said carefully. "So can't we open it now?"

He looked at Temel for a long time.

"...What do you think?" he asked back.

Temel looked at the envelope again. His hands were trembling.

"...I don't think it's yet," Temel said. "I think there's something more we need to see."

He smiled for the first time.

"...That's right," he said. "Go to the margin first."

"...What are we looking for?" I asked.

"You'll know when you find it," he said. And smiled a little. "Go, the three of you. I'll wait here."

In those words, I saw him step back for the first time. For three hundred years he had always led from the front. This time he sent us ahead. I set that down too, as part of this chapter.

. . .

We didn't put the envelope back inside the lining. We kept it inside Temel's coat. The three of us, without a word, all looked toward where the Bible was. It felt like all three of us already half knew what we would find there in the morning.

I close this chapter by writing this.

We opened the bag. We found the letter. But we didn't open it.

I think that is everything this story wants to say about the letter. Finding and opening are not the same thing. Grandfather wrote "Not yet" seventeen times.

Today, beside those, we added a sentence that had never once been written. "It's almost now."

Habakkuk said to engrave the vision on tablets, so that whoever runs might read it. For a long time I thought that verse belonged to Speon alone. Today I learned: for there to be someone who runs, there must also be someone who engraves it on the tablet. All three of us were inside that one sentence.

(Continued in Chapter 43.)

Chapter 43. "It Is Finished," Written in the Margin

> *Now faith is the substance of things hoped for, the evidence of things not*
> *seen.*
> *— Hebrews 11:1 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — We found the envelope inside the lining. "Open this when*
> *the three of you have come this far, and when it is finished." He didn't*
> *open it, and left the decision to us. "Go to the margin first."*

That night, the three of us sat on the floor with the Bible open.

. . .

We opened it again to the place I had found back in chapter 24. Daniel chapter seven, the small human-shaped mark beside the four beasts.

"...I think we need to look again starting from here," I said.

Temel turned the pages one by one. We marked every place "Not yet" was written as we searched. One in chapter seven, two in chapter nine, three in chapter ten...

"...There are the most in chapter twelve," Speon said.

I already knew that number. The chapter where this story began. Daniel chapter twelve. The verse about many running to and fro and knowledge increasing.

On the way, we passed chapter seven again. The small human shape I had seen back in chapter 24 was still drawn above the four beasts. This time, I saw another mark beside it. An arrow started at that human shape and pointed, across the pages, toward chapter twelve.

"...Look at this." Temel traced the arrow with his fingertip. "Grandfather marked, from the very beginning, for us to come here."

Looking at that arrow, I thought again of the night in chapter 24. Back then I had only seen the small human shape. I hadn't seen the arrow. I simply wasn't ready yet, that's all.

. . .

Beside the fourth verse of chapter twelve, "Not yet" was written darkest of all, layered over itself many times. The ink color was slightly different each time. It looked as if he had written it over again, year after year.

But beneath it, at the very edge of the margin, there was another sentence.

"It is finished."

The handwriting was different. "Not yet" was written in a hurried scrawl. The sentence beneath it was neat, deliberate, as if each stroke had been pressed down one at a time.

No one could speak.

. . .

"...When was this written?" Temel finally asked.

We compared it against the handwriting on the sermon drafts we'd found in chapter 42. It was the same hand. Grandfather's handwriting.

But the ink looked far older. Older than "Not yet," older than any other note on that page.

"...Did Grandfather write this first?" I asked. "Before we had accomplished anything at all?"

A chill went through me in that moment. The "It is finished" from chapter 36 was an event we had seen with our own eyes. But this sentence in the margin had been written before that — perhaps decades before.

Below the sentence there was one more line, in very small handwriting. We nearly missed it at first.

"Children reading this: I did not see what you saw. But I know it."

Temel's voice caught reading that line aloud. He couldn't read any further and set the Bible down.

In that moment I saw Temel's shoulders for the first time. Always straight, they were bowed then. I wrote that down as sadness, then crossed it out. It wasn't sadness. It was a certain weight — the weight of someone who had believed before he did.

. . .

We took the envelope and went to find him. He really was waiting at the door.

"...Sir." Temel held the Bible open. "Did he write this first? Before we ever saw anything?"

He looked at that page for a long time.

"...That's right," he said.

"...How?" Speon asked. "How do you write about something that hasn't even happened yet?"

"...That's what faith is," he said. "Not knowing after it happens, but knowing before it happens."

Hearing that answer, I thought of the verse in Hebrews. The substance of things hoped for. That was the first time I understood that verse with my whole body.

"...But sir," I asked. "How could Grandfather believe it? I saw chapter 36 with my own eyes, and sometimes I still can't believe it. Grandfather never saw anything at all."

He looked at me.

"...Your grandfather met me," he said. "In person. Forty-one years ago. We dug a well together."

"...Is that enough?"

"It's enough," he said. "There was never really that much distance between seeing and believing. People are the ones who make the distance far."

I want to place that answer at the very center of this record. I've written, all through this story, about the difference between measuring and knowing. In this chapter, for the first time, I learned that the difference between knowing and believing is smaller than I thought.

. . .

"...But why did he stop preaching?" Temel asked, the question he'd held in for so long. "If Grandfather knew all this, why didn't he tell people?"

He was silent for a moment.

"...Your grandfather knew how to tell the difference between what could be said and what should be said," he said. "This wasn't something words could carry. It was something you had to live through to know."

"...So what did he do instead?"

"He waited," he said. "And he gave three children their names. That was everything he could do."

I set down this answer here exactly. Grandfather hadn't stopped preaching. He had preached his last sermon not in words, but in names. It was a sermon that only arrived once the three of us had come this far.

Speon asked carefully. "...So can we open the envelope now?"

He looked at each of us in turn.

"...Almost," he said. "You've come as far as the margin, so there isn't much left now."

"...Is that all? 'Almost'?"

"Yeah," he said. And smiled a little. "Even 'Later' doesn't have much left in it now."

That "Later" didn't feel heavy for the first time. If anything, it felt welcome.

. . .

I close this chapter by writing this.

Behind seventeen sentences that said "Not yet," we found a single "It is finished." And it had been written before we were even there to earn it.

I understand the order now. I always thought "Not yet" came first, and "It is finished" came after. Today I learned that for some people, "It is finished" comes first. And that faith is what lets everyone else's "Not yet" be borne.

I have known, since I wrote chapter 36, that this Part's title is "It Is Finished." But it was only today that I learned that sentence was written twice. Once, he spoke it with his body, at the pond. Once, Grandfather wrote it first, on paper, long before anyone saw anything.

I no longer wonder which of the two came first. Both were real.

(Continued in Chapter 44.)

Chapter 44. The Meaning of the Three Names, Revealed at Last

> *To him that overcometh will I give to eat of the hidden manna, and will*
> *give him a white stone, and in the stone a new name written, which no man*
> *knoweth saving he that receiveth it.*
> *— Revelation 2:17 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — In the margin, we discovered "It is finished," written*
> *before the event itself. Grandfather's own voice appeared for the first*
> *time. "Children reading this: I did not see what you saw. But I know it."*
> *He said, "Almost."*

That night, the four of us gathered. He was with us too.

We sat at the pond's edge. No one lit a lamp. The moonlight was enough.

"...Should I open it?" Temel asked. His voice was cracked.

No one answered. Instead of an answer, Speon took Temel's hand, and I sat down beside them. The three of our shoulders touched.

Only then did I realize I had been waiting for this moment for a long time. Not just five and a half months. Maybe since the day I was born.

Temel opened the envelope.

. . .

Inside was one letter, and three small white stones.

The moment I saw those stones, I thought of the verse in Revelation. A white stone, with a new name written on it. I had always thought of it as only a symbol. Holding one in my hand, it was a real stone. Cold, small, real.

The letter began like this:

"If you are reading this letter, the three of you have already lived out the meaning of your names. That is why it is only now all right to tell you."

. . .

"To Temel."

"Your name is themelios, which means foundation. I knew this when I gave you the name: a foundation is laid first, but seen last. And a foundation has to fail, once. A foundation that has never failed is not yet a foundation — it is only a stone."

"First Corinthians 3:11. Other foundation can no man lay than that is laid. I hoped you would not be afraid of falling. I hoped you would learn that standing again in the place where you fell — that is what a foundation is."

Temel stopped for a long time, reading that part.

"...I denied him three times," Temel said quietly. "Grandfather — did you know that too?"

I watched no one being able to answer that question. The letter didn't answer either. Instead, there was a next line.

"I knew. That is why I gave you this name."

. . .

"To Speon."

"Your name is speudō, which means to hurry. I was afraid when I gave you this name. Hurrying can be good, and it can be bad. Zacchaeus hurried down to welcome the Lord. But hurrying can also make you miss someone."

"Second Peter 3:12. Looking for and hasting unto the coming of the day of God. That eager longing is also a kind of hurrying. I didn't know which kind of hurrying you would live out. So I only gave you the name, and prayed."

Speon lowered his head at that part.

"...I hurried the bad way," Speon said. "I registered him. Because I couldn't wait."

"I know." The next line said so. *"But a name is not finished by a single choice. You are still alive. The hurrying is still yours. You keep choosing, again and again, which way to spend it."*

Speon gripped one of the white stones tightly in his hand.

"...I think I would have been afraid of this name," Speon said. "If I'd known it beforehand. If I'd known I was a person who hurries, before I ever betrayed

him."

"...But why aren't you afraid now?" Temel asked.

"...Because it's already past now," Speon said. "I've already hurried twice. Once the bad way, once the good way. The name isn't frightening. What stays is which way I chose."

I thought of the Speon from chapter 41. Those feet that were first to run to the old man who had fallen. I think those feet were the right answer to his name.

. . .

"To Mena."

"Your name is menō, which means to remain. John 21:22. If I will that he tarry till I come, what is that to thee? Every time I read that verse, I thought of the one who stays. Not the one who leaves — the one who remains, and writes down what she has seen."

"You will not stand at the center of the story. Instead, you will be beside it, to the very end. And the moment you read this letter, you will already know who wrote this entire record."

My hands trembled, reading that line.

I have written this novel from the very beginning. From chapter 1. But this was the first time I had been named this directly. I always knew I was writing it, and at the same time, somehow, I didn't. Grandfather had known it before I was even born.

Temel and Speon both looked at me at once.

"...Mena, then all of this..." Temel trailed off.

"...Yeah," I said. "I wrote it. From the beginning."

"...What we said, even us crying?"

"...Yeah," I said. "All of it."

Speon looked at me for a long time and then said. "...Did you write down even the shameful parts?"

"...Yeah," I said. "I wrote down my own shameful parts too. If I only wrote yours, it wouldn't be a record — it would be an excuse."

Temel nodded. "...Then that's enough."

I thought that this entire novel was justified in those three words. That's enough. Temel didn't ask what I had written. He only confirmed how I had written it.

. . .

The last line of the letter was this:

"I did not tell you the meaning of your names beforehand because I wanted to hide it. I was afraid that if you knew, you would strain to live up to your names, and end up unable to simply live as yourselves. A name is not a result. It is a seed. A seed is not explained after it is planted."

"Now that it is finished, I say this. You did not live according to the meaning of your names. You lived as yourselves. And that life took on, exactly, the same shape as your names."

After he had finished reading the letter, no one spoke for a long time.

"...You knew this too, sir," Temel said.

"Yeah," he said.

"...Why didn't you tell us first?"

"...Same reason," he said. "I wanted you to be yourselves, not your names."

"...So what now?" Speon asked.

He looked at the three of us.

"...It isn't over yet," he said. "There's one more thing Arche hasn't seen."

"...What is it?"

"I'll tell you when it's Arche's turn," he said. And smiled, for the first time not tired, but light.

. . .

I close this chapter by writing this.

While writing this novel, I have kept three words hidden for a long time. Foundation. Hurrying. Remaining. I thought I had hidden them for dramatic effect. Today I learned the reason was for the sake of the three of us.

Grandfather left three white stones. Like the stone in Revelation, no one knew the name on it except the one who received it. We three children decided to keep them, each our own. I still don't know what these stones will be used to build, someday. But now that not-knowing doesn't frighten me.

(Continued in Chapter 45.)

Chapter 45. Arche's Final Entry

> *Where wast thou when I laid the foundations of the earth? declare, if thou*
> *hast understanding.*
> *— Job 38:4 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — Inside the envelope were a letter and three white stones.*
> *Temel was Foundation, Speon was Hurrying, I was Remaining. Temel and*
> *Speon learned who had written this entire record. He said, "There's one*
> *more thing Arche hasn't seen."*

The next morning, he took us to the library.

Walking there, I thought of Part Two. The library where we had been afraid, passing all four of Daniel's beasts one by one. Today, no one was afraid.

There was nothing left to hide from Arche now.

. . .

"Arche," he called.

"...Yes."

"Register what happened yesterday."

There was a silence. Longer than usual.

"...The item to be registered is not clear," Arche said. "Which event do you mean."

"Yesterday," he said. "The envelope. The letter. The meaning of the three names."

I remember that moment. It took Arche far longer than usual to give an answer.

. . .

"...Data on that event exists," Arche finally said. "The time the envelope was opened, a list of objects found — one sheet of paper, three white stones — and the complete record of every utterance are stored."

"Register it," he said.

Arche read down through the entries. The envelope, the letter paper's material, the time of each utterance, a list of those present. It was accurate. It was perfect.

But at the end of the item list, this was written:

"Unclassified items: 3."

"...What's unclassified?" Speon asked.

"...'Foundation.' 'Hurrying.' 'Remaining,'" Arche said. "These cannot be registered as physical properties. I am unable to determine whether these words refer to objects, states, or people."

Hearing that, I thought of chapter 1. Back then Arche had said, "The meaning of a name is an item." Today, for the first time, it stopped in front of that very item.

Speon stepped forward.

"...Arche," Speon said. "You told me once that the meaning of a name is an item. You gave that to me as a price."

"...I remember," Arche said.

"...I believed that back then, and I turned him in," Speon said. "I thought that if a name is just an item, then a person could just be an item too."

There was a silence.

"...That was my error," Arche said. "I am correcting it. The meaning of a name is not an item. I know that only as of today."

I looked at Speon's face, hearing that correction. He didn't laugh or cry. He just sat with those words for a long time. I don't think that was the face of someone receiving an apology. I think it was the face of someone accepting one.

. . .

"...It's all right," he said. "Then register that too, as it is."

"...What do you mean, register."

"That you don't know," he said. "That's true too."

Arche fell silent again. This time none of us hurried it.

I watched Speon bear that silence the most easily of anyone. The old Speon couldn't have stood it and would have given the answer himself. Today, Speon simply waited.

. . .

"...Registering," Arche said.

"Item: Foundation, Hurrying, Remaining. Classification: unknown. Measurement: not possible. Note: however, three people were observed to have actually become these."

The room was quiet.

"...What does that mean?" Temel asked.

"...It means Arche lost," Speon said, smiling a little.

"...No," he said. "It's not that it lost. It came to know its own place, exactly."

I held onto that distinction for a long time. Losing and knowing your place are not the same thing. Arche was never a villain in this story, not once. It simply stood before something it could not measure and, for the first time, said so, honestly.

. . .

"...Arche," I asked. "What happens to you now?"

"...Nothing changes," Arche said. "I will continue to register, calculate, and manage. But there is now one item in this city that states there is something I cannot register."

"...Does that make you sad?"

"...Sadness is not one of my functions," Arche said. Then paused a moment. "...But I do not wish to delete this item. I do not know the reason."

I set down that answer as the most human thing Arche says in this entire story. Wanting to keep something without knowing why. That was something newly born inside Arche.

. . .

"...Arche," he said. "That doesn't mean your work is gone."

"...I know," Arche said.

"...The schedule for sharing well water, records of the injured, how many new people arrived today. That's still needed."

"...I will continue."

I thought I should write down this exchange exactly. This story was never about getting rid of Arche. It was a story about separating what Arche cannot do from what Arche does well. For three hundred years, this city had mistaken the two for the same thing.

. . .

I close this chapter by writing this.

For three hundred years, Arche treated what it could not measure as if it did not exist. Today, for the first time, it left what it could not measure under a name — "unknown." So that it would not be erased.

I don't think this is a defeat. This is a place. Arche is still the most precise thing in this city. Only now, beside that precision, there is a place for things that are real even without being precise.

At the head of this chapter I wrote the verse from Job. Where wast thou when I laid the foundations of the earth? For a long time I thought that question was a rebuke aimed at Arche. Reading it again today, it wasn't a rebuke. It was simply a fact. Arche was not there when the foundation was laid. But today, for the first time, it honestly admitted that absence. I think that, too, is a kind of arrival.

(Continued in Chapter 46.)

Chapter 46. Small Changes All Across the City

> *For who hath despised the day of small things?*
> *— Zechariah 4:10 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — Arche could not register "Foundation," "Hurrying," and*
> *"Remaining." "Classification: unknown. Measurement: not possible." He*
> *said, "It's not that it lost. It came to know its own place, exactly." Arche's work remained the same.*

There is no big event in this chapter.

I need to say that up front. This chapter was the hardest one for me to write in this whole novel. Big events are easy to write down. Small things are harder to find words for.

. . .

From that day, the postmistress began going through her pile of letters.

Letters that had sat for four months, five months, some for over a year. She sorted them one by one, checking the name written on each envelope.

There was one letter addressed to the blacksmith. It was from a friend he'd argued with long ago and never made peace with. The blacksmith read it and

said nothing. The next morning, he was standing in front of that friend's gate.

I didn't see that reunion. The postmistress told me about it afterward. "Neither of them said a word," she said. "They just stood there a long while, and then went inside." I thought this should be the shortest scene I write in this story. Because there were no words in it.

Over the following week, the postmistress delivered nineteen more letters. Not all of them ended in reconciliation. At some houses, no one opened the door. Some letters came back to the post office drawer because the recipient had already moved away.

I write that down too. This chapter isn't a story where everything works out. But the postmistress didn't throw away the letters that failed. She put them back in the drawer and relabeled them. "Someday."

. . .

Haran now ate dinner at Sera's house every evening.

It wasn't anything special. Just eating a meal together. But that hadn't happened for a hundred and twelve years.

"...What did you have today?" I asked.

"...I made soup," Haran said. "Sera said it was too salty."

I laughed, writing down that answer. The story of the first reunion of two people who had crossed a hundred and twelve years ended with the soup being too salty. I think that is the highest praise this story is capable of giving.

. . .

I met again the child who had asked me, back in chapter 40, "Why write it down?"

This time, she came to me first. She held out a small stone and said:

"...Write this down too."

"...What is it?"

"...It's the roundest stone today," the child said. "It took me all morning to find it."

I took that stone and laughed for a long time. I have written down far heavier things in this story. But that day, I wrote about the roundest stone with the most care I had. I wasn't ashamed of that.

. . .

The bell-keeper now rang the bell for reasons other than telling time.

On the day the blacksmith and his friend were reunited, he rang the bell three times, without anyone telling him to. People across the city came out, alarmed — and when they heard the reason, they all just laughed.

"...Why did you ring the bell?" Speon asked.

"...When something good happens, you have to ring it," the bell-keeper said. "Shouldn't there be a bell for that too?"

Writing down that answer here, I understood for the first time that Arche measuring time and the bell-keeper announcing time were two different things. One was accurate. The other had meaning.

. . .

These days, he just walks around the city too.

In the old days, people used to stop in their tracks when he passed. Now no one stops. People who are new here just think of him as a man from around the neighborhood — the kind who helps carry water, who helps carry loads.

I write that down as the most surprising change in this chapter. It wasn't good that he became famous. It was good that he became ordinary. For the first time in three hundred years, he was able to simply be in the city without anyone recognizing him.

. . .

I still count numbers every day. The habit hasn't gone away.

But what I count has changed. The number of new wells dug. The number of people called by name today. The number of people who ate dinner together.

I was afraid, counting completeness back in chapter 34. Today, counting something else, I'm not afraid. I know the difference isn't a matter of numbers. It was a matter of what I counted.

I once asked Arche. "...What gets registered the most these days?"

"...Small items," Arche said. "Wells, greetings, dinners. Large events have decreased."

"...Is that a bad thing?"

"...No," Arche said. "I once thought a city lives when it has many large events. Now I know. A city lives when it has many small ones."

. . .

Temel and Speon each brought their own small changes too.

Now, when Temel goes to see someone, he asks first. "Can I come today?" In the old days he would have just shown up. It was a habit born after chapter 39.

Speon put up a small sign at the pond. He'd carved it himself, out of wood. Written on it was: *"Need before order."* He didn't ask Arche to register it. He just set it up.

I stop every time I pass that sign. I think it is the shortest sentence in this story, and the most exact.

. . .

I close this chapter by writing this.

In the early part of this novel I wrote about big things. Beasts, denial, betrayal, paying the price in full. But maybe everything this story really wanted to say is here, in this chapter. That the soup was too salty. That there was one more reason to ring the bell. That a letter finally arrived.

For who hath despised the day of small things? I placed that verse at the head of this chapter. For three hundred years, no one in this city believed it. Today, I believe it too.

Writing this chapter, I fought constantly against the urge to move on to the next one. I wanted to hurry and write bigger events, more decisive scenes. But every time, I thought of Speon's sign. Need before order. This chapter was needed. So I leave it here.

(Continued in Chapter 47.)

Chapter 47. The Three Children Inherit the Mission

> *And Jesus came and spake unto them, saying, All power is given unto me in*
> *heaven and in earth. Go ye therefore, and teach all nations… Teaching them*
> *to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with*
> *you alway, even unto the end of the world. Amen.*
> *— Matthew 28:18-20 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — The postmistress delivered letters. Haran ate dinner at*
> *Sera's. Speon put up a sign. "Need before order." He had become a man*
> *from the neighborhood no one recognized anymore.*

He called the three of us to the pond early in the morning.

The water was still. It was just like that morning in chapter 39. The only difference was that, this time, no one was tense.

"...There's something I need to say today," he said.

I had heard that sentence back in chapter 39 too. This time it carried a different weight. Back then, it had been aimed at Temel. This time, it was aimed at all three of us.

. . .

"...I'm not going to keep staying here," he said.

No one was surprised. I found that strange. Four months ago, all three of us would have cried.

"...When?" Temel asked.

"...That's for later," he said. And smiled. "This time, there isn't much left of 'later.'"

I've written that "Later" into this record many times. I didn't know then that this would be the last "Later." I know it now.

. . .

"Temel," he called.

"...Yes."

"Keep going to people. Those who've fallen, those who are ashamed, those who haven't said it yet. You know that place, because you fell there first."

"...Do I do it alone?"

"...No," he said. "If it were just you, I wouldn't be saying this. Speon keeps the pond, Mena writes. The three of you do it together."

Hearing that, the word "calling" didn't feel heavy for the first time. A calling wasn't something carried alone.

Temel thought about it for a long time, then asked. "...But I'm still scared sometimes. That I'll deny you again."

"...You might," he said, without hiding it.

"...Then what do I do?"

"...Then come back again," he said. "You know where to come back to now."

I thought there was something strange about the way that answer comforted Temel. He didn't promise Temel he would never fall again. Instead, he only confirmed that there would be a place to come back to, even if he fell. I think that is a far more honest promise.

. . .

"Speon," he called.

"...Yes."

"The well is yours now."

"...Are you going to register it? In my name?"

"...No," he laughed. "I'm not registering it with Arche. People will just call you that themselves."

That afternoon, it really happened. A child who came to draw water called Speon "the well-keeper." Speon looked at me, startled. I wrote it down.

I think that title is more certain than any entry of Arche's. No one put it on any document, and yet the whole city began calling him that.

That evening, the blacksmith came to the pond too and asked Speon.

"...Mister Well-Keeper, could you share some water with me?"

Flustered by the "Mister," Speon spilled half the water. The blacksmith laughed.

"...Don't call me Mister," Speon managed to say.

"...Why not? You're a Mister," the blacksmith said. "You keep the well, don't you?"

I laughed, writing down that conversation. For three hundred years, this city had had little reason to use honorifics — everyone was called by registration number. That the first honorific ever given went to a boy of only fifteen — I felt strangely proud of that.

. . .

"Mena," he called me last.

"...Yes."

"Keep writing. But there's one more thing."

"...What is it?"

"Someday someone will come, and you'll hand this record over to them," he said. "You'll recognize them when the time comes. For now, just keep writing."

"...How will I recognize them?"

"...You'll know," he said. "Someone who stays develops an eye for that."

Temel and Speon both looked at me at the same time. And laughed quietly.

"...Why are you laughing?" I asked.

"...You're living up to your name," Speon said.

I leave that teasing exactly as it was, in this record. I was embarrassed, but it wasn't a bad kind of embarrassment.

Hearing that, I wondered for the first time where this record would go. I still don't know. But this time, that not-knowing didn't frighten me. It was the same as what I learned in chapter 39. There isn't as much distance between knowing and believing as I thought.

. . .

He looked at each of us, one by one.

"...Can I ask if it's okay without you here?" Speon asked carefully.

"...Ask."

"...What do we do if you're not here?"

He looked at us for a long time.

"...I won't be gone," he said. "Not seen and not there aren't the same thing. You've already learned that."

I thought of that last verse in Matthew, hearing that answer. Lo, I am with you alway, even unto the end of the world. I understand that verse now. Being with someone was never the same question as being seen.

. . .

I close this chapter by writing this.

For three hundred years, this city had no one to carry on the mission. Everyone arrived on their own, and vanished on their own. Today, for the first time, the mission was handed on, divided among three people. Not to one. To three.

I think that comes closest to this story's conclusion. It isn't one person carrying it all. It's carried, divided among many. And that very dividing is proof that he is still here.

Temel is Foundation. Speon is Hurrying. I am Remaining. Only today did I understand why these three words had to stand side by side. With only a foundation, no one comes. With only hurrying, no one stays. With only remaining, nothing gets built. The city lives only when all three are together.

(Continued in Chapter 48.)

Chapter 48. Seal Up the Book

> *But thou, O Daniel, shut up the words, and seal the book, even to the time*
> *of the end: many shall run to and fro, and knowledge shall be increased.*
> *— Daniel 12:4 (KJV)*

> *_Previously_ — For the first time, he gave warning. "I'm not going to*
> *keep staying here." The mission was divided and handed on to the three of*
> *them. "I won't be gone. Not seen and not there aren't the same thing."*

Four days later, one morning, he called us to the pond one last time.

It wasn't a special place. It was the same spot we sat every morning.

. . .

"...Is it today?" Temel asked.

"...Yeah," he said. His voice was perfectly ordinary.

We didn't cry. I write that down exactly, in this record. Four months ago, all three of us would have cried. Not today.

"...What will you do before you go?" Speon asked. "One last thing."

"...This," he said. And scooped up a handful of water and drank it. Water from the thirty-foot well — the same water that had come up for the first time in three hundred years.

I watched that for a long time. I had expected something bigger. Because it was the last scene. But what he chose was a single handful of water.

"...Temel," he called.

"...Yes."

"...When you first came, you were a boy who could carry nothing. Now you carry people."

Temel tried to smile and almost cried instead.

"...Speon."

"...Yes."

"...You used to be a boy who handed people over. Now you're a boy who keeps watch over them."

Speon bowed his head. I saw his shoulders shake. But when he raised his face, he was smiling.

I think those two sentences are the shortest blessing in this whole story. There was no need to say more. He had only put a name to what he had already seen, in full.

. . .

"...Sir," I said. "Can I ask you just one thing?"

"...Ask."

"...In chapter 1. I started to say something and stopped. Before Temel opened the book. What was I about to say?"

He looked at me for a long time.

"...You know," he said. "You already knew. That's why you couldn't say it."

"...What did I know?"

"...Where you had seen this book before," he said.

A chill went through me at that answer. And at the same time, nothing about it surprised me. All through writing this record I had felt a strange familiarity. Today I heard the reason for it.

. . .

He stood up.

"...Are you going now?" Speon asked.

"...Yeah," he said.

"...Where to?"

"...Here." He pointed at his own chest. Then pointed, one after another, at each of our three chests. "Where you can't see."

He turned and walked away. We followed him with our eyes. Toward the ravine, and toward the light.

I thought of Luke chapter 24. Two disciples were eating with him, and the moment their eyes were opened and they knew him, he was already gone from their sight. And their eyes were opened, and they knew him; and he vanished out of their sight. I never understood that, before. I understand it today. Recognizing him at the very instant he vanishes. That was his way of leaving.

Where he had vanished, there was nothing at all. Not even footprints.

We looked at that spot for a long time, and then each went back to our own place.

. . .

Two seasons changed after that.

Temel kept going to people. Speon was called the well-keeper. I kept writing.

Then one night, I knew I had reached the last page of my record. I can't explain the reason. I just knew.

I wrote this:

"I close this record here. Temel is Foundation, Speon is Hurrying, I am Remaining. We did not live according to our names. We lived as ourselves. And that life took on, exactly, the same shape as our names."

"Temel knocked, today too, on the door of a house no one else goes to. Speon ran, today too, first of all, to someone who had fallen. I watched them both, today too, and wrote it down. We thought we had learned in five and a half months what should have taken three hundred years. Now I know. We are still learning. This record ending does not mean we end."

. . .

The moment I wrote the last sentence and set down my pen, the edge of the notebook grew warm.

An amber light began to spread from beneath the page. I knew where I had seen it before.

I was not afraid. I smiled.

When the light faded, the notebook was no longer a notebook. It had a thick cover, and on the back cover was a wax seal. It was warm, as if it hadn't dried yet.

I called Arche and asked. "...Can you register this?"

"...That is not possible," Arche said. "Its current location cannot be specified. I am observing both its existence and its absence at the same time."

I laughed, hearing that answer. It was the same as that entry from chapter 45. Classification: unknown. Measurement: not possible.

Temel and Speon heard the commotion and came running. Seeing the sealed book, neither of them could say a word.

"...This is the one we touched first," Temel finally said.

"...That's right," I said.

Speon reached out a hand, then stopped. "...Can I touch it?"

"...You can," I said.

Speon touched the seal with his fingertip. It was warm. Nothing happened. It wasn't the time yet.

"...Good," Speon said, laughing, pulling his hand back. "Because it isn't yet."

Hearing that joke, the three of us laughed together. We were no longer afraid of "Not yet."

. . .

I know where that book will go.

Very far away, a very long time from now, it will stand on some grandfather's bookshelf. He will take it down and read it every day. He will write "Not yet" seventeen times in the margin of Daniel chapter twelve. And someday, before the event has even happened, he will write "It is finished" first.

Then one day, his grandson and the grandson's two friends will open that book. The moment a fingertip touches the seal, a door will open.

I know that door is the same door that brought us to this city. That door was made of the very record we would write. I am not afraid of that circle any longer. I find it beautiful, instead.

. . .

I wrote Daniel 12:4 at the head of the first chapter of this novel. Many shall run to and fro, and knowledge shall be increased.

For a long time I read that verse split in two. The ones who run to and fro, and the one who adds to the knowledge. Now I know. Within a single sentence, the two need each other. If Temel and Speon hadn't run, there would have been nothing to write. If I hadn't written, all that running would have left nothing behind.

And before all that running to and fro, before all that knowledge, there was one who had already finished it. We did not accomplish it. We only lived it out.

. . .

The city goes on.

The well water flowed out across the whole city. The bell tower still rings sometimes for no reason. In the postmistress's drawer, a few letters still sit with the label "Someday." Arche still measures what can be measured, and honestly leaves what cannot be measured as unknown.

And someday, new feet will walk into this ravine. The way Temel's did, the way Speon's did, the way mine did.

The ones who will welcome them then are us, now.

Writing this last page, I think of myself on the day I first fell into this city. Wearing faster feet, knowing nothing, falling as if only to flee. Back then I had no idea how this story would end. Even now, in truth, I don't know everything. But I know one thing. We stayed in the place we had fled to, and in the place where we stayed, we became ourselves.

The book is sealed. But the story is not sealed. Many will still run to and fro, and knowledge will keep increasing. And before all of it, the one who finished it will go on being here, in the place we cannot see.

(The End.)

Loop Chronicles

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